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Happy reading~

Chapter 1

Avino

It was a wonderful night; the bedroom was clad in a warm glow via string lights, and a chorus of crickets and frogs hummed through a cracked window. The air slipping in was cool but not chilly, bringing with it notes of fresh grass and the nearby river.

From his spot on an armchair, a man looked upon his two young sons with a sideways grin. They were bouncing on their beds, whooping as they tossed a pillow back and forth, the atmosphere doing very little to relax them.

Their mother popped into the doorway. "That doesn't look like getting ready for bed, boys," she observed with mock reproof.

The children merely giggled and proceeded to jump about in gleeful protest.

"We're not sleepy!" The ten year old hollered.

"Yeah, we're not sleepy!" The six year old parroted.

"Perhaps you're just needing a good story to wind you down," their father suggested, and the brothers ceased their antics at once.

"Ooh, ooh!"

They nestled into their beds without delay, spurring laughter from both parents.

"Don't keep them up too late, Avino," his wife said. "*Goodnight*, boys."

“Night, Mom!” her children called back.

“Not to worry, it won’t be long,” Avino eased.

His mate smirked at him through amused suspicion before disappearing into the hallway.

“Tell the one about the dragon!” The younger urged.

“No, tell the one about the sphinx you and mom tricked!” The older one said.

The boys were always an eager audience to hear about their adventuring days. However, the father had something else in mind.

He pulled a familiar, lavish tome from the bookshelf next to his chair. “Those are both good stories. But, how about I read you the one about your great, great grandfather?”

Both gasped and agreed with eager cheers.

Avino smiled at their enthusiasm; he was delighted that hearing their family history was still enough to excite them.

He cozied up in the armchair and cracked open the heirloom to a page of embossed, foiled runes. He waved his palm over them, stirring their embedded power with a pulse of his runa. The runes glowed in turn, shimmering with golden light as they awoke.

With a turn of the page, a landscape of sweeping netherstone cliffs shown under an orange sky revealed, joined by woods of Firelarch and Crawling Bramble. In a clearing was a small settlement. However, the image was no mere illustration; it rippled with movement, animated by intricate magic.

Words began to appear, Avino reading them out loud as he had several times before. “Long ago, the Vaaskiir family lived within the netherrealm of Pyroth. We experienced relative peace for such a harsh place, but it was not to last.” The projection shifted into fire and smoke, the town falling into duress. “For our home was attacked.”

“By a big, mean devil!” The smaller child interrupted.

“Karreo, shh!” The eldest shushed.

“Yes, by a big, mean devil called Belthamot.” The page turned and the visage of a she-devil clad in war dress appeared, with her twisted horns and tattered wings. Her tail thrashed like a whip, her red eyes gleaming as she wickedly laughed. “She was a terrible war

lord, even by the standards of the netherrealm. She was relentless and her power only grew with each settlement she took.”

The next page depicted families of demorin fleeing, flames licking at their tails as their home blazed in an inferno behind them. “When she came to our ancestors’ village, their forces were no match for hers; they would be killed or enslaved if they fought back. And so, they had no choice but to run.”

“They were not alone. Belthamot’s scourge had displaced many.” The next scene showed thousands of hellborn massed together in a scorched field. Above the crowd, on a high rock, their leaders were debating heatedly. Then, the chiefs nodded and turned to address the mass. “It was agreed that they could not stay in the war-torn netherrealm. Instead, they would migrate to the Middlerealm: to Azyria.”

The tome showed the refugees banding together, heads bowed and hands linked, a shimmering aura radiating off of them. “But such a plan was no simple task. To travel between the realms would take awesome power, and so they all came together to pool their magic and intent. Through teamwork and sheer will, they were able to open a portal to Azyria, but it would not last for long.”

The next painting was of a wavering rift in the landscape, shuddering with instability, but holding. The hellborn were filing through it hurriedly. “The portal would only remain long enough to get them across once; they left the only home they knew, knowing they would not return.”

The next page had the refugees working together to build a new settlement. “Although from different corners of the netherrealm, they all banded together and forged a new life. Soon, there was a settlement with food, water, shelter, and, most importantly, peace.

“However, not all felt at ease. There was talk that Belthamot would not be satisfied conquering Pyroth, whispers that she would not stop until the Middlerealm was hers, too. They were safe for now, yes, but would it last?”

A demorin with curved ivory horns and yellow irises atop shadowy sclera filled the following page. His skin was a deep red, his hair a midnight black, his expression determined.

“It’s him!” The boys whooped.

“Your great, great grandfather, Vettikus Vaaskiir, did not want to wait and find out. He wanted to fight back against Belthamot’s fury. How many more would have to lose their homes and freedom?”

The page turned, the illustration showing Vettikus leaving the new settlement before shifting into him talking with a stranger. “And so, he went to seek out others who would stand against Belthamot.” The person turned their back on Vettikus, however, to the demorin’s dismay.

Vettikus then was talking to another stranger, and then another, and another, each giving him the same treatment. “He found it was no easy task. Many in Azyria were not used to our kind, and he found most were distrustful or fearful of him. He traveled for weeks, met with nothing but prejudice and distrust. No one would give him an audience, and he was incredibly discouraged. Perhaps it was a mistake to leave—”

“No!” The brothers both rejected.

“Don’t give up, Vettikus!” the eldest cried.

Avino chuckled and ruffled his son’s ebony hair, the tufts catching on the child’s prepubescent horns. “He did not. He kept going, until the most unlikely of folk finally listened to what he had to say.”

The new projection showed two figures standing tall and proud, one male and one female. Atop their heads were glowing halos of light, the woman’s fiery gold and the man’s frozen blue, mirroring the striking color of their eyes. Their flowing hair, orange and blue accordingly, rippled majestically.

“The angels!” Karreo cheered, throwing a clawed fist in the air.

“A pair of celestelles approached Vettikus, curious about his plight. Do you remember their names?”

“Approphas and Kaleena!” the eldest instantly answered, in time with the picture showing the three of them shaking hands.

“Correct, Valen, very good!” Avino praised.

“Not fair! I wanted to say!”

“It’s alright, Karreo, you can answer the next question,” their father eased. “Approphas, an ice celestelle, and Kaleena, a fire celestelle, had heard rumors of Vettikus’ story, and sought him out.

The depiction painted the three of them glancing at each other, expressions suspicious and uncertain. “Vettikus couldn’t help but feel unsure of them, and the feelings were mutual. There is a long, long history of distrust between demorin and celestelles, but that’s a story for another time.”

“But they still helped him, Dad?” Valen remarked.

“That they did. Their goals aligned, as it turned out. The celestelles had heard of Belthamot, too, and shared in the worry that she would not stop at conquering the nether realm.

In fact, there was evidence that Belthamot already had Azyria in her sights, to search for a mythical artifact of unimaginable power.”

The book now showed a towering room with thrones of various heights and grandeur, decorated celestelles of high rank seated atop them. Approphas and Kaleena stood beneath them, bowing. “The Celestine council decided to send Approphas and Kaleena to sort fact from rumor and properly assess the threat. If Belthamot really was after this relic, the angels would stop her.”

The next page showed Vettikus arguing with Approphas and Kaleena, his demeanor determined. “At first, all the two wanted from Vettikus was information, but he would not let them leave him out of the fight.” The duo was shown relenting in the next scene. “And so, an uneasy alliance between demorin and celestelles began.

The book then depicted a lone, tall tower high in the mountains. “The heroes set out to find more information on the relic Belthamot was after, and came into contact with a scholar who specialized in ancient texts.” An elderly human man clad in mystic robes appeared, a twinkle of mischief in his eye.

“Yeah, yeah! Edwin the Sa-sa— sa gey— um....” Karreo couldn’t quite wrap his tongue around the word.

“Edwin the Sagacious.” Avino confirmed with a chuckle. “Using their intel, Edwin deduced the artifact in question: The Hammer of Volkara.”

An antique drawing of the artifact came into view: it was a massive, metal mallet, scored with white-hot molten cracks, as though threatening to erupt. The handle was shimmering volcanic glass, deceptively strong. “Once belonging to an ancient god, the hammer was said to have the power to not only destroy anything, but create, too. Finding it was far from simple, however, if it even still existed at all. Most sources doubted the validity of it, but the trio were determined to find out for sure.”

“Could it really destroy *anything*?” Valen said, his citrine eyes wide with wonder.

“That’s what was said,” Avino answered. “Regardless, they had to find out before Belthamot did; it would be catastrophic if she held such power.”

A map then appeared, the destinations forming the shape of a diamond, the last mark dead in the middle. “Edwin drew out a map that marked five different temples, each one housing a piece of a key that unlocked an ancient vault. Within that vault was said to be the Hammer, but unlocking it was a perilous task, for each fragment was fiercely guarded by a great and powerful beast.

The following painting showed a temple so high in the mountains it rivaled the clouds. "The group set off to the first temple, but what they found there was terrible."

The projection revealed an oversized griffon that lay defeated, its gold and teal plumage bloodied and battered. "The guardian of the first key piece was already defeated; the trio were too late."

"No!" The boys wailed.

"But, not all was lost."

The scene portrayed the three placing their hands on a center monument, the apparatus growing brilliantly. "According to the text of the temple, there was a way to renew the guardian. A spell was engraved into the monument at the heart of the temple, and if activated, would heal the guardian's physical form."

"And so they concentrated their power into completing the ritual and the guardian was healed."

The griffon rose to its feet, all of its power restored and its wounds healed. The three crowded around the beast as it spoke to them. "The guardian introduced himself as Arraelius, a griffon hailing from the heavenly realm of Stellaar. Arraelius explained that Belthamot had indeed attacked his temple, and stolen the fragment. The griffon stressed the importance that the vault remain locked, that the power inside was indeed terrible."

Several beasts of various forms came into view. There was a mighty but agile thunderex with electrified feathers, an armored bludgebear with massive talons, a blazing hellhound with gnashing teeth and, finally, two serpentine dragons of light, gold and silver respectively. "Arraelius could sense that his fellow guardians were in peril, and that two more had already been defeated." The bludgebear and thunderex faded from the roster. "It was now a race against Belthamot to stop her; only 3 guardians remained in her way."

The throne room from before reappeared, the three heroes reporting to the council with intensity. "Everything they feared now confirmed, they reported the news back to the Celestine council. The council recognized the threat, and began to rally their forces. It was too late to prevent Belthamot from getting all of the key pieces, but they could meet Belthamot in battle before she reached the vault."

Vettikus was in front of all the hellborne refugees giving a passionate speech. "Vettikus returned to his new home and beseeched the hellborn to join the fight. While there was suspicion and distrust towards their celestine helpers, many still agreed to help. The power of the angelic army was great, and finally gave them hope of victory."

A demorin and celestelle general were depicted shaking hands in front of their numbers. "Putting aside their differences, the army set off for the vault, but not before stopping at each temple to revive each guardian as they went."

A depiction of each guardian being renewed passed by, before the page turned to reveal the final temple at last. The last of the two guardians, the dragon siblings, were engaging Belthamot's forces at the landing of a multistory door: the vault.

"When they made it to the vault, the draconic twins Drannis and Ifira were locked in combat with Belthamot and her company. An epic retaliation broke out: demorin, ice and fire celestelles, guardians, and devils clashed with everything they had."

The fight flashed by in major strokes, earning the amazement of the young demorin boys.

Then, the trio were shown approaching Belthamot alone, weapons drawn. "Approphas, Kaleena, and Vettikus were to face off with Belthamot herself. It was hard fought, but through determination and bravery, the three were able to best the devil."

A silhouette of the fight played out, Belthamot's head falling from her shoulders via Vettikus's blade.

"Yeah!!" The boys cheered.

"With their leader defeated, Belthamot's forces fell apart. The guardians retrieved their fragments and returned to their temples once more. The United Front had won; all the realms were finally safe from Belthamot's fury."

The next page painted the three bowing in front of the Celestine council, each being presented a medal.

"Approphas, Kaleena, and even Vettikus were recognized by the celestine council for their heroism, bravery and will. It was unheard of for a demorin to receive such an honor. It was truly special, indeed.

"Their job done, Approphas, Kaleena, and Vettikus parted ways, vowing to always be comrades."

"They each returned to their homes, where they began families and went on with their lives, their adventuring days behind them..." A snapshot of each hero with their family showed, and then the illusion on the page slowly began to fade.

Avino's tone trailed off, but still maintained tension, spurring the brothers into sharing a knowing look.

“...Or so they thought.” The projection sprang back to life, revealing an undead Belthamot floating above a group of cloaked followers, a wicked aura distorting the space around her. The figure at the front of the company had the same glow about him, and his sneer was that of Belthamot’s. “Belthamot’s determination was not squashed so easily. Across several years and dark magic, her most loyal followers were able to manifest her essence into a vessel.”

The next scene had the vault’s guardians gathered together, followed by a sample of all three heroes dreaming. “The guardians reached out across the ether, calling the trio back to assist in the fight.” Each was shown to have the same vision of the guardians plea.

The three were now saying goodbye to their families, their children watching them go. “And so, the three left their new lives behind and came together to stop Belthamot yet again. They amassed at the final temple, before Belthamot and her cult had arrived.”

The three heroes were depicted squabbling in the next frame, while the guardians looked on, pensive and quiet.

“Approphas said that they should open the vault and use the power of the Hammer against Belthamot. He argued they could use the relic's power to defeat the devil permanently, then, the hand would be entrusted to the Forerunners, the Celestelle's greatest and oldest council, so that no evil could ever pursue the Hammer again.

“But Vettikus disagreed. He argued that they should open the vault and destroy the Hammer, so that *no one* would ever be able to wield it.

“Kaleena too had her own thoughts. She believed it was not up to them, that the Hammer should remain locked away. To move or destroy the hammer would be defying Volcara and her will.

The guardians looked upon each other, and then left the heroes to talk amongst themselves. “It was decided the guardians would convene to make a decision. The trio were left in wait as their arguments were considered, and that is when Belthamot suddenly descended upon them.”

The next set was of Belthamot cornering Vettikus, who was alone and caught unawares. “The she-devil went after Vettikus first, and he was overwhelmed in the struggle.”

Once again, silhouettes acted out the carnage.

“Nooo!” The children cried.

Approphas ran into the scene right as Vettikus lost the fight. “Approphas had arrived too late, but he would not let Vettikus’ death be in vain. He called over Kaleena, and the two engaged Belthamot, empowered by their grief.”

Events from the battle flashed by rapidly, until finally Belthamot’s vessel laid on the ground, defeated. “Kaleena and Approphas were able to overcome Belthamot at last, and the battle was finally won.

“However, the threat of Belthamot returning yet again was undeniable.”

The two once more stood before the guardians. “Approphas again pushed that the Hammer be taken to the Forerunners, while Kaleena still held firm that it should remain locked away. The guardians heard them out, and when they fell silent, they gave their decision.

“It was true that they could not do the same strategy again and again. However, they also would not unlock the vault, it was out of the question. So, what were they to do?

“Well, the guardians had an idea. The temples and vault were not strong enough as it was, but that could be changed.

On the next page was the vault, Approphas and Kaleena in its shadow. “Through ancient and powerful magic, a blood seal *could* be imposed on the vault. However, the cost would be great.

The two shared a look before brandishing their weapons. Both sliced into their palms before joining each other in hand, their essences combining. Each placed their free hand on the door, awakening the ruins into incandescence. The emblem's intensity grew stronger and stronger still.

“If Approphas and Kaleena performed the spell, it would cost them their mortal lives. However, the seal would be extraordinarily powerful; no one but their bloodline would be able to bypass the lock.

The ritual reached a crescendo, and then there was a final flash of blinding light. “Approphas and Kaleena agreed, knowing that if they didn’t, the cycle would repeat itself.”

When the light faded, the two laid crumpled at the foot of the door, still hand in hand. “They made the ultimate sacrifice and cast the seal on the vault, locking it for good.”

The final page was of Approphas and Kaleena, but they had been transformed. There were wings on their back, and their halos were embellished with a crown of light. “For their noble sacrifice, the Forerunners ascended their immortal souls into Second Angeldom, the highest honor any Celestelle can receive. They watch over their descendents now, ensuring the blood seal remains, and that the realms remain safe.”

The projection faded, leaving the brothers awestruck. Even so, Karreo was already drifting off as Avino tucked in his blanket and kissed his forehead.

However, his older son seemed deep in thought. "Dad, how do we know what happened? I mean, if Vettikus died there...?" Valen asked, gesturing to the book.

The father admired his son's critical thinking. "The guardians reached out across the ether to our family. They told our kin about his sacrifice, and the ultimate fate of the vault. The story has since been passed down each generation, immortalized through this tome. My father read it to me, as did his father. And now, I'm telling the story to both of you."

"...So, the vault is still locked?"

"The blood seal remains, yes," Avino replied. He tucked Valen's blanket over his shoulders and touched his cheek. "Because of Approphas and Kaleena, the world is protected from Belthamot, and any others that would try to take the Hammer."

"Vettikus helped, too," the young demorin inserted, peeking from over the comforter.

Avino flashed a proud smile at that. "Yes, Vettikus helped, too." The father kissed his child's forehead and took his leave, sparing one last look before clicking the door closed. "Goodnight."

Chapter 2

Stella

The sun crept down the horizon's edge, searing the skyline in stunning shades of orange and violet. A woman beheld the sunset from a balcony of polished stone, the beauty of it lost on her. Her spirit was too uneasy, her mind too pensive.

A constant gust pulled at her brilliant red hair, the highlights of orange and gold flickering like fire in the wind. Her halo glowed in the twilight, a faint animation of dancing flame playing upon its edge.

"You seem troubled," A gentle voice observed from the bedroom. "Are you alright?"

The woman released a breath she hadn't realized she was holding. She considered disguising her melancholy, but landed upon transparency. After all, her husband was not one of the prying elders, or a concerned colonist. If she could not be vulnerable with her mate, who else could she open up to?

Even still, she remained quiet, her words ensnared within a gnarled mess of rumination.

Her partner joined her on the balcony and wrapped his arms around her, strong and gentle. "What's on your mind, Stella?"

Her nightmare struck her psyche like lightning, and her hand grasped at the pendant around her neck as the thunder rolled. The ornate metal was smoldering underneath her palm, as though magma was pooling under the surface.

"I..." Stella attempted to start, but the rest didn't follow.

"...Is it the nightmares?"

Stella was not prepared for him to guess so effortlessly. She spun to face her mate, her mouth agape. "How... did you know?"

"You're my wife, Stella." Emmet cupped her cheek. "I can tell these things."

Stella broke eye contact to stare out into the distance, the amber fire in her eyes flickering. "I said I do not remember them... But that... was not the truth."

Emmet stayed quiet, listening intently.

Stella overcame the last of her hesitation with a sigh. "In my dreams... I am high above the Boulder, gazing down at Cloudtouch. The air is fresh and the sky is bright, and I feel..." She searched for the word. "...Satisfied. Proud."

"But then, as I'm looking down at the town, this.... Creeping sensation prickles down my spine. Uncertainty. Apprehension. ...Shame.

"I blink and there are suddenly clouds circling overhead, and the air becomes thick and oppressive. The world is cast into darkness as a monstrous wind howls, and the Boulder starts to tilt and groan like a ship rocked by a storm.

"I look to the Central Tower just as white-hot cracks erupt down the middle, splitting it into rubble. Lava belches out as the fissures reach into the earth, splitting the land open. The town is sucked into the chasm, drowned by liquid flame, and then the Boulder itself starts to fall.

"I am being dragged along with it, my flesh is burning and the wind is so, so loud in my ears. Even still, I can hear everyone shouting as we all careen down to the world below, into the waiting sea. I always wake up right before we hit the water, and the necklace is always boiling hot on my neck. Even now, it smolders..."

She grabbed her husband's hand and wrapped it around the pendant. "Tell me, do you feel it, too?"

Emmet studied the necklace with a somber look before gingerly taking back his hand. "It's... cold."

Stella was not surprised. "The dream teller said the same."

"...And what did he have to say about the dream?" Emmet's gloomy look kept.

"He says I am not the first to have this vision." The image of their home falling from the clouds in a fiery splendor ricocheted in her mind's eye. "But... the intensity and frequency is unlike my mothers before me." She winced against the weight of that shame. "It must be an omen of my failures."

Emmet grabbed her shoulders. "Stella, you have done everything in your power for this order, and Cloutouch is a better place for it. You have sacrificed *so much*. What failures could you even mean?"

A wry grin tugged at the corners of her lips. "The elders would say our marriage, for one."

Emmet shook his head at that. "You had every right to choose, there was no law forbidding it."

"They yet they have never forgiven me for rejecting my betrothed... Every decision I've made, every order, called into question..."

"That says more about the elders' failures than yours," Emmet pressed. "Perhaps this is a warning for *them*."

Stella leaned against the railing with a sigh. "As leader of this Order, it is my responsibility, regardless."

"But you are not alone in this," Emmet assured. He once again brought her into his arms and placed his forehead against hers, their halos intersecting like planetary rings. "Remember, we are a team, you mustn't struggle on your own."

A sad smile bubbled to the surface at that. "It's true. But what about when you leave tomorrow?" Visions of a different life flashed by, before the reality of her position was a burden she accepted. *'I wish I could just leave this place! Can't you take me?'* a younger Stella begged a younger Emmet.

"Oh, Stella..." both present and younger Emmet sighed. "Please understand, I would love to take you..."

Stella's defeated smile spread wider as she once again gripped the pendant around her neck. *"The power of the seal survives through us,"* her mother's lecture echoed in her memory. *'As Kaleena's kin, it is our duty to remain here and protect it. The blood seal must never fail. You understand that, don't you?'*

"I understand..." Stella muttered out loud, the flame in her eyes flickering weakly. She cupped her husband's cheeks and pecked their lips together before flashing the same glum smile. "I'll just continue to see the world through you... vicariously."

"And that is what makes you an incredible leader," her husband admired.

Stella shook her head. "There wasn't ever a choice, Emmet. Can I really take credit for merely doing my duty?"

"When so much is asked of you, yes," Emmet insisted. "I... wish things were different."

"Do not," Stella encouraged. "It is a great honor to bear the seal."

"As it is a great honor to serve and protect you, my Star."

They were in the middle of another embrace when rapidly approaching footsteps sounded.

"Daddy, please don't leave tomorrow!" A young girl with the same vermillion hair crashed into their huddle. An identical pair of fiery amber eyes peered up at Emmet, quivering with tears.

Emmet kneeled down so he was eye level with their daughter. "Cece, you know I have to."

"It's not fair!" The child stomped her foot in teary protest before looking to her mother. "Can't you just order someone else to go?"

Stella crouched down, too, a small smirk threatening to break at her daughter's display. "Celine, your father is the best ranger we have. The Order needs him to do his job."

"But we need him here!" Celine whined, unsatisfied.

"I promise to bring you something from the outside," Emmet attempted to ease. He tucked a strand of her orange curls behind her ear. "It's only a week, Cece. You'll barely notice I'm gone."

"Yes I will!" the five year old cried. "Please don't go, Daddy!"

"Celine, it is his duty," Stella said, a tad firmer. "He must do his part for the Order."

"Your mother is right, Starfire," Emmet settled. "The town is in need of supplies, and if I don't go, we won't get what we need. Everyone is counting on me."

Celine rubbed at her wet eyes, sniffing in defeat. "O-okay..." her little voice croaked.

Emmet kissed her forehead. "That's my girl." He stood and kissed his wife the same. "You'll both be alright. The Order will take care of you."

"As is *their* duty," Stella agreed. She scooped up her daughter and Celine snuggled into her with a snuffle. "Everyone has their part to play, Celine."

"...Then what do I do?" Celine wondered.

Apprehension clenched Stella's throat as she remembered asking her own mother the same question. Hundreds of lectures replayed over in an instant, blurring into a cacophony.

She managed to stifle her consternation. "Your job is the most important one of all, my daughter."

Celine lifted her head from her mother's chest in anticipation, her golden eyes wide and twinkling.

"Your job..." Stella touched her daughter's nose and offered her a bittersweet grin. "...Is to remain safe, well, and *happy*, my Star."

Chapter 3

Abram

A constant howling of turbulent wind and frozen rain rattled against the manor's walls, but it was of no consequence to the man laboring in his study. His attention instead was on

documents laid out in front of him. He worked efficiently, his lips pulled thin with concentration and his icy stare focused.

The door creaking open was an unwelcome threat to his workflow. "Leave me be," he mumbled without looking up.

"Forgive the intrusion, Abram Sir," his butler intruded anyway.

"Ugh, what is it?" Abram's tone was curt as he forced his attention away from his work.

"It's the young master," the servant said from the doorway. "The storm has him a bit... frazzled."

Abram growled and pinched the bridge of his angular nose, a strand of his long slate-blue hair falling into his face. "Surely you've sent him company?"

"Well, ah, that's the thing, Abram Sir," the butler explained. "He's asking for... you."

Abram closed his eyes and sat there for a long second. Then, with an exasperated sigh, he stood.

He made his way down the halls of the manor, towering portraits of their stupendous lineage flanking him as he went. He arrived at his spot on the wall, and he had the mind to stop and reflect.

There was a painting of him at every major stage thus far in his life, followed by a depiction of a beautiful woman. She was dressed in a wedding gown of shining silver, adorned in jewelry with intricate, frozen motifs.

The dress complemented the teal of her lustrous hair, and her striking blue eyes mirrored that of her halo. She was tenderly smiling, a contrast to the other portraits that oppressed the halls.

The next painting depicted the two of them together, her influence having relaxed the intensity in Abram's eyes. The next was a maternity shot of his wife, her same gentle smile glinting with pride, but that was where the happiness ended.

For next in line was a vacant frame on the wall, where a family portrait should have been.

Grief constricted him as he gazed upon the empty frame, but the following picture transmuted hurt into bitterness. Abram glowered at his heir's newborn portrait, the injustice of it all seething within him.

The next painting showed the boy grown into a young child, but Abram did not even allot it a glance. He stormed on until he arrived at his heir's room.

When he opened the door, he spotted several servants crowded around the child's bed. They bowed at his arrival and he excused them with a hand wave, to which they hurriedly removed themselves.

There was an offering of cheap comforts on the nightstand: a teddy bear, a sweet scone, a musical toy, a glass of warm milk... The father sneered and shook his head; how could the welp still be needing more?

Said welp was shuddering underneath his blanket, whimpering.

"There is no reason to be afraid," Abram said. "Saulivan, come out from there."

Saulivan emerged from his fearful cocoon, his flushed face smeared with tears and his blue hair mussed. "Papa!" The five year old reached for his father, but Abram did not go to him.

"This storm is our element. To fear it is to fear your own heritage," his father went on coolly.

"B-but-" The child shivered. "It's so loud! I-It's shaking the house! It's--"

"This manor has withstood far worse storms, boy," the parent interjected. "And there will be far worse storms yet. Don't hide underneath your covers. It is unbecoming."

A particularly forceful gust wailed and forced a tree branch against the window, its crystalized bark scraping against the glass. Saulivan yelped and retreated under his blanket yet again, spurring a scoff from his father.

"It is just ice and wind, Saul. Stop this cowering."

Saul did not budge, and Abram scrunched his features in irritation. *'Talia, this should have been your responsibility. How can this be expected of me?'*

The father sat down on the bed and removed the blanket from his child. Saul dove and clung onto Abram at that, the boy's cerulean eyes pleading. "P-Papa," he blubbered, "please stay here!"

"I have work to do, Saul," he shot down. "Look around, do you already not have what you need?! I cannot waste my time *codling* you." He shrugged the child off, Saul sobbing at the refusal.

"Papa, please!"

“No, Saulivan.” The father drug the boy out of a crumpled ball and back into the correct position. He methodically laid the blanket so it was properly covering him. “You will never become the strong celestelle Frostreach needs if this keeps up.”

Saul hiccuped and quivered as the storm outside surged on, but he did stray from his father’s rearranging.

Satisfied, Abram stood from the bed and stiffly left the room. He lingered in the doorway before giving his weeping child one last word of advice. “Conquer your storm, or let it conquer you.”

Saul only bawled in response, and as Abram watched the display, he could imagine the disdain Approphas had for his house in its present state.

He shut the door with bleak reckoning. ‘No wonder he has forsaken us.’

[Note: Stella and Abram’s stories WILL be part of this book, but I’ve been focusing on one arc at a time for now. Thus, the following chapters don’t deal with their stories, as of now, sorry!]

Chapter 4

Avino

There was a knock at the front door. The demorin glanced up from his book with a quizzical stare, as they weren’t expecting any guests.

He adjusted his collar and removed his reading glasses before standing to answer the door. A stranger was there to greet him, clad in a sharp suit. Avino was surprised to see it was a fellow demorin with ram-like horns and burnt orange skin.

“Hello, I hope I’m not intruding too much on your evening, sir,” the man began with a velvety voice. “Could I borrow a couple minutes of your time, perchance?”

Avino fidgeted with his cuffs as he weighed the situation. There wasn’t harm in entertaining a solicitor for a minute or two. “Of course, how can I help you?”

“Ah, it is actually me who is here to help you,” the man replied. “But, let’s not get too ahead of ourselves. My name is Thadius Ives, and I represent an organization that fights for and protects Pyrothian kind.”

A pamphlet manifested in his hands via a puff of magic and he offered it to Avino, who gingerly received it. The cover depicted the silhouette of a horned figure with their fist in the air, text above them reading ‘The Clawed Fist’, ‘Watcher of the Scorned’.

“We are the Clawed Fist,” the man, Thadius, said. “We are here to assist you and any family in whatever struggles you are endeavoring.”

Avino was immediately skeptical, as he was no stranger to guilds and their ceaseless appetite for donations and dues. “I’m sorry, but I’m not interested.”

Thadius smiled at his refusal. “Oh? Why is that? Is it because you anticipate fees? Or perhaps you think yourself capable of handling hardship on your own?”

Avino’s expression narrowed, unimpressed with the solicitor’s accuracy. “We aren’t in need of the service you’re offering, is all.”

“We? So you *do* have a family?” Thadius surmised, his eyes flickering to the room beyond Avino. “You’ve been able to support them fine, keep them safe?”

Avino was unsettled as a check in his gut rippled. “Of course. Why wouldn’t I?”

“Well, this world can be awfully cruel to our kind,” Thadius elaborated. “Prejudice, financial hardships, and under-representation are just the tip of the list. We are here to help ease your burden, and fight for justice for our kin.”

The cause sounded noble enough, however... “And what do you get in return, then?”

“We do not expect any compensation; think of us as a charity of sorts. But, if you were to be grateful for our service, or wanted to help other struggling demorin, donations are how we do what we do!”

Avino processed that with a slow nod. “Well, while that all sounds great, we’re not in need of any assistance. This town has been good to our family.”

It was no fib, but that had not always been the case. When Vivianna and he had first moved to Riverview years before, there had been some hiccups, surely, but since then the town had come around.

“How fortunate for you. Many are not so lucky,” Thadius replied, ever smiling. “Even still, I reach out my hand to you. Please, take it if you ever need it.”

The fellow demorin handed over a card, and Avino took it to be polite.

“Um, thank you, Thadius.”

“Please, call me Thad!” Thad urged. “And what shall I call you?”

“Ah, Avino. Avino Vaaskiir.”

The men shook hands.

Thad dipped his head with a nod that suggested the encounter was coming to an end, to Avino’s relief. “Well, I must be off, then. I wish you good fortune, Avino. Please, do not hesitate to contact me if you ever need anything.”

Avino didn’t think he would, but he still offered the solicitor a nod. “Of course.”

The other demorin waved goodbye and set back down the steps, Avino watching him go before slowly closing the door. He spared the business card and pamphlet a fleeting glance before casting them into the spam pile.

He dismissed the oddity of the meeting with a shake of his head and returned to his book.

It had been a week or so since that encounter when something foreboding happened.

Avino at last arrived on his doorstep, weary as he fiddled with his keys. He unlocked the door and stepped inside, longing to leave the stress of the day on the other side of the threshold.

He announced his presence with a sigh of relief. “Vivie, I’m finally home.”

“Down here, love! I’ll be up in a few!” His wife called out from the basement.

The demorin hung his satchel and coat and nervously adjusted the collar of his pressed shirt. He smoothed his burgundy vest, his ears perked for either of his children, but the house was silent.

It was enough to worry him after the day he’d had. “Where are the boys?”

“They’re just down by the river. I sent them to collect rocks for the new planters,” his mate dispelled his anxiety.

“Oh, alright.” Apprehension still gnawed at him. “Nothing strange has happened today, right?”

“No...? Look, we’ll talk when I come upstairs, alright? Give me a minute.” There was no urgency in her tone, and so he allowed himself the grace to relax.

He headed for the bathroom; it would do him good to wash up.

He shut the door and braced his palms on the sink. He studied his reflection in the mirror, a portrait of his unease staring back at him.

His typically neat black hair was caught on his horns, a symptom from nervously running his hands there earlier. His normally rich red skin was paler than he’d like, and his topaz eyes were dull with tension.

His pointed ears sank and his tail slumped; it was not like him to be so unkempt.

He turned the tap and filled his hands with cold water before splashing his face, gasping at the chill. He scrubbed thoroughly, hoping to scour free some of the strain.

When he exited the bathroom, he could hear his mate rustling about in the kitchen. “The stew you put on this morning tastes ready!”

He thanked his foresight in preparing dinner before he left for the day; at least that was one less stress to fuss over.

He walked into the kitchen, finding his wife ladling soup into a bowl from the slow cooker. She greeted him with a smile, only for it to drop upon realizing his demeanor. “Long day?”

Avino pursed his lips and his brow scrunched with consideration on how to begin. “It was... troubling.”

Vivianna handed him his bowl and sat down with her own, gesturing to the chair across from her. “Do tell.”

Avino took a seat and pushed his stew around the bowl, steam wafting into his face. “There was... some graffiti on the shop when I went in today.”

Vivianna’s garnet eyes squinted incredulously. “Graffiti?! What do you mean?”

“There was writing all over the window and doors... calling us ‘hellspawn’, ‘demon freaks’, ‘devil bootlicker’...” He trailed off, a bad taste in his mouth from recounting such insults.

Vivie bristled instantly. "You're kidding...!"

Avino's jaw clenched with unease. "Unfortunately not..."

Vivianna's ebony curls shook as she grew more and more agitated. "This is ridiculous! Did you report it?!"

"I went to the station right when I found it. They documented it, and told me it would be under investigation."

They both sat in silence, solemn, their soup growing cold.

"It's... definitely unusual," Avino broke the quiet. "Nothing like this has happened since we moved here... and that was years ago."

"I figured everyone had come around..." Vivianna's initial anger boiled off, leaving behind hurt.

Avino draped his hand over hers, offering a tender squeeze. "I know, Vivie... But we can't let one or two buffoons get to us. Riverview has been good to our family."

His partner took a moment, but did ultimately nod. "I know, hun... It just... makes you wonder."

Avino's thoughts trailed to the pile of spam by the front door, and the business card buried there. He'd told his wife about the solicitor the day it happened, both of them finding the proposition ridiculous. It was ironic and humbling to have that assessment called into question, but Avino was sure the police would get to the bottom of it all.

The cellar door crashing open downstairs made them both jump. Familiar laughter and chattering had them both sighing in relief.

"I got more than you!" They heard Karreo boast from the basement.

"Ha, I see that! Great job, Karri!" Valen praised. "Let's get cleaned up; I don't think Mom will be happy if we track all this mud inside."

"Correct," Vivie called out, smirking despite herself. Avino spared a chuckle, too.

"There's stew waiting for you after you're done," the father said. "Then, we need to have a family meeting."

Valen

Morning came entirely too early the next day. The fifteen-year-old attempted to force himself awake, a yawn splitting his mouth as he stretched, but his eyes were too heavy to keep open. He was normally not one to feel so sluggish at the start of the day, but the prior night had held him captive with worry.

He had stared up at the ceiling for hours, tossing and turning, his mind tirelessly replaying the earlier conversation. It wasn't the family meeting that had perturbed him so, at least not immediately. They were told their father found something troubling at work, and to tell one of them immediately if someone treated them poorly or differently. All in all, it was unnerving, certainly, but not drastically so.

That was until his father pulled him aside after Karreo had been tucked into bed.

"Son, don't tell your brother this, as I don't want him to be afraid," his father had said. "But this was actually a pretty serious crime"

What followed was a much less watered down version of events, including a reveal that his parent's start in Riverview had been rockier than Valen ever realized.

"I'm not sure what happened to bring this out again," his father had said. "But, law enforcement is involved, and we'll get to the bottom of it."

Cue a disturbed night of sleep, and morning's curt arrival. Valen groaned, rubbing his bleary eyes, heavily considering if magic lessons were *really* that important today.

"You're not up yet?" his little brother's question came from the foot of the bed. "Whoa, you look terrible!"

Valen scoffed in good humor and managed to keep his eyes open long enough to squint at his sibling. "Gee, thanks, Karri." He yawned yet again. "I was... up late reading."

"...Uh, aren't you supposed to be leaving soon? It's almost eight o'clock..."

The tiredness evaporated off of Valen in an instant; he leapt out of bed without so much as another blink. Magic lessons really were that important, afterall.

A quick sniff at himself insisted he needed a shower, to his detriment. He bathed in record time, still dripping as he hastily dressed himself in one of his father's custom made outfits. He buttoned his shirt and combed his wavy, damp hair, lamenting that it would have to forgo being styled.

He nearly forgot to brush his fangs and tie his shoes, but he managed to get out the door at 7:55 sharp.

He scurried to the bus stop down the road, his tail swishing behind him as he ran.

“Valen!” Karreo hollered from the top of the hill. “You forgot your satchel!”

The teenager winced, acutely aware he had no time to spare. He turned around and saw his brother waving said satchel in the air. “Throw it!”

“...What?” The eleven year old shouted incredulously.

“*Throw it!*” Valen could hear the grumbling of the bus approaching.

Karreo resisted for another moment before doing what he was told, the bag flailing into the air with not near enough momentum to carry it the entire way.

That was, until Valen muttered a quick incantation. The bag jerked forward against physics and jetted down the hill, right into Valen’s waiting hand.

“Thanks, Karreo!” the demorin said, just as the bus came around the bend and hissed to a stop. Valen stepped inside, dropped in his coins, and plopped into a seat, a tiny, relieved laugh slipping. He could hardly believe it, but he had made it.

—

Chapter 5

Valen

Whisperwood Library was modestly filled with a patron or two when Valen walked into the doors. Mr. Dayas was at the front counter, peering through dense spectacles as he organized a stack of books. His lengthy, silver hair was smoothly tied back in a ponytail, and his bespoke slate-gray suit was embroidered with a shiny, white thread. The librarian’s somewhat lavish appearance contrasted with the rest of the building, which was a tad run down and declaring its age as no secret. Wallpaper peeled from the walls, most shelves had a slant in them, and the furniture of the place smelt of dust and rotting paper.

As Valen approached, the eln’s elongated ears perked and his teacher welcomed him with a tight grin. “Ah, there’s my young protege,”

“Hello, Mr. Dayas,” Valen greeted, polite as ever. “How are you today?”

“Just fine, thank you,” his teacher replied. He gestured towards his office and they headed inside. “What have you got for me?”

Valen handed over his homework as the two took their seat, Mr. Dayas at his desk and Valen in a chair at the front of it.

The eln thumbed through Valen’s papers, fast but thorough as he scanned the assignment.

The teenager’s nerves fluttered despite his near-certainty that he had done the work properly.

“Well well, my boy, everything looks correct,” Mr. Dayas said at last, straightening the stack of papers against the desk with a tap. He adjusted his spectacles and smirked at his student, expectant. “Let’s see a practical demonstration then, hm?”

Valen smiled at the chance to prove his skills. “Well, alright, Mr. Dayas!” His peripherals found the picture-windows on the far wall and he invoked an incantation. The ruckus of a marching band suddenly blared outside, noisy as can be. “But it’s a little hard to concentrate with all that noise!”

His tutor turned to look outside, but there was no such ensemble there. The disturbance rattled on before Valen willed it into fading, his teacher snorting with amusement.

“Very good! What else have you got for me?”

Valen muttered a string of cue words on his breath, and a delightful aroma of freshly baked cookies wafted into the room. “I would love to show you, Mr. Dayas. But, first, what are you baking? It smells wonderful!”

His teacher sucked in the illusion with a wistful inhale. “If only! Ha, one last spell and you pass.”

“Will do! But... I have to ask first.”

“Hm?”

“Are you feeling alright? You’re looking a little... green.”

Mr. Dayas lifted an eyebrow before gandering down at his once purple hand, the color seemingly green. He looked to a mirror on the wall and chortled upon seeing his freshly renovated reflection.

"Very good, Valen!" The eln approved. "Very good, indeed!"

Valen dismissed the spell, the green fading back into lavender. "It was a nice look, but purple is definitely your color," he quipped.

"You're a cheeky one!" Mr. Dayas wagged a finger at him. "You grasped those illusion spells quite easily, didn't you?"

Valen's chest puffed with pride. "Well, a lot of this lesson I could already do naturally, it's just the book explained *how* I do it."

"Ah, yes, that's no surprise with your heritage. Many spells come to you naturally, hm?"

The demorin nodded.

The eln retrieved some paperwork from a drawer and glanced over it. "What training have you had again?"

"My father taught me to control some innate cantrips while growing up," Valen answered. "But, he didn't start officially training me until I got my permit when I turned 10."

"So why the change in teacher?"

"Well, my Dad felt I could use more dedicated training to take my skills to the next level."

"Ah, right then. Well, seeing what you've done these last couple weeks, I think you're more than ready for that. It's time you had a challenge, hm?"

Valen leaned forward in anticipation. "I would like that, Mr. Dayas!"

His teacher stood and motioned towards the door. "Very well then, my boy. Come with me." They traveled down the hall, the lights buzzing faintly as they went.

"How are you with decompiling runes?" Mr. Dayas inquired en route.

"Uh, alright!" Valen replied with a sprinkle of uncertainty. "I've had a little experience, but not a lot."

"Well, this will be a good exercise for you, then!"

They entered a room packed with glass cases, each overstuffed with knickknacks of every kind. Sculptures, vases, candles, cutlery, pouches, boxes, frames—

"Oh, wow-!" Valen stammered.

His teacher presented the room with a sweep of his palm. "Here is just a small sample of Whisperwood's curios collection." The eln clapped his hands together. "Now, what jumps out at you?"

Valen was overwhelmed by the question. He scanned the room, countless objects competing for his attention. There were also mugs, clocks, pots, brushes, and the list went on even still. "Uuuh..."

"Just pick one, my boy!"

Valen forced himself to do just that. He decided upon an oil rubbed spyglass with a point of his claw. "How about that one?"

"Ah, good choice!" Mr. Dayas unlocked the case and retrieved the antique before handing it over, Valen receiving it gingerly.

"Now, for today's lesson," his teacher said. "You are to decompile the enchantment and identify the spell to the best of your ability. Let's see how you do, hm?"

- - -

Valen plopped down into a diner booth, relieved it was finally lunch time. His stomach had not been shy in reminding him that he skipped breakfast, thus magic class had passed by to the gurgled tune of a lamenting belly.

Even so, the remainder of his lesson had gone well enough, if a bit sideways at times. Decompiling the runes proved to be tricky, as the cell containing the enchantment had refused to budge despite the multiple rucanic pulses Valen had sent into the spyglass.

"Sometimes it takes a bit of... elbow grease, we'll say. Especially with these old trinkets," Mr. Dayas had encouraged him. "Go on, really give it a zap."

"If you say so..." He had directed his runa into a more forceful shock and the seal finally folded, but it came at the cost of duress. The spyglass had shuddered and creaked as the runes decompiled into the air around it, as though they'd been violently wrung out.

Valen was mortified, convinced he'd broken it. "I'm so sorry—"

Mr. Dayas had only chortled at the display. "It's alright, lad. It's still in one piece! Perhaps just be a *tad* gentler next time, ho ho!"

Next came spell identification, which proved a challenging puzzle as the syntax was unfamiliar to him. The demorin was used to his father's methods of spell formulation, but the

change in caster was a welcome deviation. If he was to be a mage worth his salt, assessing different spellcasters styles would be a fundamental skill.

“The spell is... of the extrasensory school,” he had deduced, but further study went into piecing together the full picture. “Wait, there’s some illusion here too.”

As he thumbed through the spell, he stumbled into a large compendium of data, Valen stunned at the amount. He scrolled and scrolled through a never-ending list of... creatures and their descriptions? “It’s got like... an entire bestiary in here!”

It all clicked into place at that. “Oh, I see! When you point the spyglass at a creature, an overlay of information appears. It shows you what you’re looking at, in short.”

Mr. Dayas was shaking his head and grinning, as though in disbelief. “Very good, Valen. Very good!”

His teacher had recompiled the enchantment, the runes collapsing back into the symbol on the side of the spyglass. The eln then offered it back to his student. “Here, this is yours to keep now.”

Valen had been stunned. “Wh- Are you sure, Mr. Dayas? I can’t—”

“Take it, study it, *learn* from it. It will do you *much* better than these dusty cabinets, anyway!”

Therefore, the spyglass now sat strapped upon his belt, nestled inside a leather sheath.

“Hey there, hon!” A warm voice greeted. A middle aged terran woman approached the booth, her waist-long sideburns braided and embellished with rhinestones. Her coarse, wavy hair was held back with a bandana, and her wide stature was curvy.

Valen met his old friend with matching warmth. “Hello, Mrs. Ponto! How are you?”

“Oh, you know, hon, busy as usual.” She gestured around the diner, a good portion of the seats filled. “But I can’t complain! Keeps a roof over me and the missus!”

Valen chuckled. “Yeah, I don’t think you’re going out of business any time soon.”

“Isn’t that the truth? I tell you, there’s been so many new faces here lately!”

What would usually be an interesting talking point instead conjured prickles of anxiety. He maintained his smile, regardless. “Oh yeah?” He gazed around the restaurant, scared he would catch some ill-intending stranger glaring at him, but no one fit the description.

“Mmhm! Riverview is finally on the map, it seems.” She pulled out a notepad from her apron and tapped it with a pen. “Anyhow! What can I get you, sweetie?”

“I’ll just take whatever the lunch special is and a cream soda,” the teenager replied. “Same as usual.”

She winked at him knowingly. “One of these days we’ll have to make it something outlandish and surprise you.”

Valen laughed. “That works for me!”

The terran chuckled to herself as she walked off. “It’ll be out in a few, hon.”

—

Lunch was far from outlandish: merely a grilled salmon sandwich, but a scrumptious one at that. The rustic bread was crisply delightful, and the salmon was impeccably seasoned. Such was the expectation of the Skipping Rock; Mrs. Panto was a very talented baker, and her wife was an equally matched chef. They made a dynamic team, thus their diner was a staple of the town.

Valen had one more stop to make before heading back home for the day. He made his way down Main Street towards Old Trader Plaza. When he arrived, he found the place bustling with patrons.

The same nervousness from before bristled at so many people. Could someone be judging him from the depths of the crowd, hateful enough to lash out? He sucked in a breath and stuffed paranoia down enough to make his way through the bustle.

His destination came into view: Thickett’s Peach Patch. A human teenage girl with chestnut hair and honey eyes was restocking the cart with their namesake: fresh peaches.

The demorin stole a moment to stare, his heart in a patter. She was catching his attention in a way she never had before; she had evidently grown into a young lady in her time away.

He attempted to close the distance between himself and the cart, but found nerves putting rocks in his shoes. He shook them out, feeling silly. *‘It’s not like she’s a different person!’*

When he arrived, the girl spun to welcome him with her best service voice.

“Hello, how may I—” Her speal cut off upon realizing who she was talking to. “Valen!” She squealed with delight, shooting forward to throw her arms around him.

His cheeks flared at her closeness, but he was happy to return the embrace, albeit a tad self-conscious of his hands. "Long time no see, Sienna!"

"It's so good to see you!" Sienna gushed as she broke the hug. "Wow, you've gotten so tall!"

She looked him over, Valen suddenly remembering his lack of hair styling that morning with a deepening blush. He ran a hand through his charcoal locks in attempted nonchalance.

"You too!" the demorin said, the words coming out more awkward than he would have liked. "I mean, you've grown too! I mean- you look so different!" He proceeded to flounder.

She giggled at his struggle. "Different is good, I hope?"

"Of course!" Valen sputtered, scratching an itch that burned on the back of his neck. "It's great, you're great." *'Wow, Val, way to nail the reunion.'*

"Hehe! You're great, too," she replied, her olive skin deepening with a blush of her own.

Valen's heart fluttered at that; he somehow hadn't completely fumbled the situation, after all.

"Ugh, *you* again," a cranky, elderly woman interrupted. She sneered at the demorin, seemingly displeased at the sight of him.

Valen mustered his most charming smile at his admirer, amused at her reluctance. "Hello again, Mrs. Thickett!"

"Grandma, don't be so mean," Sienna giggled. "If it weren't for Valen, who would buy most of our stock?"

The woman scoffed with a shake of her head. "Well, if you're buying something, make it quick. She's got work to do, can't be yapping with you all afternoon."

"Of course, Mrs. Thickett," Valen eased. "I'll take a dozen."

Sienna got to work bagging his order and Mrs. Thickett went to stand on the opposite end of the cart, grimacing.

"Sorry about her," Sienna whispered as she worked.

"I know she's happy to see me," Valen chuckled. Him and Mrs. Thickett had known each other since he was small; Thickett's Peach Patch had always been a staple of his summers.

Then, a couple years back, her granddaughter began to accompany her when she came into town, and Sienna became a part of the season, too.

The two became fast friends, their days spent playing in the river, foraging for wild berries, catching frogs, and more. This year, now that she was older, Sienna's schedule involved working at the cart, but that didn't mean their rendezvous had to end. It would just have to be after the plaza closed, in the evening...

Sienna handed over the paper bag of produce. "I hope Karreo likes these. Tell him I said 'hi'!"

"Come tell him yourself," Valen urged. "You should come over for dinner after you close!"

"Oh!" Sienna said, blinking. "You're sure?"

"Of course," Valen assured instantly. "My family would love to see you! How about tonight at six? Your Mom should come, too!"

It appeared it was Sienna's turn to be embarrassed. "Oh, right, yes!" She laughed and it struck Valen as a tad nervous. "I'll—we'll be there!"

—

Chapter 6

Valen

Valen obsessively adjusted his hair to the left, no, the right, utterly unsatisfied with his appearance. Everything he did made him look silly or weird or--

"You've been brushing your hair for like, hours," His younger brother exaggerated. "Come on, let's go play something."

The teenager shook his head. "I'm gonna be helping with dinner, remember? Why don't you help too?"

"Eh," Karreo shrugged, unconvinced.

"Suit yourself," Valen said with his own shrug. He went back to preening, Karreo leaving with a little huff.

At least coordinating his outfit had gone quicker. His cream dress shirt was now joined by an emerald vest, complete with suspenders. The green did well to contrast his red skin, or so he hoped.

His mother eventually popped into his open doorway with a quick knock. She leaned against the frame, smirking with far more understanding than Karreo had. "You're looking quite snazzy, Valen."

The young demorin pulled his eyes off the mirror to glance towards his mother, embarrassment flaring at the way she knowingly grinned. It was easier to go back to focusing on his reflection. "Aheh, thanks..."

She came up next to him and they stared into the mirror together. She was shorter than him, and his horns were gaining in size. Valen mainly took after his father in genetics, but there were whispers of his mother's burgundy skin and curly hair still. Therefore, he was a tinge more purple than his father and brother, and he had waves in his hair compared to their straight.

"Oh, look at you..." She wrapped an arm around him in a side hug and squeezed. Her lips pursed and her brow wrinkled, tears threatening. "You're really growing up... You're a young man now."

He gently grinned at his mother, flattered but a tinge embarrassed.

She pulled his cheek down for a kiss and ran a hand through the hairdo he'd been trying so hard on. "I'm so proud of you."

Valen giggled as he pulled away, but when he went to fix the damage, he actually found he liked his mother's contribution. "Thanks, Mom..."

—

Dinner was to be alfredo pasta with pan-seared chicken, one of many dishes Valen loved to prepare. He had always enjoyed shadowing his parents in the kitchen, thus he had quite the knack for meal preparation. It was one of his favorite hobbies; to cook was to create art that you not only admired, but could eat.

His father and he prepared dinner in good spirits, despite the tension of the night before. Valen shared how his magic lesson had gone, his parent bright with pride at the report. Karreo had poked in at mention of the spyglass, and Valen promised his brother time to play with it if he helped chop peaches for the tart they were also making.

It was a deal; his little sibling labored over the produce, his tongue out in concentration, Valen only spotting him sneak a slice or two.

Before long it was nearing six o'clock. His mother finished chopping a garden salad before topping it with nuts and feta, while Valen placed the peach tart into the oven. His father put a lid on the chicken alfredo to keep it warm, and his little brother set the table. Everything was ready, now they just needed their guests.

They were not to wait long, as a knock sounded at the door.

Valen hurried to the entryway. "I'll get it!" He realized he was a tinge sweaty; perhaps the kitchen had grown hot from the oven...

He adjusted his hair one last time before opening the door, his heart in a gallop.

Sienna was standing there alone, Valen's breath catching at the sight of her. There was a scarlet headband in her almond hair, which was styled into a side-braid. Around her neck was an ascot that matched the ribbon, and she wore a black blouse that reached past her knees, cinched at the waist. Charcoal, opaque stockings accented her slender legs, and red mary janes capped her feet.

She was a sight to behold; he gawked as his brain attempted to catch up with him.

"Hey," she sweetly said, her tan cheeks dusted with blush.

"Hey...!" Valen squeaked out, just as Sienna's mother joined her daughter on the stoop.

"Hello, Valen!" The woman greeted. "My, you've grown!"

Valen smiled away his disorientation. "Hello, Miss Picano!" He stood aside to let them both in. "Please, come in!"

They walked inside, Valen's mother there to continue the welcoming committee. "Hey, Terra, Sienna, it's been too long!" She beamed at Sienna, her hand lifting to her mouth with a gasp. "Oh, hun, look at you!"

"They're growing up too fast, Vivianna!" Miss Picano gushed. "It's so good to see you. Thank you for having us!"

His mother gestured to Valen. "You can thank this one for that."

"That's what I heard!" Miss Picano shot him a savvy look before sharing in the expression with his mother.

Valen was blushing again. Why was it so different than any other time they'd all had dinner? His sharp dress and puttering heart made a case...

“Greetings, ladies,” His father joined the reunion, dipping his head meekly. “You’re both looking beautiful this evening.”

“Oh, stop, Avino,” Miss Picano giggled. “It’s so good to see you!”

The pleasantries continued on, Valen and Sienna finding each other’s gaze as their parents chatted. They grinned at one another in a mixture of shyness and anticipation.

Karreo bashfully peaked from the kitchen, catching Miss Picano’s attention. “Oh, Karreo, you’ve gotten so big, too!”

His little brother awkwardly nodded before retreating out of sight, earning a laugh from the parents.

“Well, dinner is just in the kitchen,” His mother said. “Let’s eat, shall we?”

—

Dinner was delicious, if Valen may say so himself. The savory flavors of the alfredo combined with the tang of the balsamic vinaigrette of the salad was divine. The caramelization of the tart was the perfect finisher, made all the sweeter by great company.

Following the meal, they relocated to the backyard, the evening air crisp with an early summer breeze. They all sat on the porch socializing while their parents sipped on wine.

Valen had brought his guitar out to strum on, serenading the evening with a gentle melody. If there was anything he loved as much as magic or cooking, it was music. His mother had taught him to play when he was just a boy, and he’d not put the hobby down since. He had dabbled with a couple instruments over time, but the acoustic guitar was his most trusted utensil. He could lose himself in the rich vibrations; it was like an embrace for his soul.

Sienna watched him intently, as she usually did when he played. Somehow, he felt a tad more self conscious than past performances, however. He kept stumbling over chords, to his chagrin.

“Come on, I wanna go to the river!” Karreo eventually insisted.

“Ooh, I’d like that!” Sienna seconded.

Valen too was in agreement, and so off they went, Karreo running ahead as Valen and Sienna strolled behind, considerably slower.

Just outside their yard's fence was the steep beach of the ____ River. There was a bench the family had long-ago placed in the shade of a willow tree, overlooking the most shallow part of the river bank.

Karreo of course got there first, shouting in victory, the two teens conceding with laughter. The younger demorin scampered down to the gravelly beach, where there was an eddy in the current. In times past, Sienna and Valen would be right behind him, eager to play in the water themselves, but instead they took a seat on the bench.

"It's so good to be back here..." Sienna said, gazing out towards the river. The water was rippling with shades of twilight as it tirelessly coursed past. "I wish we didn't have to leave every year..."

The prospect of Sienna leaving stung a tad more than it usually did. "Can't convince your Mom to live with your grandmother for the whole year, eh?" Valen tried to joke.

Sienna giggled despite the threatening melancholy, but she didn't reply otherwise.

"Well, you just got here. We have the whole summer ahead of us. We don't have to think about it ending right now," Valen encouraged.

She set her honey eyes on him in a wistful smile. "You're right..."

Something about the way she stared made his insides tingle and flutter, thus it was his turn to stare out towards the river. The conversation lapsed, the flowing of water and frogsong filling the quiet. Valen pressed himself to keep talking, not wanting the momentum to fizzle out.

"Well, I'm really happy you're here for another summer." He rallied his courage and faced her again, finding her still staring at him. The two locked eyes as he went on, a lump in his throat and his cheeks overheating. "It's... really good to see you again."

"It's... really good to see you, too," she told him, her own cheeks aflame.

Karreo shouting for them interrupted the moment. Valen was dizzy as he snapped his attention towards his brother, who was climbing back up the bank with a frown.

"Aren't you guys coming?" Karreo whined, his feet slipping on the uneven terrain.

The tension released as both of them laughed, embarrassed and nervous. They stood from the bench and set down the bank, just like old times.

Chapter 7

Avino

The week passed by uneventfully, to his relief. No new graffiti replaced the words that had been scrubbed away, nor any other signs of trouble.

Well, at least as far as that situation was concerned.

Indeed, there were developments of a much different type: his oldest son was showing the first signs of romantic interest in a girl.

"They seem mighty drawn to each other, don't they?" Vivianna had observed the evening they all had dinner together. The parents were not so discreetly peeping at the two of them sitting just outside the fence.

Terra had giggled into her wine at that. "It's so good to see. He's a great match for her!" The human woman elbowed Vivie in jest, winking. "I always said if they can cook, they're a keeper."

The two ladies leaned into one another, snickering as they both eyeballed Avino. The demorin shook his head, amusement playing on his features. The wine was starting to use them as a mouthpiece, it seemed...

That night, after their guests had left and they readied for bed, Vivianna had told him: "I think it may be time to have a chat with Valen, Avino."

The father definitely agreed, but said talk was to be an endeavor. He had tried multiple times the following days, only to fold when the moment arose. All the while, Valen was keen to visit Sienna again, but the parents had orchestrated tasks to delay their next meeting. Watching Karreo, housework, grocery trips, town errands; there definitely wasn't a shortage of quests to send him out on.

Valen was always an eager sort to help, but Avino could sense his son growing more and more antsy. The nightly phone calls on the landline weren't going to tide him over forever, thus, one last favor would be the father's deadline to breach the subject: asking Valen to help at the shop for the day.

Luckily, his son had perked up at the idea, happily agreeing.

They were busy getting ready to open the shop when Avino decided it was now or never. Valen was sorting through some premade shirts when the father cleared his throat.

“So, dinner with the Picanos’ went well the other night...” He began, Valen freezing at the mention of it. The teenager peered over at his father, his expression a mix of intrigue and nervousness.

“Y-yeah!” Valen replied, returning to his task as a form of retreat. “I thought so, too!”

The two nodded wordlessly as Avino gathered his thoughts.

“Son, you’re about that age now...” the father said, every word slow and deliberate. “Where you become interested in... relationships.”

The shirts on the rack demanded every bit of Valen’s attention as the parent went on.

“What you’re feeling is normal, and, ah, a good thing!” Avino struggled on. “But, it’s important you understand... emotions are going to run... very high. There... may be things you’re wanting to express and... *urges* that you’re going to have—”

“Dad, it’s fine!” Valen cut in, his maroon cheeks flushing. “I get it! I— I know!”

“Well, son, it’s important we have this discussion,” Avino insisted. “I need to know that you’re going to be responsible and not do anything... rash.”

“Dad, come on...” Valen groaned, melting into the clothes rack. “Of course I won’t. She—I— it’s not even like that!”

“That may be the case now, but things can suddenly move awfully fast at your age. Promise me you’ll be a *responsible* gentleman?” The demorin pushed.

“Dad...!”

“Valen.”

His son deflated. “I— of course!”

“Good.” Avino went to flip the open sign, satisfied. That was one massive weight off his shoulders.

The day chugged on, both of them happy enough to put the awkward exchange behind them. Valen was an eager assistant, fetching him supplies and ringing clients up with a smile. The boy’s customer service was fantastic; Avino could use his help at the store more often.

Closing time arrived, Avino locking up as Valen looked towards the road wistfully. It was not lost on Avino that it was in the direction of Old Trader Square.

"You can go talk to her," Avino said with a smirk. "Just don't be out too late, you hear?"

Valen brightened at his father's blessing. "Thanks, Dad, I won't!"

Valen

It was like a dream to see her again. While their phone calls had been lovely, nothing quite matched the dance of his heart when they met in person. He had found her closing the cart for the day, the two reuniting with a hug, to Mrs. Thickett's disapproval.

"Enough of that," the elderly woman had grumbled, the two of them defusing with a nervous giggle.

"Want to join me for dinner at the Skipping Rock?" He had worked up the nerve to ask after some idle chit chat.

Sienna's eyes had sparkled at the proposition. "Can I, Grandma?!"

Mrs. Thickett had glowered at them for a tense second. Then, she scoffed. "Go on, then."

Dinner went wonderfully. The meal passed by with giggles and flighty chatter, Mrs. Panto delighted to serve them. When he got the bill he noticed the terran had given him a steep discount, which he appreciated. While he could have afforded it, having worked for the day, it was a kind gesture.

They stepped out of the restaurant, finding the town awash in the sepia tones of twilight.

They were walking towards the bus stop in silence when Sienna bit her lip, as though weighing something. She twirled her hair and dropped her gaze to the sidewalk, suddenly shy. "So... is..."

Valen waited for her to continue through nervous intrigue.

The human girl bashfully lifted her chin, their eyes meeting with a skip of his heart. "Is this... a date?"

The demorin's face blared hot and his stomach fluttered. "Do... you want it to be?"

A smile lifted Sienna's olive cheeks and she glanced down in consideration. She once again met his eyes, her hazel on his topaz. "...And if I do?"

"I... I want it to be, too," Valen admitted, his own smile breaking.

They both laughed away the nerves and welcomed the relief with more smiles. Their giggling trailed away, and then Valen felt the friction of Sienna's hand brush up against his.

He dared himself to lace his fingers around hers and it was like bellows on a forge when their hands entwined. The fire in his heart burned bright; he was thrust into a jubilation he'd never experienced.

They walked down the street, hand in hand, words unneeded.

When they arrived at Sienna's bus stop, they took a seat on the bench, still attached.

Valen searched for something to say, but nothing quite matched the energy of his soul. "I had a lot of fun tonight," he settled on, unremarkably.

"Me, too..." Sienna replied through a blissful sigh.

The minutes ticked by all too quickly. When her transport arrived, Valen squeezed her hand before letting her go with a little wave. "Have a good night, Sienna..."

She offered him a sparkling smile before stepping onto the bus. "See you later, Valen!"

His bus operated at a different part of town. He set towards it, a pep in his step as he went.

Dusk was giving way to night, as such the streets became less and less crowded.

It was freshly dark when he heard shuffling behind him. He glanced over his shoulder, spotting three older teenagers slinking their way towards him.

Valen was instantly uncomfortable at the way their eyes bore into him. He turned back around, hoping they would just pass on by, but that possibility vanished as they moved to cut off his path.

"Excuse me, I'm just trying to get home," Valen attempted politely, but the teens didn't budge. Adrenaline grabbed him by the throat as dread bubbled where glee just had.

"You're not going anywhere," one of the boys, a human, grunted. He had dark hair and greasy skin.

"Yeah, we got a lot to talk about!" another said, also human. This one was tall but heavy set, with blonde hair.

Valen glanced between them, doubtful they meant a friendly chat.

"We saw you got yourself a new *girlfriend*," the middle teen, an eln, sneered, spurring a snort from the other two. He appeared to be their leader, judging by his demeanor. He had pin straight black hair and silver skin dotted with blue flecks.

A chill shuddered down Valen's spine; how did they know? He'd never spoken to or seen these boys before in his life!

"Well?" The middle challenged, stepping too close, the other two mirroring him. "That true?"

He racked his brain for how to respond, what to do, how to get out of the situation, *anything*, only for nothing but frenzied static to answer.

"Hey, he asked you a question," one of the lackeys growled.

Valen's wheels proceeded to spin in place.

"Yeah, *demon*," the other goon muttered. "You too dumb to talk or what?"

The insult breathed some gumption into him. "W-What's it to you?"

The eln shoved at the demorin. "Watch your mouth, hell rat. Now," he pushed Valen again, "You seeing this girl?"

Valen's tail thrashed at the assault, teenage testosterone coming to his aid. "And if I am?"

The eln wickedly laughed, the other two parroting their leader. He got right up in Valen's face with a scowl. "That would be trouble for you."

"Yeah, we can't have hellspawn thinking they can get cozy with the locals," the larger one chided.

The rush of blood was deafening in Valen's ears as panic coursed through him. He'd dealt with passive bigotry before, but this was on a whole other level. He hated conflict as it was, let alone with someone threatening real violence. '*This has to be who vandalized the shop.*'

"I'm not gonna ask again," the eln growled. "You seeing this girl, or *not*?"

Valen recognized they were trying to threaten him into submission, but his spirit balked at the idea of it. It wasn't any of their business who he dated, his heritage had nothing to do with it!

Then again, he knew that if he replied truthfully, their violence would likely escalate from petty graffiti. Being it was three against one, the odds were stacked against him.

He took too long to reply for their liking as they shoved into him yet again, Valen stumbling back this time. He bumped into the husky teen, who had slunk behind him.

"Tell us you're not going to bother her anymore, and we don't have to make your face even uglier," the eln threatened, uncomfortably close again.

Teenage hormones and pride finally forced his head into a shake. He wouldn't, they couldn't bully him!

The eln snickered incredulously, dumbfounded at his defiance. "Wrong answer, hellspawn."

The leader was winding up a punch when the whooping of a siren sounded. The three bullies turned to see a police cruiser coming up the road, crashing their plans.

They cursed and took off in a hurry, but not before the eln hollered "Tell anybody about this and your whore girlfriend gets it!"

Valen watched them cut into an alley as the car slowly inched forward. He waited to make absolutely certain they were gone as the cruiser arrived next to him.

He let go of a bated breath and the police car faded into nothingness, plunging the street back into quiet darkness.

He hurried towards his bus stop, desperate to get home in case his tormentors grew wise to the trick. He ran as fast as he could, but it didn't feel quick enough.

Despite it all, he made it. He cowered in the lean-to, waiting to be caught at any moment, but his bus eventually pulled up to rescue him.

He arrived home, dizzy and nauseous from the come down of the adrenaline. His hands were shaky as he fumbled with his keys and unlocked the door, sparing one last glance behind him.

He was alone. He'd managed to escape.

He went inside with bleak expectations. *'For now...'*

Chapter 8

Valen

Valen was sick the next day. At least, that's what he had told everyone.

His parents had noted his distress on his return, but he'd assured them he was just feeling under the weather and needed to lie down. He'd retreated to his room, afraid he was actually going to lose his dinner as panic harassed his innards.

A sleepless night followed, a whole battalion of what-ifs and terrifying scenarios storming his mind. Certainly he had to tell someone about what happened, but the bully's threat was a sobering one. Considering they were resorting to physical violence with him, Valen feared calling their bluff was unwise. It horrified him to wonder what they might do to Sienna; her getting hurt or worse was just something he refused to risk.

Then what was he to do? If he told his parents they would surely tell law enforcement, and that could backfire in the exact ways he dreaded. Yet, if he could not tell anyone, how was he to deal with his tormentors on his own?

The idea of being jumped by the trio again terrified him; he knew he would not be so lucky a second time.

One night of rumination was not enough to solve his predicament, thus he was feigning sickness for the foreseeable future. Not even the magic lessons he was supposed to have that day could spring him from his self-imposed prison of blankets and solitude.

His father knocked on his door that evening, offering soup. Valen had not eaten since the night before, but that was no accident. The idea of food nauseated him; he was simply too stressed to consider it.

Regardless, he allowed his father to deliver the offering of chicken noodle on his nightstand. Despite being faced towards the wall and bundled in blankets, Valen could sense his father searching for words.

"Did something happen?" His parent finally said, Valen wincing from within his cocoon.

"I just don't feel good," the teenager croaked, and it was no fib.

His father sat down, sinking the edge of the bed. "Son, you can talk to me."

But Valen knew he couldn't.

"...Did Sienna turn you down?" The parent guessed after another pause.

The question took him off guard. "Wah- no. It's not –" he shut his mouth before he dug himself into a hole. He chose his next words carefully. "I just must have caught something, Dad."

He could feel his parent's eyes on him, prodding. "Well, eat some soup. It'll help you recover." He patted Valen's back and his weight lifted off of the bed. "Feel better, son."

Karreo

Karreo was eavesdropping from just outside the kitchen as his parents discussed his brother's mysterious illness.

"He's still feeling sick. Claims it's nothing to do with him and Sienna, and he didn't seem to be lying," his father shared.

There was a sigh from his Mother. "It's not like him to hole himself up like this. Maybe he really is sick, Vinny."

Karreo was bummed to hear Valen was still under the weather. He'd not been in to check on his brother since that afternoon, when Valen had assured him he'd be ready to play later. However, judging by his father's news, Karreo would have to wait longer yet.

At least he had a good book to occupy his time, as was often the case. He grabbed his current read, 'Secrets of Modulation' and snuggled up by the fireplace, his tail curling around his legs.

Runes and charts lined the pages, filing away in his memory as he intently learned. This book's focus was on the rucanic school of Modulation, describing spells that temporarily augmented the physical form. The current chapter was delving into spell duration verses runa expenditure, while the next was to be a formula break-down of a 'Speed' spell. Karreo had already read the book front to back before, but the second read would provide further elucidation.

He must have drifted off at some point, for the next thing he knew his father was carrying him to bed. Karreo sleepily accepted his parent's care as he was tucked in and kissed goodnight.

Avino

Avino was sat in his study, charging some rucanic batteries for the next batch of enchantments. An unexpected guest popped into the doorframe, rousing him from his concentration

“Valen, you’re up!” The father remarked, encouraged by his son being out of bed.

“Hey, Dad...” Valen was far from his usual self; he was clearly still exhausted. The teenager went to sit down in an armchair, nervously running a hand through his unkempt hair. “Have... have you heard any news from the cops about the vandalism?”

Avino frowned at the reminder. “Afraid not. Unfortunately, since there was no evidence left behind, they have no leads. Best we can hope for if it happens again is to catch them in the act, and I have surveillance set up now.”

Said security was an old witness-orb he’d dug out of storage; if anyone lingered in front of the shop for too long, the orb would record and store the scene. It was a suitable enough solution until a more sophisticated camera arrived in the mail.

Valen didn’t appear comforted by that at all. “What... what if they don’t stop at... just vandalizing.”

Avino sized his son with a raise of his eyebrows. “What do you mean?”

His son dropped his gaze to his knees. “What if... what if someone wants to hurt us.”

A realization that had been amassed through sprinkled hints and suspicion finally bloomed.

“Why, did someone threaten you?” He watched his child carefully as Valen squirmed in his seat and shook his wavy hair, perhaps too hurriedly.

“N-no! It’s just... I can’t help but feel like it’s building to that.”

“Well, vandalism is a petty crime. What makes you think whoever did it has the bravado to hurt anyone?”

Valen bit his lip, Avino sensing deliberation. However, the younger demorin ultimately bumped his shoulders in a shrug, defeated.

“Well, if they *did*,” Avino stressed this word, “We would report it to the police, who would help us deal with the threat.”

“And what if the police don’t... don’t do anything in time?” Valen’s concern kept.

The father's attention drifted over to his mounted spellslinger on the wall, dusty from its long retirement. "We're not defenseless, son." He stood, his bad leg stiff as ever as he limped over to stare closer at his old weapon..

Valen was staring at the gun, too. "But... your leg..."

Avino smirked at his son. "I don't need a good leg to fire a spell."

Valen's lips twitched with a meager grin despite his uncertainty. He proceeded to stare at the spellslinger, the usual wonderment he had for the weapon replaced with anxiety.

The older demorin sighed with a shake of his head. "I don't think it's going to come to that, son."

"But what if it does?" The teenager struck Avino as a bit too contemplative as he studied the weapon.

"There are steps we can take first," the father said, with a touch of sternness. "We'd get the police involved first, it shouldn't have to come to violence."

"O...Okay..." Valen conceded, returning his attention to his knees.

"...Is there something we need to talk about?" Avino again pressed, but Valen still stubbornly shook his head. The teen got to his feet, and Avino stepped forward to wrap his child in a hug.

"Well, when you're ready to talk, I'll be here," he told him with a squeeze. Valen broke the embrace with a weak nod and left the room, glum as he entered it.

Avino grimaced at his son's reluctance to share; it was out of character for the lad to be so withdrawn.

The demorin drew his attention back on the spellslinger, finding himself in a reminiscent mood.

Memories from Vivianna and his prior life adventuring echoed in his memory, ricocheting with a nostalgia that had aged bittersweet.

It all rushed back to him: he recalled meeting Vivie at their guild and his immediate infatuation with her. Him meeting another demorin on his travels filled a void he hadn't realized he'd done without, and her beauty was captivating. However, that wasn't all that drew him to her. Her wit was keen as a knife, and she was assertive and commanded respect. It counteracted his meekness starkly, but it was a complimentary sort of contrast.

They grew to like working together, and then they grew to like each other, too (her much slower than he). Soon, he couldn't imagine his life without her, and when they both left the guild to pursue independent work, they became a team.

They saw the world together, braving dungeons and caves and tombs, besting all the odds. But, it was not to last forever.

He had suffered a terrible fall, the impact shattering his legs. While terribly painful, it usually would have been no consequence, for they had healing potions. However, there was always a risk with biomanipulation spells, and that caveat only multiplied with such a complicated injury.

The usual agony of the spell propelling his body through months of healing in mere seconds had overcome him, but as the majority of the pain faded, he could tell something was wrong. His left leg still ached horribly, and when he looked down at it, it was clearly set incorrectly. They had called off their dig early and retreated back to town, where they sought medical attention.

The healer had explained that yes, the spell had put his leg back together, but it had healed in bad form. Such a break *should* have been healed under careful supervision by a biomanipulist or even a mundane doctor, not entrusted to only a healing elixir. It was fortunate that only his left leg was handicapped so.

He was given a choice: rebreak the leg and pursue guided healing, with no guarantee it would completely fix the issue, or leave the damage as it was. He figured he had to try, if there was a chance it could be saved.

It was not to be. Though the reconstruction helped the pain, the magical scar tissue had bestowed him with a permanent limp. Thus, his adventuring days were over.

At first he was jaded, but as the comforts and fulfillment of domestic life panned out, those feelings metamorphosed into contentment. He found great purpose in his enchanted tailoring business, and even more in fatherhood.

The only regret was the cost of his physical state. Though, he hadn't dreamed of needing offensive capability in his slow life at Riverview. Outside from his nightmares, anyway.

Even now, nothing proved with certainty it would come to such, but Valen's fretting rustled something deep within his instincts.

He dismissed his retrospection with a sigh and left the room, turning off the light. Hopefully, Valen would share what had happened sooner than later.

Chapter 9

Karreo

The next morning came with the possibility of Valen finally emerging from his bedrest, but when Karreo went to him, he was still a bundled lump on his bed.

“Do you feel any better?” Karreo asked the mass of blankets with a tiny frown.

“Uggh...” The pile answered. “A little... just give me... a couple minutes.”

A couple minutes turned to ten, then to thirty. Still no Valen.

Karreo was going to try again when the responder rang, stealing his attention. He stayed within earshot to snoop as his mother picked up the line.

“Hello again, Sienna...Yeah, he’s still feeling sick, sorry sweetie. ...Oh, I’m sure he’d like that, go ahead!”

Oh, what was Sienna up to? The eleven year old scampered into Valen’s room with fresh ammunition.

His sibling had at least pulled himself into sitting up, albeit with large bags under his eyes. Karreo plopped next to him, confident his news would breathe some life into his brother.

“Sienna called again. I think she’s coming over.” It was a guess, but an educated one, based on how his mother talked.

Valen sprang to life, alright. He shot out of bed, but instead of excitement, he seemed... panicked? “What?! Why?”

Karreo grimaced with confusion at Valen’s weird reaction. “I’unno...? What’s *with* you?”

The older demorin didn’t answer as he rushed out of his room and to the landline. His mother greeted him with surprise, but Valen was too preoccupied with dialing what Karreo assumed was Sienna’s number to spare her a reply either.

“Hello, you’ve reached the Thickett-Picano residence!” Miss Picano’s chipper voice came from the receiver.

“M-Miss Picano, can I talk to Sienna?” Karreo could peg that Valen was trying to disguise his worry, but he wasn’t doing a very good job.

“Oh, you just missed her, Valen! But, don’t worry, she’s actually on her way over!” Miss Picano confirmed Karreo’s suspicion.

“O-oh,” Valen replied. “G-great, thank you! Bye...”

Both Karreo and their mother stared at Valen in bewilderment.

“I told her she could come over, is that a problem?” Their mom wondered.

Valen pulled at his sleep deprived features with a groan. “N-no... I just... Don’t want to get her sick...”

“Honey, surely you’re not contagious by now?” She insisted. “Go get yourself a shower, eat some breakfast, and come back to the world of the living, son.”

Valen left the kitchen, his tail dragging, Karreo watching him go with a sideways look.

“I thought he wanted to see her?” He mused with his mother.

She nodded, eyes narrowed. “Something isn’t adding up.”

Something wasn’t adding up, indeed...

—

Karreo was sitting on the couch watching outside the window, eager for their guest to arrive. Wherever there was Sienna, there were usually peaches in tow.

The human girl at last came into view, a bundle in her hands as she made her way up the hill. Karreo’s tail couldn’t help but wag at the promise of a sweet treasure.

Sienna is not all he spotted, however. An unfamiliar vehicle was making its way slowly behind her, only to pass faster when she glanced over her shoulder. It struck Karreo as odd; cars traveling down their road were fairly rare, as their neighbors only owned farming equipment or no vehicle at all, much like their own family.

Karreo thought himself a spy in one of his novels as he squinted at the car, mentally noting details. It was of Runestepper make, a sedan. By the curve of the headlights and high side mirrors, likely a Stallion. It was black, and curiously the windows were tinted. When he went to check for plates, they were smeared with mud and harder to read, contrasting the rest of the car’s neat appearance.

He still managed to make out a couple numbers before the car came close enough that he had to duck out of sight. He peeked back over the upholstery to watch it drive on, the back plates even more obscured than the front.

Sienna made it to the door and he opened it before she could knock, causing her to jump. “Oh! Hi, Karreo!”

He eyed the bag in her hands before awkwardly waving. “Hi...”

She followed his gaze and snickered. “Yes, I brought peaches, of course! I know they’re your favorite.”

That was true. He stepped aside and she came in, sparing one last look behind her. Karreo looked too, seeing nothing but an empty road.

The girl hefted the bundle in her hands. “Where should I put these?”

‘In my belly.’ “Uhhh, just the counter or something.”

His mother was in the kitchen gathering supplies for laundry. She greeted Sienna with a smile before making her way downstairs. “Valen is just getting dressed now. He’ll be out shortly. Nice to see you, sweetie!”

“You too, Mrs. Vaaskiir!” Sienna said.

“Make sure he eats something when he comes out!” She called before disappearing down the steps.

Sienna put down the bag and Karreo spared no time snagging himself a pink prize. He bashfully dipped his head in appreciation and shuffled out of the kitchen, Sienna giggling at the display.

“You’re welcome, Karri.”

He grabbed himself a strategic seat in the living room, knowing from prior experience it was a good distance for eavesdropping.

Valen finally came from down the hall and Karreo watched him slump into the kitchen through the corner of his eye. He put his spy cap back on, hoping to discover just what was bothering his brother so much.

Valen

A shower and a fresh pair of clothes had him feeling a tad braver to face Sienna, but it still sank his stomach to see her sitting in the kitchen. She met him with her usual bubbly smile.

“Hey! I figured since you were still feeling under the weather I would just stop by! I—” her grin went apologetic as she noted his demeanor. “I hope that’s okay.”

“Uh- yeah! It’s, it’s fine,” Valen fibbed. Truthfully, everything was the very opposite of fine. He dropped himself into a chair, shaky and nauseous.

“You should eat something. Here, I brought some fresh peaches; they should be gentle enough on your stomach.”

He allowed her to hand him one, and he bit into it despite the fire all around him. The gush of delicate flavor flooded his senses as he realized just how hungry he was. The peach was devoured down to the pit in record time.

“Oh wow, taking one from Karreo’s book, huh?” Sienna giggled.

Valen released some embarrassment with a single chuckle. “Sorry, I... haven’t eaten much.”

“Well, I’m glad I could help, then!”

The conversation lulled, Valen’s gaze on the table as he considered how to proceed.

“Has... anyone... *bothered* you recently?” He began after a pregnant pause.

The girl tilted her head. “I don’t think so? Why do you ask?”

Relief trickled at her confusion. “You haven’t noticed any one... staring at you, or following you, or anything out of the ordinary?”

“No, I—” She cut herself off as her eyes narrowed. “Well, actually, when I was walking up the hill just now, a car slowly came up behind me before passing. But that’s all I can think of.”

The reveal walled his relief back up instantly.

“...Why? Did something happen, Valen?” Her petite hand slid across the table to grab his, loosening the dam.

Valen weighed what he should do and what he should reveal. He couldn’t keep this all to himself any longer, it was eating him alive. Plus, if Sienna was aware of what was going on, perhaps she could take measures to prevent the unthinkable.

Her being there in his kitchen was already violating the bully’s demands anyhow, the best damage control now was being transparent, if only with her.

“...Yes. I...” He wanted to just be out with it, but the words weren’t coming together as fear and shame knotted his tongue. Despite everything, he did his best to stitch the story together. “The other night, after... after dinner... I was jumped by three older kids. They... They said some terrible things, and... threatened me. They claimed that I... that I shouldn’t be hanging out with

you, and that it would be trouble if I did. They were going to beat me up, but I was able to get away...”

Sienna was a horrified audience to his tale. She gaped at him, stupefied. “Why... Why didn’t you tell me sooner?”

“They said if I told anyone, they’d hurt you...” Being that he was doing the exact thing he was warned against, together with her in his house of all places, the threat was especially foreboding.

“That is preposterous!” She cried too loudly, indignant. “Please tell me you’ve at least told your parents!”

“Shhh!” He wasn’t keen on letting anyone else know just yet. “You... you’re the first one to know.”

“Valen! This is serious!” Sienna hissed, only marginally quieter. “You need to tell your parents!”

“But then they’ll tell the police!”

“Exactly!”

“They can’t! Those creeps said they’d hurt you!”

“Valen,” she squeezed his hand in hers. “If we tell the police, they’ll be able to stop them, right? How else are we going to fix this?”

His head was too heavy to lift as he replied, “I... I don’t know.”

“Uh... guys,” Karreo’s voice came from the archway, spooking both of them. “The car is back...”

They both gawked at the eleven year old. “What?!” Why did Karreo know about the car?

“The black Stallion from earlier... it’s in front of the house.”

They hurried to their feet and went to see for themselves. It was true; a black car was idling on the road in front of their residence.

“That’s the car that was following me,” Sienna confirmed, her voice shaking. “Valen...!”

The fear in her voice rattled his terror into resolve.

“Are those the bad guys?” Karreo whispered, apparently savvy to the situation. Valen didn’t have the mind to question that yet.

“Karreo, go get Mom,” Valen ordered, his vision not leaving the vehicle for a moment. His little brother fled towards the kitchen steps to do just that.

Adrenaline pumped through him, liquid moxie. The gears in his brain turned rapidly; what was he going to do if they got out of the car? How could he protect Sienna, his family?

The wall in his father’s study flashed in his mind, to the dusty spellslinger hung there. His father’s console reprimanded the idea.

He was caught in a web of indecision when the car obnoxiously revved and the windows opened to release a volley of rotten food. The sludgy barrage sloshed onto their front lawn and the side of their home.

“Go back to hell you demon freaks!” A raucous voice hollered as the car skidded off, wicked laughter punctuating it.

His mother arrived just in time to see the barbaric display. She spared not even a second to rush outside and hurl netherish obscenities, much to Valen’s horror.

“Mom, no, come back!”

“Mrs. Vaaskiir!”

Her storm of curses raged on as she balked at the heap of garbage soiling their lovely flowerbeds. “Valen! *What is going on?!*”

“Just— just come back inside, please!” Valen pleaded from the open door. “I... I can explain.”

Chapter 10

Valen

The red and blue lights of the chief’s cruiser played on the lawn as the vehicle pulled into the driveway. The family had anxiously gathered in the living room to receive the officer; their father had hurried home as soon as he heard what happened.

Chief Sarpani was ushered in by his mother. “Thank you for coming so quickly, Chief.”

The human jerked her head in a firm nod. "Just doing my job. Sounds like your family has been through it, from what you said on the correspondent."

Bleak nods from all around the room answered.

"Well," the chief's attention locked onto Valen, expectant. "Let's hear it, then. What have you got for me?"

He had been bracing himself to share the story yet again, but the prospect of explaining everything remained a chore. Even so, he was able to fight against the current of hesitation. It was his third time telling the tale now, having already told Sienna and then his family. The words still felt unnatural on his tongue, as though he were talking about somebody else.

Chief Sarpani listened with a steel expression, taking notes every so often. She asked for descriptions, locations, times, fine details... The story came to the car that had vanded their property, and when the chief asked for plates, Valen had no answer, regrettably. How had he missed that?!

"923H were the first characters for sure, but it was really hard to make out all of it," his little brother cut in.

The room sized the eleven year old with a look of puzzlement, but Chief Sarpani didn't dwell there. "Color, make, and model?"

"Black, Runstepper, a Stallion, I think." The child's shoulders bumped with a tiny shrug.

Valen was still bewildered at just how much his little brother had noticed. He knew Karreo was an astute kid, sure, but his observation skills definitely exceeded expectations. Judging by the way his parents gaped at him too, it was a shared experience.

The chief scrawled down the information efficiently. "Anything else to report?"

"I only imagine these are the same kids who vandalized the shop," his father said.

"You're probably right, but unfortunately we're between a rock and a hard place currently," Chief Sarpani replied.

His parent tilted his head with scrutiny. "How so?"

"Well, we'll certainly track these kids down and give them a good talking to, but with no hard evidence, that's about all we can do."

His mother shot to her feet. "What do you mean?! Look out at our yard! How is that not evidence?!"

"We have enough to question them, but with no photographic or forensic evidence, it's just a matter of he-said she-said."

"You're joking! That can't be right!?"

The chief's stern eyes wavered with regret. "You have my word that we'll be doing all we can. We'll keep a close eye on these punks, next time they act up we'll be there to catch them."

"And if you aren't?" His father wondered. "Wasn't it you that were telling me the other day that you only had so much man power? How do you expect to be everywhere all at once?"

"I'll be stopping by businesses and homes to alert them of the trouble. We'll have the whole town keeping an eye out."

Embarrassment welled at the idea of the whole town knowing about the struggle, but it promised some comfort, too. It would be better to have the public aware, despite the shame.

"Any other questions, comments, concerns?"

Valen glanced at Sienna, who had barely spoken a word since earlier. Worry and guilt constricted him; he hated that she was involved. "They... they said they were going to hurt Sienna if I told anyone. Doesn't that incriminate them in some way?"

Sienna snapped to attention at the mention of her name, but still remained quiet.

"It definitely counts as a threat," the chief replied. "But, it's not enough to make any prolonged arrests, not unless actual violence is committed."

"That is ridiculous..." His mother hissed. "So we just have to wait around for them to attack us? There's nothing you can do to prevent it?!"

"Bringing them in to talk to them will likely scare them into backing down. I've dealt with these goon types from the city before, they're a lot more bark than bite."

The violence the teens had already inflicted challenged that statement, but the family did not press it farther.

"Well, do keep us informed," his father sighed. "I don't like having to just.. Wait for trouble, but if it's all we can do..."

The officer curtly bobbed her head, her expression regretful.

“Chief Sarpani, can you please bring Sienna home? I don’t think she should ride the bus,” Valen requested, and the chief tipped her hat with a nod.

“That I can do.”

Valen half-listened to his mother talk with Sienna’s in the other room, the words blurring into a slurry. He was numb and wrung out from the day’s turbulence; he hoped he had made the right decision, and the corresponding relief assured him he had.

His mother sounded like she was wrapping up the call when Karreo plopped down next to him on the couch.

“So, how exactly did you know what was going on?” Valen tried him.

Karreo was nonchalant as he shrugged. “You’re loud when you talk.”

Valen snickered despite himself. “Ah, so you were eavesdropping...”

His brother again shrugged, and Valen ruffled his hair, bemused. He should probably feel disturbed at being spied on, but instead he was just more impressed. His sibling had shown shrewd initiative and competence; those spy novels he liked were rubbing off.

He did have to wonder just what else Karreo was savvy to, however... “What else have you heard?”

“More than you, Mom, and Dad think I know,” the eleven year old replied.

The conversation with his father when the vandalism first happened flashed in his memory.

“We just didn’t want to scare you, buddy,” Valen explained.

“I know,” Karreo replied, and Valen didn’t doubt that he did.

—

Chapter 11

Avino

The next day, the chief stopped by to deliver the news that the troublemakers had been talked to. It went about as well as she'd promised; the boys denied everything and they were unable to keep them arrested. She explained that they did their best to scare the teens and dissuade them from any further antics, but it was best that the family remain vigilant.

It did little to comfort Avino and Vivianna, but what else could they do but trust law enforcement?

...Well, there was one other thing they could try.

Avino thumbed through the mail pile until he found the card from weeks before. He showed it to his wife, who beheld it with matching intrigue. Weeks ago, both she and Avino had not been impressed with the solicitor's proposal, but events had certainly developed since then. If the police weren't doing enough, then perhaps it was time to see exactly what this "Clawed Fist" could do for them.

Avino stared down at the card the man had left them through a mixture of shame and hesitation. It was certainly embarrassing to go from telling the organization their life was ideal to far from it, but he wasn't about to let pride get in the way of protecting his family.

When he dialed the number, the same man who had stopped by answered, warm and friendly. "This is Thad Ives speaking. How may I help you?"

"Ah, hello again, Thad. It's... Avino. Avino Vaaskiir.":

"Ah! Greetings, my friend. I hope everything is still going well for you?"

"Ah, that's actually why I'm calling..." Avino sighed. "We've.. been dealing with some unexpected trouble; you mentioned you provided assistance?"

"Oh, I am so sorry to hear that. Yes, that we do! What's this trouble, can you describe it for me?"

Avino summarized events; Thad an intent audience.

"Unfortunately, the police aren't able to do much. We're in a bind."

"That does not surprise me. Police are hardly ever willing to help *us*, but do not worry. We'll be able to get to the root of the issue for you."

"Oh? How's that?" Avino couldn't help but wonder.

"We have our ways," Thad dodged, dismissive. "We'll be in touch. *Demor, ik Avthor, lek ta far graheil, kin toh vi.*" The last part was spoken in Pyrothian, translating to '*May Demor, our king, smile on you, my brother.*'

Before he could press further, Thad ended the call. Avino brushed off the secrecy with a shake of his head; he wasn't sure why there had to be theatrics, but if they really could provide help, then he would play along.

When it came time to leave for work, the rest of the family accompanied Avino into town for the day; the father disliked the idea of anyone being alone at the house. "We won't let these delinquents control our lives, but we need to be wise. It's best no one is alone right now."

Vivianna and Karreo were in the back while Valen and Avino worked the storefront. It was nearing lunch time when some familiar faces stopped by the store, but not to buy clothes. Dell Panto and her wife A'rahi had come bearing a meal for the entire family.

"If these thugs think they can run rampant in our town, they got another thing coming!" The terran assured. "Riverview has your back. We're all here for you."

They were not the only ones to show their support. Several other patrons came by to voice similar; even Valen's magic tutor, Simitri Dayas, stopped in to reinforce confidence in the family.

"You're a keen lad. These brutes are directionless and thrashing out because of it," the eln encouraged his son. "I hope to see you back in class, but do be safe out there."

It was heartwarming and reassuring to see the town rally up behind them. It did well to remind Avino that while their start in Riverview had been rocky, the community had grown to value and care about them. They were not alone in this.

"Dad, can we stop by the Picano's before going home?" Valen suggested as they closed up shop.

"Of course, son." Afterall, their family wasn't the only ones needing additional support. After a quick stop to purchase a gift of flowers, the family made their way to the Thickett-Picano residence.

They arrived at the town-house, Terra warmly receiving them and ushering them inside. However, Miana Thickett, Sienna's grandmother, was not so delighted. She pulled Avino and Valen aside, her expression tight and uncomfortable.

"Look, I know it's not your fault, but I don't think it's best your family comes around right now," the elder insisted, hushed.

Avino frowned, but it was of understanding. Valen appeared guilty and embarrassed.

Before Avino could get a word in, Mrs. Thickett set her attention on Valen. "It's nothing against... you, but it's best you and Sienna don't see each other any more."

His son lifted his chin to protest, but no retort came.

"Mrs. Thickett, I think that's a bit much?" Avino instead argued on his behalf.

"Is it? They threatened my grandbaby, Avino. How would you feel?" Mrs. Thickett hissed.

"We—*she* doesn't need this. She comes here to get *away* from the city, not to have more trouble!"

"Mrs. Thickett, I'm... sorry," Valen was downtrodden but polite. "I don't want her to get hurt either. But, please..."

"If you really feel that way, you should understand, then," the grandmother held. "Don't come by here again, any of you."

Valen and Avino shared a fretful look, but before they could argue further, Miana Thickett left the room in a huff.

Terra noticed her mother go with a sideways look and ceased her chatting with Vivie. "Oh, what did she say? Don't mind her, she's always sour!" She attempted to encourage, but it did little to assure them. "Please, stay for some coffee!" Her attention found Valen. "Sienna will love to see you!"

Valen flinched and he stepped back towards the door, visibly shaken. "We—we actually should be going."

"We appreciate it, but we have a lot to get home and discuss as a family," Avino added.

"Oh?" Terra frowned, sparing another look at where Mrs. Thickett had stormed off. "If you say so..."

Before they could leave, the thumping of hurried steps down the stairs foretold Sienna's arrival. "Valen!" She reached the landing and bounded up to embrace his son.

Valen was noticeably uncomfortable, and Vivianna narrowed her eyes at Avino. 'What happened?' She mouthed silently.

Avino replied with a look that promised an explanation later.

Valen broke the hug, bluffing a smile. "Sienna, it's great to see you, but we were only stopping by."

"They dropped these off!" Terra said, hefting the bouquet Vivianna had handed over. "Wasn't that so sweet of them?"

“Wait, so you’re leaving?” Sienna was disappointed, and it had Valen’s facade crumbling.

“S-sorry, yeah...”

“Oh... well, I’ll see you soon?” The girl wagered, hopeful.

“Uh,” there was a flash of Avino and Valen sharing another look.

“There’s a lot going on right now, Sienna,” Avino chimed in to spare his son. “Let’s take things a day at a time, alright?”

The young lady appeared confused. “Oh... alright?”

“If this is about her grandmother, I’ll talk to her,” Terra tried.

Sienna jerked with sudden understanding and indignance. “Wait, what did she say?!”

Avino didn’t want to stir the pot; if they wanted to know, they would have to take it up with Mrs. Thickett themselves. “We really should be going. Please, be safe, all of you.”

—

Chapter 12

Valen

It was to be another day in town, but Valen preferred it that way.

The demorin yawned for the umpteenth time as he fussed with a clothes rack, a consequence from another night of poor sleep. He had been knee-deep in rumination since their talk with Mr. Thickett the evening before; it was a hard pill to swallow, but Valen could not deny that he had a point.

It weighed on him drastically that Sienna was roped up in it all. Perhaps it *was* the better thing to not see her anymore, but the prospect had his heart weeping. He felt miserable and selfish because of it, but he didn’t want their relationship to end.

However, he didn’t want Sienna to get hurt even more, right?

It was a constant tug of war in his heart; the struggle carried on and on.

The ring of the door promised a distraction, and he turned around with his best smile to welcome their latest customer.

...Only to see the very person he was so out of sorts over.

“Sienna!” He gasped through a hybrid of panic and longing. “What– What are you doing here?”

“I can’t stay for long. Is... is there somewhere we can... talk?” She appeared uneasy as she scanned around the store.

Valen’s father cleared his throat and gestured to the backroom. Valen and Sienna shared a look before taking up the suggestion.

They were alone in the back, as his mother and Karreo were out running errands in the safety of the midday rush. Valen shut the door for privacy but it was of little comfort; he was sweating at the idea of Mrs. Thickett storming into the store to put an abrupt and fiery end to their meeting.

“You... shouldn’t be here,” Valen said into the wood of the door, his ears and tail drooped.

“Ugh! What did she say to you?!” Sienna growled. “Whatever it was, she’s wrong!”

Valen summoned his courage to face her, and she sprung forward to hug him.

“This is all so unfair!” She cried into his chest, her voice shuddering with threatening sobs.

Valen tightened the hug to ward off her tears, but it only seemed to summon more. They stood like that for a pregnant minute, Valen begging himself to say something. Everything he wanted to voice was stuck roiling in his guts, swirling to the current of indecision.

Eventually, Sienna stepped back to wipe her eyes and cradle her sides, her gaze on their feet. Valen opened his mouth to speak, but his verbal constipation withheld.

Sienna dug into her blouse’s pocket to retrieve an envelope, and she handed it to Valen without lifting her chin. As he took it, she spared him a brief glance, her honey eyes quivering.

“I... I have to go,” she croaked before setting past him, out the door and then out of the shop.

Valen watched her go as his own eyes shimmered. He looked down to the note with fearful anticipation, terrified at what it might say. He pocketed it, not brave enough to find out quite yet.

His father approached him and offered a wordless pat on his back. The night before, his father had told him that the whole situation would eventually work out and to not lose hope; that same assurance was conveyed in his parent’s touch now.

It wasn't until that evening he rounded up enough of his courage to read the letter.

'Valen,

I want to see you, but I can't right now because of my grandmother. She's constantly watching me, and won't let me be with you. She's talking about sending me back to the city!

Come to Riverview Park tonight at midnight. I will be there. *Please* come. I *need* to talk to you.

-Sienna'

It was far from the breakup he was anticipating, but equally terrifying.

Sienna wanted to see him, alone. In the middle of the night. While there were thugs out for them.

Valen had never even snuck out before, let alone while under the threat of physical ramifications! Everything in his gut told him it was a bad idea...

...But of course he *had* to go. He wouldn't let her be out there all alone, and truth be told he was dying to see her, too. *Especially* if their time together was drawing to a close.

The very real threat of his tormentors crashing their rendezvous was a steep one. What could he do to keep them at bay? Surely his illusions only had so much influence; and he doubted he could keep them convincing with all the emotional turbulence.

All roads led to one answer, and it was on display in his father's study.

The spell slinger he had long admired and adored hung in front of him, seductively glinting in the moonlight despite its layer of dust. The ebony-tinted steel was grooved with designs of Pythrothian origin, twisting around runes that shimmered with flecks of yellow, akin to smoldering coals. However, these runes were mere decoration, for the true body of the spell was nestled within the belly of the barrel, encoded in a plate at the back.

Valen stared at the weapon, his mouth dry with nerves and his heart in his throat. He'd never fired a spell slinger before, let alone *held* one. That coupled with the delinquency of his plan had him nervous to even touch it.

Touch it he eventually did, the weapon's steel cold despite the suggested heat of its motif. Gingerly as can be, he hoisted the gun off its bearing and took it into his grasp, the alarm bells deafening as they blared in his mind. '*This is a bad idea!*'

Regardless, he retrieved the holster and strapped the weapon to his side, the weight impossibly heavy. Even though the safety of the gun was on, Valen feared it would fire at any moment.

Of course there was a lot more to it than that. To fire a spell slinger of this class, one needed to activate the runes with the flow of their runa, as the gun itself had no power source of its own. While accidental fires were possible, especially for sorcerers like himself, it was usually an act of deliberation.

Valen had decent practice activating runes, but he was far from experienced in such. However, adrenaline was an impeccable teacher, or at least so he hoped.

Next he took up his father's old bracers, and he fastened those with far more confidence. Much of his prior training in activating magical gear was through those very bracers, which when activated cast 'runic shield' on the user.

The spell would act as a forcefield that would mold tight around the body if activated, bestowing general protection. If necessary, the spell could be augmented by pumping in additional runa, providing further insurance.

His father's old adventuring cloak was the last of his bounty. By the time he'd pulled all the straps tight, readjusted the drape, and hoisted the belt, he felt ready to venture out.

Well, at least more so than he had before.

He slipped through the window into the blue night beyond, his demon eyes adjusting to see in the gloom. He set towards the bus stop, keeping low, his every step a reminder of his deviancy. He attempted to quell his conscience with the necessity of the situation; he *had* to do this!

He huddled in the lean-to from the shadow of his hood, finding comfort in how it obstructed his horns. When the bus finally came, he slipped on to find no one aboard, an unsurprising development, for it was in the middle of the night.

He dropped his coinage into the repository and took a seat as the automated vehicle set back into motion, heading down its route in an endless loop. He leaned his head against the window, and it was cool against the flame of his nerves.

His eyes closed as the vehicle steadily brought him closer to town; he hoped he was doing the right thing.

Karreo

Karreo stirred from his slumber, swearing he had heard something in the hallway. From his spot on the bed, he watched the crack of light under his door flicker as a shadow passed by.

His little heart skipped at the idea of an invasion, and he retreated hopelessly under his covers, squeezing his eyes shut. When no violence followed, he warily crawled out from hiding and willed himself to approach the door.

He put his ear to the wood and could barely make out faint movement, but it was hushed and growing farther away.

Careful as could be, he inched open his door and slunk towards Valen's room so he would not be alone. He didn't dare make any additional sound, and so he slipped inside without knocking.

He tiptoed to his brother's bed, his eyes and ears on the hallway as he went.

"Valen," he whispered, reaching out a hand to nudge his sibling awake. "There's somebody in the house—"

However, he felt nothing but bunched bedding. He turned to look at what he was touching, and while he saw his brother there asleep, he did not feel him. Karreo squinted with confusion, and then with understanding. 'An illusion!'

But... Why would Valen cast an illusion of himself sleeping?

Karreo set back into the hall, equally quiet, but much less afraid.

He found the real Valen within his father's study. Well, at least he could hear him in there; Karreo didn't dare blow his cover by peeking into the room.

Valen was shuffling around for a good minute or so, and then there was a thump and a slide that Karreo pegged as the window opening.

It wasn't until the window was shut for a few seconds that Karreo ventured into the study, finding their father's old adventuring belongings missing, as well as Valen himself.

He snuck up to the window to peer out, spotting a cloaked figure creeping down the hill. He recognized his brother's gait, but not his behavior. Valen was sneaking out? To where, and why?

It was strange enough to bring him back into Valen's room, hungry to find any explanation.

On his first sweep there was nothing of note, but Karreo wasn't keen on giving up empty handed. He pictured himself as one of the detectives in his books; what clues could he glean from the scene?

Valen's nightstand was clear, which at first might *seem* unremarkable, but Valen *a/ways* brought a glass of water to bed. Wherever he was going, he hadn't even gotten himself ready for sleep yet, so it must have been premeditated!

Karreo was poking around Valen's desk when he noticed a book on the shelf was slightly ajar from the others. He cracked it open, finding...

Aha! Jackpot! Hidden in the book was a stash of mementos, sentimental keepsakes, and, well, Karreo was too embarrassed to take a closer look at the rest of it. He ignored the lewd pictures and ticket stubs in favor of the envelope at the top of the pile.

There was a check in his spirit as he thumbed open the letter; was he *really* going to invade his brother's privacy?

...If the whole situation wasn't so bizarre it would have been one thing, but Karreo just had to know what had his brother acting so strangely! Especially in lieu of the threat lately.

The letter was from Sienna, and... oh.

Valen was sneaking off to meet her in town?!

Why would he do such a foolish thing; did he forget about the crazy people wanting to hurt them?!

...Oh, so that's why he took the spell slinger. But, that was a whole other layer of bad idea!

The development was a sobering one. Karreo sat staring at the letter, uncertain on how to proceed. He didn't want to rat his sibling out, but... what if Valen got hurt?

At first he decided that he should keep quiet, and he returned to his own bed to get some more rest. However, as the minutes ticked by, he tossed and turned as worry weighed more and more on him. Eventually, he could take it no longer.

He rolled out of bed to head down the hall to his parents room.

"Mom, Dad, I need to tell you something..."

—

Chapter 13

Valen

Valen's hand was unnaturally perched by the spell slinger on his hip, attempting a chimera of concealment and readiness. Every sound was a bleak possibility of danger, the crickets and katydids song a maddening loop in his ears.

He was briskly making his way to the park, his thoughts scrambled with trepidation and regret. However, he couldn't turn back now; he had to at least find Sienna and bring her home.

He at last arrived at Riverview Park, the place rendered liminal via the glow of the streetlamps and lack of commotion. The jungle gym laid bare, the swings still, and the lawn empty.

A look at his watch told him the time was 12:08. He scanned desperately for Sienna, but couldn't see her anywhere. His heart swelled with consternation; maybe she had lost her nerve, or had found her senses and not come at all? Those possibilities were far kinder to consider than the alternatives...

He didn't dare call out her name as he began a more thorough search for her. He approached the playground, dipping and kneeling to check nooks and crannies, to no avail.

He passed the swings and the half dome and the empty benches before setting his attention to the grassy field and its frame of trees. Still no Sienna.

He was turning tail to head for her house when movement caught his eye, from up in a tree. A boost of adrenaline snapped him to attention as his hand found the holster of the spell slinger, but when he focused on the figure, he realized it was no threat at all.

He hurried over, a contradicting mess of relief and disappointment. When he reached the base of the tree, he looked up in time to see a rock hurtling down towards him. He only barely dodged it as it catapulted past.

"Stay away!" Sienna's fearful but tenacious order came, and another stone came flying down. This one managed to hit him on the shoulder.

"Ow! Sienna, it's me!" Valen yelped, shielding himself from the volley.

"Wah— Valen?" Sienna gasped. "I— I'm sorry! I didn't— I didn't recognize you!"

Well, that wasn't entirely surprising, given his hooded appearance. He dropped the cowl so she could see him clearly, and he raised his hands in submission. "Can... I come up?"

Sienna stammered, embarrassed. "Of course!"

The demorin pulled himself up the tree, his shoulder protesting as his fresh injury ached. "You've got quite the arm on you..." He joked despite himself.

"I'm so sorry... I... I thought you were..." She put her head in her hands as Valen plopped down on the branch next to her. "Sorry..."

"Aw, Sienna, it's fine. It'll take more than a rock to keep me down."

She peered between her fingers, and the two began to snicker as their eyes met. It fledged into laughter, displacing tension through joyous release. Valen hadn't laughed for days, he'd been too accosted by turmoil for the better part of the week.

She leaned into him as their giggles waned, and his arm wrapped around her. They sat like that for a fleeting moment, grasping at the last of their glee until it was swallowed back up by the gravity of their situation.

"This... this wasn't a good idea," Valen started, resting his head on hers.

"I know..." Sienna conceded, her voice low. "I just... didn't know what else to do."

"We just need to be patient. The cops will eventually get these guys when they pull something again, and things can... go back to normal."

"I... I don't think we have the time to be patient," Sienna sighed. "My grandma... she's... really upset by all of this. She's talking about sending me back home..."

The prospect had him squeezing her tighter, but it riled much of his previous conundrum. "Maybe... that's not a bad thing, Sienna."

She pulled away, her brow furrowed with betrayal. "How could you say that?"

"I— I don't want you to get hurt!" He hurriedly explained. "This whole thing, I— I hate that you're involved! It's... it's not fair to you."

"It's not fair to *you*," Sienna cried. "I don't know who these creeps think they are, but it's ridiculous!"

"It is..." Valen agreed, solemn. "Still... I don't want you to get hurt... because of me."

Sienna entwined their hands. "*Valen*, I'm here for you, no matter what."

"I... I can't ask you to do that—"

"You're not. I *want* to be." She gazed deep within his eyes, her sincerity captivating him.

They stared at one another, hand in hand, emotion welling within him. The pressure became too much and it had them both looking away. Even still, Valen's chest was a furnace and his cheeks sweltered from the flame.

Sienna nestled back into him, her closeness another log on the fire. “Remember when we used to come here? We’d climb the trees, just like this...”

Valen chuckled at the memory. “Of course. It wasn’t that long ago.”

“Then why do things feel so different now...” Sienna sighed as a breeze blew past, tugging at the tail of his cloak.

“...Different is good, I hope?” Valen said playfully, though admittedly a tinge worried she didn’t mean well.

Sienna giggled at the call back to their reunion, dispelling that worry. “You know what I mean...”

That he did.

“Well, I’ve really enjoyed our time together,” Valen remarked after a pause, the butterflies in his stomach threatening to float him away.

Sienna once again sat up to stare into him, and he dared himself not to retreat this time.

“Me, too...” Sienna breathed, her gaze keeping as well.

Thus, they became lost in each other, damning all the worry and strife as their faces inched closer and closer still. The gap was closed, their lips meeting amidst a blissful inferno.

The world melted away, all he knew in that moment was the softness of her lips and the sun exploding within him. His free hand came up to cup her cheek, deepening the embrace into a crescendo.

They broke apart when it became too much, the blood pumping in Valen’s ears resonating with every pulse, rendering him dizzy. He stammered wordlessly, agape and enchanted. She slipped into a wide grin, and they both nervously giggled, their foreheads dinking together.

She went in for another kiss, and he couldn’t help but gasp with longing. The fire wasn’t only in his face and chest now, it was *everywhere*. It was unlike anything he’d ever experienced; it invigorated every fiber in him as his inhibitions were conquered by the overwhelming flame.

The hand around her fingers unraveled to travel up her arm, arriving at her shoulder, pulling her even closer still. His hand found her back, the ends of her chestnut hair tickling him, and his palm quested further down. He was entirely titillated as he found the small of her back, and her corresponding gasp was enough to nearly knock him out of the tree.

They once again broke apart, Valen attempting to swallow down the lump that had formed in his throat, but it was wedged firm.

"I'm not going to let her make me leave," Sienna said with conviction.

"Let's not worry about that right now," Valen dismissed, the hand on her cheek moving to tuck some of her hair behind an ear.

Indeed, the sound of wicked snickering from down below had their worries switching gears exceptionally fast.

"Hellspawn and the whore sittin' in a tree," One of the bullies, the tall bulbous one, chided.

"K-I-S S-I-N-G!" The other lackey hooted raucously.

"Shit!" Valen gasped as his entire world crashed all around. How did he not hear them, or see them, or—

"Shut up," the eln scolded his henchmen with a shove. He glowered up at Valen and Sienna with a chilling glint in his eyes. "Get down from there now."

Sienna and Valen gawked at each other, fear now substituting their bliss.

"Stay up here," Valen told her, to which Sienna whimpered.

"No—"

"It's okay," he whispered, squeezing her hand. He channeled more confidence than he truly felt into the words.

"I'm not gonna tell you again!" The eln barked as his goons guffawed.

Valen hefted his father's cloak; how many monsters had it witnessed, how many times had it seen his father be brave? Hopefully, this would be another success under its tally.

He didn't risk himself climbing down, he instead jumped past them, but not without summoning a quick illusion of inky shadow exploding in front of the boys. They all cursed and yelled as they swatted at the darkness.

Valen hadn't even known he was capable of such a spell, but he didn't have time to linger in his newfound trick. As the fog rapidly dispersed, he shakily retrieved the spell slinger from its holster, the steel cumbersome as he fussed with it.

He managed to point it right at the trio, who had yet to even turn around to see him properly. The control bestowed him a scrap of confidence.

"Behind you," he snarled with a touch of sass, relishing where he could.

The group swung around, ready for fisticuffs until they saw the spell slinger pointed directly at them.

"What the fuck, demon!" The eln spat, the other lowlifes bemoaning similar.

"Leave us alone," Valen commanded with a thrash of his tail.

"Or else what? You *really* gonna shoot us?" The eln chastided. "For what? We haven't even done nothing to you!"

"You've done more than enough," Valen growled, indignation supplying his confidence further. "Get out of here!"

"You don't even know how to shoot that thing!" the head bully goaded. "Even if you do, I've watched you. You're way too soft!"

The bully's gall to call his bluff made him wish he could just shoot to prove a point, but the eln *wasn't* wrong. He wasn't positive he *could* fire the weapon, and in the end he really, *really* did not want to. Infuriatingly, the eln already seemed to know that.

...Or perhaps he just *acted* like he did. 'Two can play at that game.'

"You really wanna find out?" Valen challenged, to which the posse argued amongst themselves.

"Darthin, it's not worth it, man!" One complained.

"I'm not getting shot today!" The other cried, and indeed began to scamper off, spurring the other into following.

"W-where are you going?!" The eln, Darthin apparently, howled. "You clowns, he's just bluffing!"

"Forget it, Darth! You can get shot!"

The leader seethed and cursed, but it was a lot less intimidating when he had no back up. A rock came spiraling down from the tree and clobbered him right in the shin, promoting his griping into pain.

“Get out of here!” Sienna shrieked, already poised to throw another stone. “We’re not afraid of you!”

Darthin roared with frustration and set after the others. Valen lowered the weapon as the teenager fled, hardly believing his eyes. It had worked! He holstered the gun, stupefied.

“Valen!” Sienna called and he looked up to her, them sharing in a look of shock and awe.

The girl started her climb down, Valen stepping up to the base of the tree to help her. As soon as she reached the ground they embraced in a tight hug, their disbelief flowing out of them as laughter. When they broke apart, he was leaning in to kiss her again, but her eyes went wide at something behind him.

“Valen, look out—”

Her warning came right as he noticed the rapidly approaching footsteps, but it was too late.

A swift impact crunched into the back of his knees, immediately buckling him with pain. He was yanked to the side, where his arms were forced behind his back. .

Their antagonists were back for round two.

“Looks like you blew your load too early!” The bully restraining him sneered.

The other lackey stepped up to yank his spell slinger off the holster and chuck it into the grass unceremoniously. “Not so tough now, are ya!” He taunted, punching him square in the jaw.

Sienna was screaming at them to stop, but then her cries were cut off abruptly.

Valen squinted against the swelling and pain to see Darthin grabbing her, the demorin’s heart plummeting as he realized the eln was pressing a knife against her. His other hand was over her mouth, concealing her protests.

“Now that we’re all here, we can *finally* talk!” The delinquent growled. “We told you not to snitch, but what did you do? Now we gotta do this the hard way.” He gestured with his head to Valen. “Greg, Craig, you better hang on to him. He’s not gonna like watching this.”

Valen desperately struggled as the second brute seized his other arm, but he was no match for their combined might.

Darthin’s glare seared into Valen. “You could have left your little whore out of this, but you just couldn’t help yourself, could you? Well, now you’re gonna see what happens when filth like you doesn’t stay in their place.”

The eln set his ire back on Sienna, who whimpered against his palm and shook her head, pleading.

“Don’t hurt her!” Valen yowled, his assailants both kicking him back into pained silence.

“Oh, she’ll probably enjoy it,” Darthin chuckled hauntingly. “Being the whore she is.”

The eln began cutting away her top with his knife, Sienna’s muffled protests turning desperate and frenzied.

It awoke something primal and innate in his core, blazing into existence with unmatched fervor. His very blood flashed white hot as his runa built pressure, so torrid his irises radiated with the surge. It came to a head with an awesome explosion within him, the power releasing like lightning.

Darthin’s whole body began to tremble and convulse, the eln rattling out a cry. Sienna squirmed her way free, but she did not run, her eyes darting across her assailant with bewilderment.

“W-W-What the fuck!” The two restraining him sputtered in unison, dropping Valen at once.

“Run!” Valen managed to croak out to Sienna, his hold on the spell slipping away alarmingly fast. The demand was arduous and far more voracious than any magic he had casted before.

She pushed her way past the seizing eln and did as she was told, sobbing. “I’ll get help!”

It wasn’t until she was yards away that he finally surrendered to the might of his exertion. The spell fizzled out with one last terrible oscillation, Darthin gasping and groaning in the aftermath.

His lackeys ran up to their master, fretful. “Darth, are you okay?!”

Valen attempted to push to his feet, but his limbs were jelly. He laid on the grass, his ears ringing and his whole body buzzing.

“You miserable piece of rotting shit!” Darthin bellowed, pouncing forward to kick at the demorin’s ribs.

Valen cried out, his nerves already on fire.

The other bullies hesitated before joining the beat down, Valen too drained to activate the bracers, or even shield himself mundanely.

Darthin yanked on his cowl to pull him to his feet. "You are going to pay for that, hellspawn!" He shoved him, Valen stumbling back like a newborn fawn. As he fell to the floor again, Darthin crawled on top of him, brandishing his knife.

The stab punctured his abdomen, the agony unlike anything Valen had ever felt. He opened his mouth to yell, only for nothing but a squeak to come out.

The lackeys panicked and pulled their leader off before he could get another stab in.

"Holy shit, Darth, stop! He said *don't* kill him!"

"Get the hell off of me!" The eln hollered, shoving them away.

The faint sound of a siren approaching was Valen's saving grace yet again, but this time it was no illusion.

"Go back to hell!" Darthin growled, spitting at him before fleeing with his grunts in toe.

Valen's vision was blurring as he laid there, every pulse of blood carrying him further into the fog. He groaned, his hands trembling as he weakly grasped at his wound, staining his father's cloak black with blood.

His mind fluttered like a panicked bird in a cage, throwing itself against the bars at the cost of its feathers. He thought about his Dad, his Mom, Karreo... He began to weep, fearing help would be too late.

Hurried steps finally came, but he barely had the wherewithal to notice. He closed his eyes, giving himself up to the mist, too tired and battered to fight it any longer.

Chapter 14

Avino

"It's a good thing you called when you did," the officer said from his paperwork with a tap of his pen. "Because we were already en route, we were able to get there before he lost too much blood."

That should have comforted the father, but the hole in his chest only yawned the wider. Surely an officer would have been patrolling close enough that Sienna could have tagged them down? Surely someone in town would have heard or seen the conflict and reported it, too? *Surely* it wasn't only *their* intervention that saved their son?

He stewed in silence, his tail swiping to and fro, as the cop finished his legalities.

"It's terrible what those kids did. Just *terrible*. To think that our little town could have something like this happen is preposterous," one of the desk workers commented.

Avino gave a stony nod. It was preposterous it was allowed to happen, indeed.

The officer clicked his pen closed. "Well, uh, I think I got everything I needed from ya. Before you head out, though, the chief wanted to see you."

Avino couldn't say he wanted to deal with more cops, but he did have half the mind to lash out at Carmella. He followed the officer back and they knocked on her door.

"Come in." Chief Sarpani's curt reply was immediate.

The officer left them alone with a tip of his hat. The air was stiff as Avino stared at the accolades up on the wall, rewards and certifications, honors and promises...

"Avino, I'm... sorry it came down to this," The chief began, clearing her throat. "I'm frankly astonished. I would have never thought it would resort to this level. Usually, when kids—"

"What do you need from me?" Avino cut her off, having no patience for excuses.

"I understand you're upset. But, we have more than enough to send these kids off to juvie now. They won't be hurting your family anymore."

"You caught them, then?" Last Avino heard through the radio chatter, the boys were still at large.

"Several of my guys are in pursuit, and they have nowhere to run."

"Where are they, then, Carmella?" Avino challenged, his tone calm but only by a hair of restraint.

The chief stared at him for a loaded second before fetching her radio from her belt. She flipped it on with a whirl of static.

"Status report on the perps, over?"

"Yeah, uh, Chief, it's... It's really bizarre... ...Over."

"Elaborate, deputy, over."

"We had them cornered and surrounded, but when we rounded the corner to nail 'em, they were... uh..."

The line went silent.

"They were *what*, deputy?! Spit it out! Over."

"...They were gone. We... lost visual. Over."

The Chief balked at the news and Avino's fists clenched.

"So to confirm, you *lost* the subjects? Over."

Avino couldn't believe what he was hearing.

"It makes no sense! It was a dead end, but they just... vanished. Over."

Avino went to stomp out of the room, but Carmella barked at him to wait.

"Keep looking. These kids clearly don't know magic, they have to be *somewhere*. Over and out." She slammed her walkie down and sized Avino with frustration.

"Look, we're not going to let them get away. Just give us time."

Avino really, *really* did not want to hear it. "Carmella, with all due respect, I'll believe it when they're behind bars."

He again tried to leave, and she again ordered him to wait.

"That's not why I asked to see you," she said to his back. "I have something that belongs to you."

He turned around with a tilt of his head, and she was holding out his spell slinger. The sight was a curveball.

"We confiscated this at the scene. The safety was still on."

Avino endeavored to process the development as he received his firearm. He studied the shape, color, and blemishes he knew to be there; it was no doubt that it was his.

“Valen *really* shouldn’t have been carrying that without a permit, but we didn’t see anything. Let’s keep it that way.”

Avino replaced the gun into its holster with a grimace. “That’s the least you can do, right?”

The chief sighed. “We’re going to put an end to this, Avino.”

The father was done listening. “If you’ll *excuse* me, I need to go be with my son.”

He once again turned to leave, and she finally let him go.

—

Karreo

The rhythmic beeping of the heart monitor kept time as Karreo sat in the corner of the hospital room, his eyes rarely leaving his sleeping sibling.

His brother had a few broken ribs and suffered a serious stab wound, amongst generalized bruising. Sweat beaded his brow and his breathing was shallow, but he was stable.

His mother was anchored next to the gurney, humming softly as she ran a hand through Valen’s hair.

The doctors had rushed him into urgent surgery the night before. The knife had hit his small intestine, which was far from ideal, but luckily the damage was not catastrophic. The area was stitched and heavily bandaged now; the nurses were frequently redressing it to keep it as sterile as possible.

When Valen had come-to earlier that morning, the doctors had discussed treatment options with the family.

“It’s a nasty spot for a stab wound,” the doctor had explained. “I recommend biomanipulative intervention to heal it over, to mitigate the chance for infection. That, and you can get back to normal far quicker. A boy your age doesn’t want to be slowed down for long.”

Valen had appeared nervous, but still agreed.

“First, you’ll have to regain some of your strength. Ideally, we want you to be as stable as possible before we intervene. We’ll give you the day to rest, and depending on, we’ll do the procedure tomorrow morning. We’ll fix your broken ribs then, too.”

His brother had been mostly sleeping the time away, drowsy from all the medicine and physical trauma. The big question on what exactly happened the night before had yet to be answered, as Valen was too fatigued to properly drill.

Their father had shooed off a cop that came by to ask Valen for his statement. "He needs to rest. Come back later."

"Fine, but we can't delay too long," the officer had said. "I'll be back later today."

It was nearing noon when his father walked into the room bearing a tray of hospital food. He put it on the bedside table. "It's not the Skipping Rock, but it'll do."

"Aw, thank you, love," his mother murmured. "I'm starving..."

They switched spots so she could eat. His father lightly ruffled Valen's hair as he took his seat, who stirred with a groan before forcing an eye open.

"Hey, Dad..." he croaked, horse and tired.

"Hey there, son. How are you feeling?"

"Buh... really, really tired..." That was evident by the way his words slurred.

The older demorin warmly grinned. "Just get some rest. We need you strong for the procedure tomorrow."

Valen was already falling back asleep, needing no such blessing.

His father turned his attention to Karreo. "How are you holding up, son? You should eat something."

Karreos shoulders barely bumped with a shrug. He couldn't say he was hungry, but it *had* been awhile since he last ate.

His father reached out to touch his arm. "I'm so glad you came to us last night, Karri... I don't know what would have happened if you didn't."

Karreos dropped his gaze to his knees. He'd heard his father and mother chatting about what the officers said, how because of their tip, the police were already on their way to help. Had he really helped save Valen from further injury... or worse?

It overwhelmed him to recall how he had almost kept his mouth shut, thinking it the respectable thing to do for his brother. Thankfully, worry had outclassed honor, or things would have played out much differently.

He did not reply to his father, who chuckled at his silence and patted his back. "You're a good lad. Make sure you eat and get some rest."

He grabbed an apple from the tray, mostly to placate his parent. It was no peach, but it was better than a hollow belly.

After lunch, Karreo was attempting to snooze on the pull-out cot when his parents began to talk hushedly. They probably assumed that he was already asleep, and he wasn't about to correct them, for it meant less coding and more candidity.

"Did you get a hold of your sister?" His father asked his mother.

"Yeah... she's mortified for us. Told us to come up as soon as Valen is discharged."

"It will be good to get out of here for a while..." There was a long sigh from his father. "I never expected to feel unsafe in this town."

"Me neither, Vin..." his mother matched the melancholy. "Hopefully these thugs will be caught by the time we come back, otherwise... Ugh, I don't know..."

"Let's just take things a step at a time. We'll make our way up to Sengard and visit with your family while things cool down."

They were going to Sengard to see Aunt Lucia? Karreo wasn't sure how to feel about that; it certainly wasn't ideal circumstances to have a holiday, but a vacation was still a vacation. They hadn't been to Sengard for a few years; it would be interesting if nothing else to go back.

"I'll get those tickets ordered, then," his mother said. "Lucy said she'll help foot the bill. Those last minute airline tickets aren't cheap."

"Well, let's wait for Valen's procedure to get done first. Just in case there's complications."

"You're right. Guess I'm just antsy..."

"You and me both..."

A few minutes of silence followed, the room quiet but for the equipment chatter.

"I talked with Terra earlier..." His mother began again. "Sienna is... well, she's traumatized, the poor thing. But Terra says she's unharmed, at least."

"Has Sienna said what happened?" His father wondered.

"She said they were jumped at the park. Apparently, Valen had chased them off at first, but then they came back with a vengeance. She... she wasn't around for the worst of it. She says Valen did some sort of spell and it let her get away, then she ran to get help..."

"A spell?" There was intrigue in the fathers tone.

"Yeah, but not like he usually pulls," she clarified. "Said it seized the boy up, made him unable to move. Sienna said it sounded like he was in pain, too."

Karreo couldn't see his father, but he could assume he was considering that information with that look he always got when pensive.

"They want to come by when Valen is feeling up for it," his mother went on.

"...Did she mention Miana at all?"

His mother sighed, then very quietly said "yeah... She's panicked, but I... I get it. She said she won't let them stay with her at the townhouse anymore. They're heading back to Akarth tomorrow..."

"That's... that's probably for the best. Poor kids, though... What an unfortunate start to romance..."

"Yeah... I hope he takes the news okay."

Karreo imagined they were both staring at his brother now.

Another lengthy pause passed, then: "He took the spell slinger last night."

"What?" his mother hissed, stupefied.

Karreo knew that, but it still shocked him, too.

"It wasn't ever fired. The safety was on, and the barrel was still dusty inside."

"...Huh. That's how he scared them off, I bet."

"Carmella said they'll look the other way, so he's not in trouble. Well, with the law, at least."

The parents chuckled between themselves, but it fizzled out into more sighing.

“Oh, Vivie... I’m just so relieved he’s safe.”

“Me, too, love. Me, too.”

Chapter 15

Valen

It wasn’t until evening that he was finally able to keep his eyes open. The same agony that had hounded him in his restless dreams was there to bitterly welcome him back into consciousness. His whole body was terribly swollen and tense, and his breathing was restricted by both bandage and pain. His head pounded, his abdomen was burning, his ribs were protesting with every inhale—

But he was *alive*.

Another dose of a powerful painkiller made everything more bearable, albeit at the cost of mental fortitude and drowsiness. It was worth the handicap, even though he was teetering on the edge of clarity and where-with-all.

His father mentioned the police were itching for a statement, but he wanted Valen to run down events to the family first. Thus began his tale through ashamed fidgeting and nervous mumbles.

He explained that he’d received a letter from Sienna, and he went because he didn’t want her to get hurt.

“Why didn’t you just tell your mother and I?” His father had pressed.

It hadn’t even occurred to him as an option at the time. Of course, it seemed so obvious now. But, even so, he hadn’t wanted her to get in trouble or betray her trust, either.

“Why did you take the spell slinger?” His father’s next question came.

“I... I wanted us to be safe.”

“So you brought a weapon you have no experience with?”

The shame was more constricting than his tightly wound bandages. "It was a foolish idea. I'm... I'm sorry, Dad..."

"It was foolish, yes. But, at least you didn't fire it. You could have gotten into a lot of trouble, or worse."

"We'll discuss that more later," his mother had cut in. "For now, keep going. What happened when you got into town?"

He explained how they had met up, and it was fine until it wasn't. He'd managed to scare them off with the spell slinger, but then they caught him flat footed. He was restrained, and the eln was going to... really hurt Sienna, but then he was able to stop him with a new spell.

"This spell, describe it," his father had interrupted.

"I don't know... It's all kind of a haze when I look back on it. The eln froze up when I casted it, and it was really, really tiring. I couldn't hold it for long, but luckily Sienna was able to get away."

"Sounds like a seize spell," his father had replied. "That's... pretty high level magic, son. No wonder it took a lot out of you."

"Yeah, I couldn't even stand after it... Or activate the bracers. Which is why.. Well..." He had gestured broadly to himself. "They overpowered me easily, and that's when the eln... stabbed me. Then we heard sirens, and they all ran off..."

"You can thank your brother for that," his mother had mentioned. "He told us you were in trouble, and we were able to tip off the police."

He had looked over to his little brother, who seemed guilty despite the praise. "Really? How... did you know?"

Karreo hadn't offered an answer, just a meager shrug.

"Well... thanks, Karri..." He'd still been curious, but other questions burned hotter. "Where is Sienna? Is she safe?"

"Yes, she's at home with her family. She's been asking about you, too. They said they'd come by after you came to," his mother had said. "But first, let's get your statement done."

He'd been instructed by his father to not go into specifics on the spell to the officer, just that it had let Sienna get away. "I don't want the police creating trouble on you doing magic beyond your permit level," he had elaborated quietly. "Just tell the half truth, that it's really hazy and you don't remember well."

He did just that when the officer came by. He explained things in broad strokes with loose details, hoping that his nervous demeanor as he spoke was expectant and not suspicious. When the officer asked for further elaboration on the spell, he was too foggy to recall correctly.

The deputy had everything he needed after a good half hour of drilling. However, he had some troubling news before he took his leave.

"The perps are still at large," he'd revealed. "But we're going to find them, don't you worry."

It was enough to make him far dizzier than the drugs had. If they were still out there, they could still hurt Sienna!

Thus, he was antsier than ever to see her. Finally, that night, he got the chance.

He was almost asleep again when the nurse poked her head in to ask if he was accepting visitors. He was awake in an instant, blurting out "yes" before he could even think.

Sienna and her mother stepped inside the room, shuffling past the medical equipment bearing flowers and apologetic grins. Sienna's expression was immediately ruptured as they met each other's eyes, leaving behind a quivering lip.

"Valen..." she gasped through a sob as she arrived at his bedside. "Oh gods... I... I'm so sorry!"

"Sienna, please, it's okay," he attempted to ease, extending his hand to grab hers. "I'm just... I'm just so relieved you're safe."

"I shouldn't have asked you to come," Sienna hiccuped. "I-I shouldn't've—"

"Shhh," Valen soothed, desperate to relieve her of the regret. "It's okay. *We're* okay."

She cried and cried. His heart splintered, wishing he could just embrace her, but his battered body was unable. Instead, he stroked her hand and forearm, his own eyes growing misty as clouds of shame, relief, fear, and longing swirled within him. It culminated into a clap of thunder, and he pressed his head against her as the rain began to fall.

As they comforted one another, he spotted his family and Miss Picano slip outside the curtain to hushedly talk. He couldn't make it out, but he had little mind to. All he could think about was how they were both safe, despite it all.

Eventually the storm passed, and they both wiped their eyes in sniffly silence.

"I'm.... going back to the city. She... she's making me leave tomorrow morning," Sienna shared in a murmur.

It was harrowing news, but not unexpected. He squeezed her hand as more dark clouds gathered.

"It's... for the best," he forced out. "You'll be safe there." He knew it was so, but it still hurt terribly.

They searched each other's shimmering eyes, finding nothing but defeat and sorrow.

"Maybe... maybe next summer will be better?" She wagered weakly.

"Maybe..." Valen replied, but his gut told him differently.

Sienna leaned forward to touch their foreheads together, the health monitor broadcasting his heartache with every quickend beep.

"I'll miss you," she whispered into his cheek, her voice thick with another threatening volley of tears.

"I'm... I'm going to miss you, too," he said through a shuddering gasp.

Their lips came together in a fleeting kiss, like chasing the wisp of a summer evening's breeze. The wind fizzled out and she wrapped her arms around him in an embrace, the protesting from his ribs of little detriment.

They lingered there for a long moment, but it still wasn't enough time.

"We'll see each other again," he told her as they pulled apart, keeping his hand around hers, daring to hope against despair.

She grinned, sad and wistful. "I hope so..." She looked to her feet, her breath fighting the crest of another sob. Their hands unlaced and she offered him one last honey gaze, her irises twinkling from supernovas of broken fantasies. "Goodbye, Valen."

His hand furred, empty and hollow without hers. "Goodbye, Sienna..."

She left as another bawl rocked her shoulders, her composure crumbling as she ducked through the curtain and beyond.

Valen's own sobs overcame him as he was left alone, his entire being quaking from misery both bodily and emotional. There was no painkiller for the agony this time.

Chapter 16

Avino

They all opted to give Valen and Sienna some privacy and to talk amongst themselves just outside the curtain.

“The poor dears...” Terra lamented after sharing the news of their planned return to Akarth. “It’s so unfair, isn’t it...”

“It’s terrible...” Vivvie agreed. “You’re not the only ones leaving town. We’re going to stay with my sister after Valen heals up.”

Terra was relieved to hear it. “Do keep in touch. I’d hate for this to be the end of our families seeing each other.”

They assured her it wouldn’t be when Sienna burst from the curtain, flooded with tears. It sunk Avino’s heart to see her so distraught; it was all so unfair, indeed.

Valen wasn’t faring much better. They slipped back into the room to find him battling his own sobs. Vivianna rushed to comfort him, taking him into her arms as much as their son’s injuries would allow.

Avino grabbed his hand and offered his own console. “Just let it out, son.”

Karreo lingered on the cot, saddened by his brother’s sorrow, but seemingly unsure of how to help him. Avino had made sure to visit his other son, too, offering a rub on his back and a gentle tuck of his hair. Karreo received his affection with a little sigh; the father could tell the situation was weighing on him, too.

It was nearing bedtime when the medic came in. “Everything is looking good for the procedure. Just get some good sleep, and we’ll patch you back up first thing tomorrow morning.”

“I’ll stay here with him,” Vivianna told Avino. “You and Karreo, go get some rest, yourselves.”

Avino had retired to his bed, glaring at the shadows cast upon the walls from the lamp he refused to turn off. Karreo was nestled into him, and only by sheer exhaustion did Avino slip into slumber. Still, he had woken up often, spooked by the house creaking or the wind pawing at the window.

Morning did eventually come without strife. They arrived back at the hospital in time to see Valen before his procedure. His son was clearly very anxious, and Avino had a sneaking suspicion as to why.

“Don’t be too nervous. This is nothing like what happened with my leg,” he told his son. “A professional biomanipulist will be doing the spell and keeping a close eye, it’s *much* safer and quicker than letting your body deal with the injuries on its own.”

“It’ll hurt like hell, but it’s worth it, trust us. We’ve had *hundreds* of healing spells cast on us before; what happened to your dad was a bit of a freak accident. You’re going to be fine.” Vivie had encouraged him, too

As the doctors wheeled him away, Avino saw his son off with one last assurance. “Good luck, Valen.”

Valen

The drugs had him dopey and drowsy as the medic strapped him to the gurney. He was laying on his back, the beep of the vitals machine chirping slowly, as though a bored bird. That comparison made Valen snicker despite his injuries, but the pain was curiously dull.

The biomanipulist proceeded to buckle him in with an almost humorous amount of belts. “It’s important you don’t move as I work,” the biomanipulist explained, his voice sounding far away. “Less chance of complications that way.”

Valen continued to giggle, lacking the where-with-all for the anxiety that had him so nervous earlier. “Okey-dokey...”

The medic at last fastened the final strap. “Are you comfortable?”

Valen’s giggling turned to laughter. “As comfortable as I can be in binds.”

“Heh, good. Take a deep breath, try to relax your breathing.”

Valen stifled his stoned amusement, albeit after a couple more snorts.

The mage took a seat next to the bed; he was saying something to one of the attendants, but it was sloshy and warbled. There was some shuffling as people moved into position, Valen’s eyes closing as their moving forms made him dizzy.

“Are you ready?” The biomanipulist asked him, to which Valen sleepily nodded.

He opened an eye to peep at the mage hovering his hands over the injury, which was exposed and free of gauze, glistening with medicine.

“I’ll start slow,” the medic said. “You’re going to feel some discomfort.”

Valen flopped his head in a nod, his skull feeling heavy. “Gotcha...”

A light blue aura enveloped the medic’s hands, Valen’s wound responding with its own shimmer. Pressure rapidly built in his torso and painful stimuli followed it, like a wave violently striking the shore. He cried out and attempted to arch away from the pain, but the binds restricted his movement.

The torture had the tweeting of the machine frantic.

“Easy...” the medic cooed, contrastingly calm. The aura built in intensity, the pain augmenting along with it.

The wound was white-hot and alive with static as the biomanipulist worked, howling with agony all the while. The demorin’s squirming ceased, but not from any kind of relief; he was too overcome with affliction to move.

It went on for too painstakingly long. Valen was wet with sweat and whimpering when the blue aura at last faded, the ghost of the anguish dispersing like smoke after an explosion. The teen craned his neck to look down at his injury; it was now a scar laced with a faint, silvery sheen.

The biomanipulist investigated the scar and pushed on his ribs, Valen jumping as he expected pain, but it was a false alarm. He allowed himself to relax, awash in disbelief, as the mage proceeded his prodding.

The medic gave a satisfactory nod. “That should do it! How does it feel?”

“...Ahm.” Valen’s drugged mind stumbled for words. “...Better...!”

“The procedure was a success, then,” the medic chimed. The medical team set to unstrapping him, Valen still reeling from it all. “You’re all healed.”

Much easier than healing the mundane way, indeed.

Valen had been sleeping off the drugs when he awoke to a nurse fiddling with his hook-ups. “How are you feeling?”

“Urg... a bit nauseous, but... a lot better...”

“That’s normal. It will pass; the worst of it is over!”

The medic returned after Valen was able to keep awake. “Since we completely healed it over, you’re cleared to eat whatever you want now. No more IV nutrients! Which is good news, as you’re going to be *hungry*. Biomanipulative spells burn a lot of calories.”

Indeed, his stomach was gurgling from more than just queasiness.

“You don’t have to do anything special to care for the site, as it’s done healing. We’ll get you sprung and you can get out of here!”

He was freed from his IV and his father was filling out discharge paperwork when Karreo plopped down on the cot next to him.

“Can I tell him?” Karreo asked.

“Go for it,” his mother nodded. She handed Valen a bag of his clothes and stepped outside so he could get out of his hospital gown.

Valen looked at his brother expectantly, warily curious in whatever he had to say.

“We’re going to Sengard!” Karreo shared through a growing grin. “We’re gonna go stay with Aunt Lucia for awhile!”

Valen processed that news with a hybrid of emotions. He opened his mouth to speak, but no words cooperated.

“Those kids are still at large,” his father mentioned from his clipboard. “We figure getting out of town for a bit will be safer, and it will be nice to get away.”

Considering the pit in his guts at hearing they were still out there, and the gnawing heartache of saying goodbye to his summer love, Valen had to agree that it would be better to leave Riverview for a while.

“Now that you’re all healed, we plan to leave tomorrow,” his father said. “Let’s get home and get packed.”

The effort of packing had taken a lot out of him; although his injuries were healed, the exhaustion remained persistent. He’d devoured dinner by the insistence of his belly and collapsed into bed, his blankets and pillows welcoming him back with sweet whispers of comfort.

He closed his eyes and fell into a deep sleep, too drained for melancholy and wistfulness. After all, his troubles would still be there in the morning.

For now, he slept.

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Chapter 17

Avino

They were all ready for their trip tomorrow. Their aircraft would be departing in the evening, which would give them plenty of time to get into the city and prepare for their flight.

The family had all retired to bed early except Avino, who had been too restless for such. He had encouraged his wife to go and catch up on her sleep, and that he would come to bed after some reflection.

She had accepted and left him a goodnight kiss before heading to their bedroom. “We have a big day tomorrow. Don’t be up too late.”

Avino was attempting to distract himself with a book when he heard an engine rumbling outside. It immediately bristled his neck, the madness of the last week rendering him hyper vigilant. His hand went to the holster on his belt, hovering over his spell slinger as he glowered through the window.

Thadius Ives, the man from the Clawed Fist, stepped out of a black vehicle. He arrived at the door and extended his knuckle out to knock, and Avino didn’t keep him waiting.

“Ah, Avino, so sorry to intrude at this hour! But it’s for good reason, I assure you.” Thad greeted as Avino stepped outside, shutting the door.

“What is it?” Avino had little patience for polite reservations; he was too on edge to entertain a guest.

“I heard about what happened to your son. How are you all doing?”

Avino sucked in a fractious breath. “Could this not have been over the phone, Thadius?”

“Oh, there’s a reason I’m here. First, is it true that the police have yet to capture these delinquents?”

Avino's head jerked in a stony nod. His latest check-in with the police had provided nothing but more excuses and hollow promises. '*We can't be out of town fast enough.*'

Thadius tsked, appearing bothered but unsurprised. "It would not be the first case law enforcement botched for our people. Nor will it be the last. But, that's all of little matter now."

Avino narrowed his eyes at the fellow demorin, lacking any appetite for the theatrics. "What?"

"We've managed to do what they could not," Thadius said matter-of-factly. "Come, I have something to show you."

Avino balked at what he was suggesting. "What? Now?" What did he mean by 'doing what they could not'?

"Indeed, now. So sorry to spring it on you, but time is sensitive."

Avino glanced to the door behind him, his tail ticking as he processed the request. "Where are we going?" He muttered when he turned back around.

"To a private location where the police will not intervene." Thad answered, cool despite the suspicion of it.

Avino was even more guarded now. "Why would the police need to not be involved?"

"Well, they've done naught but fumble the situation thus far. We wouldn't want them messing up this recent development."

"And what development is that?" Avino grunted.

"I've tracked down where the leader of these delinquents is hiding out," Thad shared, uncharacteristically candid.

Avino gawked at Thadius as the fellow demorin kept on.

"Now, you can come with me and face this situation yourself, orrr leave it to law enforcement. However, from what I hear, that *might* not be the wisest plan, as your boy could be in trouble with casting magic well beyond his permit level. Let alone *offensive* magic, when no physical violence had yet been committed."

Avino despised how much sense he made. The other demorin was voicing the very issues the father was so worried over. Valen had too bright of a future to be legally reprimanded, too much potential to be stifled by the government barring his training. His son had acted in defense, but would the law see it that way? It was a gamble Avino did not want to roll.

“So you found this boy?” The father backtracked, his voice low.

Thadius nodded before gesturing to his vehicle. “Come, let us put an end to this terrible situation.”

Avino weighed his options with a heavy brow. He was confident he could scare the kid out of town, especially if he spun it so that the police would not be involved.

“Give me a moment,” the father grunted, to which Thadius dipped his head.

“Don’t be long, *kin toh vi* (my brother).”

Avino stepped back inside to prepare. Part of him was incredulous and betrayed he was going along with the vigilante plan, but necessity and fatherly instinct overshadowed all. He *had* to protect his family; if that meant taking justice into his own claws, he would step up and do what had to be done.

Afterall, the law had thus handled the situation poorly, and he did not trust them to resolve what had proven to be an exceptionally sensitive situation.

He went down to the laundry room to collect his cloak. Valen’s blood had been washed away, but the metaphorical stain remained. He suited up, the routine igniting an old engine that had long laid dormant.

He spared his reflection a glance, his old adventuring self staring back. He nodded in determination before setting up the steps, his confidence suppressing his limp.

He left a note on the counter in case anyone awoke to his absence. He thought about waking his wife, but did not want to disturb her much-needed rest. That, and, deep down, he didn’t want anyone talking him out of his decision.

‘I’ll be back. I’m taking care of this.’ He wrote, vague so as to not incriminate himself in case the police *did* involve themselves.

With that, he met Thad outside, armored with determination. “Let’s go.”

Karreo

Excitement for the coming trip had Karreo’s young mind wound tight. He had given up on sleep and was reading a book when he heard the front door open.

He knew his father was still in the living room, which eased his worry about any potential threats. Nosy as ever, he slunk out into the hall and went to discover what was happening.

The living room was empty, the book his father had been reading put face down, implying he was planning to return to it. Hushed talking could be heard from just outside the door, sounding still in mid-conversation. Karreo recognized his parent's voice, but not the other.

He cranked his ears and crept as close as he dared to the door, leaving himself a buffer if he had to flee. It was muddled, but he could barely make out some words. His father was talking to a man, who... managed to do something 'they' could not? Something about not wanting the cops involved?

The bombshell that this man knew where the perp was hiding was a massive one. Just who was this man?

The conversation became too hushed to make out. Before long, Karreo recognized the conversation was wrapping up by their tone and he hid accordingly, wedging himself behind the couch. Karreo heard his father come back inside and head downstairs, where he stayed for a couple minutes.

Karreo dared himself to peek out the window, spotting a vehicle in their driveway and a man on their stoop. He was a demorin, and his attention was on a portable responder in his hands. The demorin lifted the phone to his ear and began hushedly talking at a volume too low to parse. Karreo watched the man's lips, but lip reading was not his strongest suit, regrettably. He had a long way to go before he was on Detective Case's level.

"Coming" and "Location" were all he could decipher before the demorin turned away from his view. The call was very brief, as the man was already pocketing the responder.

Karreo had a theory on who this stranger was. His parents had previously mentioned someone from an organization stopping by and giving them a pamphlet, and when Karreo had rifled through the mail upon hearing that, he'd found said brochure. The 'Clawed Fist' were what they called themselves, a group that specialized in helping Pyrothian kind.

Considering the man was a demorin, it made sense to Karreo that's who was on their doorstep. Did that mean the Clawed Fist was helping them find the perps?

His father arrived back upstairs, pausing in the kitchen to shuffle with something. Paper, it sounded like. His father then approached the front door, and Karreo squeezed his eyes shut, his hiding spot suddenly not feeling very adequate.

However, he was not caught, as his father opened the door and set out, none the wiser of his onlooker. The car in the driveway started and Karreo risked himself a peek out the window, seeing his father in the passenger seat as the car drove away.

Karreo scampered off to see what his father had been doing in the kitchen, finding a note.

His father was going to confront the perp?!

He marveled at his parent's bravery, but worry bubbled in his belly. What if he got hurt, too?

His father had what Valen didn't, however: experience.

Karreo planted himself on the couch, anxious for his father's return. Frustratingly, his eyes became harder and harder to keep open, while the couch cushions became more and more cozy.

He succumbed to sleep, but not without a fight.

Chapter 18

Avino

Thadius drove them outside of Riverview's limits, towards the city. The car was quiet as Avino steeled himself for confrontation, his eyes closed as he pondered how to handle the incoming situation.

He had no plans to actually *hurt* the boy, but the kid didn't have to know that. Avino's goal was to scare him and drive him out of town, with a promise of retribution if he showed his face again.

"I do regret that your family had to face such hardship," Thadius broke the quiet. "The world we live in can be so disappointing at times. Which is why my organization endeavors for a world where this will never happen."

Avino didn't fancy himself much chatter, but the loftiness of the claim had him shooting a skeptical look at the demorin. "And how do you plan on doing that?"

"Oh, we work in many, many different ways," Thadius answered without skipping a beat. "Politics, charity..." The demorin then smirked, gesturing broadly to the vehicle. "Vigilante work."

Avino gave a wry grin. "And how is that going for you?"

"We've only just begun in recent years. There is much to be done to create a better world." Thad failed to answer.

Avino shook his head. He knew over-inflated promises and moving goal posts when he saw it. Even still... "Well, thank you for helping my family. It will be good to get closure."

"Ah, yes, of course, *palar vi* (my friend). We demorin must stick together to face this cruel world, hm?"

Avino sighed. Despite the violence they'd recently endured, he still believed the world as a whole was not as cruel as the Clawed Fist toted. He was careful not to agree, lest Thadius believe he'd indoctrinated him.

"How much further?" Avino changed the subject.

"Not too much longer now," Thadius promised. "They're hiding in an abandoned warehouse in Eastmont. The business district in general is run down, so we'll have plenty of... privacy."

Avino looked out the window to consider that. Eastmont was a neighboring town of Riverview, one that was... a tad rougher around the edges. It didn't surprise the demorin that the delinquent had taken refuge in a place more complacent with crime.

Avino hadn't set foot in Eastmont for years, but he was able to recognize the route they were on. If he remembered correctly, they were still a few minutes out, and so he closed his eyes again.

Thadius let him be, Avino thankful for the chance to bottle his moxie. The tense drive proceeded until at last they were driving through Eastmont's littered business district, underneath a spotlight of flickering lamps.

The demorin flipped up his hood, scowling against his nerves. They parked in a decrepit alley for cover, and set down the dirty backstreets on foot.

Thadius walked with his back too straight and his steps too careless. He didn't seem like he was attempting to obscure his presence much at all as the warehouse loomed just ahead.

"What's the plan?" Avino whispered as they went, and Thadius chuckled with no such volume reservations.

"No need for whispering. You'll find the situation is already under control," the demorin revealed.

Avino's brow wrinkled with confusion. "What... do you mean?"

"I've already done the hard part," Thadius elaborated, his fangs glinting in the ochre city light. "Come, let's not keep our *friend* waiting any longer, hm?"

Avino stared at the orange toned demorin, his gut rippling with uncertainty. Thadius had not been entirely truthful. "So you already caught him?"

"Indeed, *palar vi*. My gift to you!" Thad slapped him on the back with a hefty snicker, amused at Avino's perplexion. He proceeded his confident gait into the warehouse, Avino only following after another tense second of deliberation.

They arrived at the front doors, Thadius unlocking them before gesturing to Avino to walk inside.

The father merely stared as the check in his gut earned another tally.

Thadius shrugged and strolled inside, leaving it open behind him. Avino lingered in the doorway, unsure of what he was about to walk into.

He disbanded his apprehension with a thrash of his tail before marching inside. Whatever it was, he wanted to get it over with as soon as possible.

A massive, dimly illuminated room laid beyond, packed with rubble from the warehouse's past life. There were boxes, abandoned machinery, leaning shelving, and a scattering of trash.

Thadius walked ahead, Avino keeping up, albeit from a cautious distance.

"Relax, *kin toh vi*. *We're* the ones in control here."

They wound through the graveyard of commerce before they arrived at their destination.

A chair was amongst the clutter. Seated upon it was the teenage eln, gagged and bound, his face obstructed by a bag. Avino's stomach lurched as he realized how battered and beaten the kid was.

The chair was accompanied by a table, a plate of bloody tools atop it. Avino did not have to surmise what they were for.

Avino was aghast. Disgust roiling within him, he turned on the other demorin, enraged. "Thadius! *What is this?!*"

The eln jerked his chin at the disturbance, quivering violently as he pleaded against the gag.

Thadius lifted his palms in feigned appeasement, his expression satisfied and smug. “I understand you are surprised, *palar vi*. Take a moment to breathe.”

Avino’s mind was reeling. “*Surprised?! Thadius, this is not what you said!*”

“Is it not? I said I found the welp, and here he is.”

“You said nothing about– *this!*” Avino waved a hand around the room in furious disbelief.

“What did you expect? That we were going to give him a slap on the wrist and let him be on his merry way?” Thadius cursed in Pyrothian. “No, you *knew* why we came here. And you agreed.”

“I agreed to nothing of the sort!” Avino held, and it was no fib. He jabbed a finger at the eln. “I want *no part* in this!”

Thadius tsked. “You are too bound by fear of authority and misplaced compassion. I implore you to break those shackles, so you may get your revenge and assert your rightful dominance over this *filth*.”

Avino gawked at the demorin, too gobsmacked to compile words.

“*Kin toh vi*, you needn’t worry about legal repercussions, if that is what concerns you. My people have that covered! You are free to do what you *must* to return honor to your family. This one will surely regret looking down upon us!”

“Thadius, you are... this is...” Avino stammered, grappling hopelessly with consternation. “This is *madness*.”

“*Think* for a moment, Avino,” Thadius urged. “You have been presented with a golden opportunity. You can exact your due revenge, *and* solve this entire debacle! *Think* of what he did to your son! *Think* of the harm he will *continue* to do unless you take matters into your own hands. You are justified in this, this blight doesn’t deserve grace!”

“There are other ways, Thadius!” Avino rejected. “I *will not* let you torture this young man!”

Avino began hurriedly stepping towards the eln, who had whimpered and struggled against his binds their entire conflict.

Thadius stepped in front of Avino in an instant, far quicker than he. “My friend, my brother, *think*. If you release this one, your trouble has just begun. What did you come here to do?!”

“I plan to finish this!” Avino snarled. “*My way!*”

“Oh, so setting the runt free so he can spread more terror? If it’s not your family it will be someone else’s, Avino!”

“Move aside,” Avino commanded, but Thadius did not budge.

“You think yourself on some high horse, but it is actually your cell,” the other demorin said. “You have been conditioned to feel pity for your oppressors. Rise above that! Claim your dignity!”

“This is not about oppressors and pride!” Avino boomed. “This is about what’s *right!*”

“Right?” Thadius scoffed with a raucous laugh. “No, Avino Vaaskiir! What is ‘right’ has been decided by the rest of the world for far too long! *We* are the Arbiters now. *We* shall exact judgement!” Thadius’ tone was veering on fanatic, adding another layer to the chaos.

“Thadius, this is *lunacy*.” He channeled all of his conviction into his next words. “I’m ending it now.”

He once again moved to approach the chair, and Thadius uttered an incantation. With his peripherals, Avino spotted a magical, iridescent sword scored with runes of the destruction class manifest in the demorin’s hands.

“Touch him and this escalates, Vaaskiir.”

Avino froze at the threat. “Thadius, we *aren’t* enemies. This is just a huge misunderstanding,” he attempted to diffuse, slowly turning back around.

“How dare you insult your forefathers like this!” Thadius kept on, his sword still poised for combat. “You are the heir of the great Vettikus! *He* would have not hesitated to protect his family!”

How did he know of Vettikus? It wasn’t like the story was common knowledge; but, then again, the group likely did their homework on past demoric heroes.

Avino wanted to avoid violence, but Thadius was devolving at an alarming rate. “My great grandfather would have never condoned this.”

“He fought for all of his people! He did what had to be done!” The demorin pointed with his sword towards the eln. “Honor your family! Finish this, kill him now!”

The eln wailed against the gag, his young voice cracking.

“He’s a child, Thadius!” Avino stressed.

“He’s nearly a man! The law you value so much says so!” Thadius shot back, still waving his sword around. “He needs to be eliminated – for a better world! His hatred is not welcome any longer!”

“So you plan to battle hatred with more hatred?” Avino accused. “There’s other ways, Thad!”

Thadius began to laugh, deranged, a contrast to his sharp dress and usual composure. “You are naive, Vaaskiir. If we are going to shape this world, we cannot afford ignorance. Kill him, or prove your lack of worth.”

It was a threat if Avino had ever heard one. His hand inched towards his belt, the action obstructed by his cloak. He found his spell slinger and toggled the safety off with practiced sleight of hand. His fingertips buzzed with the current of his runa, at the ready.

“I won’t,” he refused, absolute.

Thadius scoffed, his acidic green irises wide and frantic. “Oh, Vaaskiir... That is... That is so regretful. Truly, we expected so much more from you.”

“Sorry to foil your expectations,” Avino spat sarcastically. He finally revealed his weapon and aimed it, the runes glowing with deadly potential. “Let the kid go, let me leave, and we’ll *all* put this behind us.”

Thadius spared the spell slinger a glance before chortling, failing to take the threat seriously. “So you’ll reject killing filth, but will point your barrel at a fellow demorin. You are truly lost, Vaaskiir.”

“You’re the one who escalated,” Avino said, eyeing his sword. “If you’re going to threaten me, I’m going to defend myself.”

“Oh, just like this runt stabbed your boy and now you’re holding him just oh-so accountable!” Thadius oozed.

“I won’t kill him, I never said anything about letting him go without consequence.”

Thadius hooted. “Oh, and what does that look like? Bringing him to the *police*? Haven’t we already discussed why that is a terrible plan?”

“Do not mistake my refusal to torture and kill as unwillingness to harm,” he bluffed to retain his slipping leverage with the eln. “If the kid doesn’t listen to reason, we’re going to have a problem.”

“You’re a misled hypocrite, Vaaskiir.” The other demorin readied to strike. “And the Arbiters have no room for you.”

Chapter 19

Avino

Thadius dove with alarming speed, the glint of his sword contrasting starkly against the dust and debris.

Avino did not have the agility to dodge him through normal means. He vanished into a puff of inky shadow before reappearing in the shade of a dismantled crane.

Thadius shouted in frustration before wildly looking around for him. Avino once again aimed the spell slinger towards Thadius, who roared when he finally caught sight of him.

“Drop the act, Vaaskiir! If you were gonna shoot me, you would have!”

“You’re right,” Avino conceded, his attention finding the unstable shelving behind Thadius.

The other demorin was not prepared for him to agree, sizing him with angry bewilderment.

Avino fired the weapon, an inky, swirling orb of force detonating from the barrel. It hurled past Thad’s feet and struck the bottom of the racks, right on mark.

With a thunderous clatter, the shelving began to topple. The other demorin attempted to duck out of the way, but his lower half was caught in the collapse. His sword slipped from his hands and clanked onto the concrete, vanishing into the ether with a flash of runes.

Thadius was belly down on the ground, half exposed from the rubble, unmoving.

Avino didn't linger. He shadow-hopped in front of the table and retrieved the sharpest of the utensils: a rusty knife.

He cut the child free from the chair and threw him over his shoulder, the eln yelling against the wool around his face, still bound.

Avino was hobbling his way towards the doors when he heard a shuffling of rubble. He turned to see Thadius struggling against the massive weight on top of him, to little gain.

"Vaaskiir!" Thadius bellowed. "The Arbiters will not forget this!"

Whoever these Arbiters were, it appeared it was the true identity of this 'Clawed Fist'.

Avino didn't entertain a reply. He proceeded his retreat, the teenager on his shoulder squirming wildly, hampering their progress.

"Hold still! Unless you want to die!" Avino warned him.

At that, he went still, and the escape went much smoother.

They reached outside, Avino shadow-hopping into the gloom of a far off alley. The demand from the repeated spell was draining his reserves, but if he could get to safety quicker than not, they would have a better chance to flee.

He proceeded to make his way across town, shadow by shadow, until he reached the outskirts of the settlement. He was gasping and sweating from the exertion as he finally reached the bank of the ____ River.

Avino finally allowed himself a break, dropping them both to the ground unceremoniously. The eln cried out, cursing into his gag and whimpering.

Avino laid there, endeavoring to catch his breath, when the kid began to scamper to his feet, desperately hopping away despite his binds.

Avino had no more appetite for antics. He aimed a restrained shot at the ground just behind the teenager, the force push sending the eln stumbling forward before crashing back onto the sandy dirt. The boy groaned and stayed where he landed.

Avino pushed to his feet and approached the young man. He tore the bag off his head and forced the eln to face him.

"This is how this is going to go," Avino growled in his best commanding tone. "You're going to get the hell out of town and never bother my family or *anybody* ever again. You so much as swat a fly and I will make your life a waking nightmare!"

The eln gaped at him with fearful reckoning, fresh gashes from his earlier torment leaking blood all across his face.

Avino yanked the gag down from his mouth, glowering with revulsion. “Why in all the realms is some punk kid like you causing so much trouble, anyway? Huh, boy?!”

“I-I-It—” The eln stuttered, before cursing loudly to earn back some composure. “God damn it! Fuck me, man! He put me up to it!”

“Who?!” the father boomed, all of his frustrations billowing out like smoke from a volcano.

“Th-that guy back there! The— the other demon— I uh-I mean demorin!”

Avino processed that with a doubtful scoff. “Why would you listen to a demorin if you hate them so much?”

“H-He didn’t always look like that!” The eln hollered, struggling against the rope with renewed fervor.

Avino moved in again, the eln yelping as he braced for harm, but the demorin merely leaned over to break the binds on his ankles. Only his arms remained restrained now.

“What did he look like, then?”

“I don’t know! Just a normal dude! He turned all demonic when we met here earlier!”

Avino digested what the teenager was insinuating. “What, so this man approached you, and told you to do *what*, exactly?”

“Make your family’s life miserable, I guess! He said it didn’t matter, just that we got under your skin!”

Avino couldn’t believe it. Everything – *everything* had been orchestrated?! He had been played like a fool; he had been manipulated and made out to believe his tormentors were actually his benefactors.

He was seething at the revelation when the eln hoisted his shoulders impatiently. “You untying me, or what?”

The teenager’s insolence was insulting. He grabbed the eln by his bloodied shirt. “I mean *everything* I said. You make yourself a problem, I will *not* refrain from fixing it.”

“Pff, go to hell, man. Why should I have to listen to you?” The eln challenged.

"Would you prefer to listen to the cops, then?!" Avino barked, and the eln snapped his mouth shut.

"Whatever! Fine! It's not worth going back to your dinky little town anyway!"

"You're damn straight it's not. We'd run you right out, kid." He knew more than ever that Riverview had their back.

"Yeah, yeah..."

Avino finally broke the last of his binds. "What was in it for you, anyway?"

"*What?*"

"Why did you take the job? What was in it for you?"

"Shit, just money! Not everyone can live a sweet lil countryside life! Some of us have been struggling since birth!"

"You think I haven't fought to get where I am?" Avino hissed. "Punks like you have been making my life harder forever."

"Pff! Then why stay in Azyria? Why not just go back to where you're wanted?" The eln antagonized.

"Because this world is for everyone!" Avino retorted, jabbing a claw towards the dirt. "The gods made this place to be the connection between all realms! Why should demorin be excluded from that?"

The eln shrugged his shoulders, striking Avino as facetious.

"Nobody has the right to make someone else feel inferior for existing" Avino went on. "*Nobody*. You'll do well to remember that."

The eln's eyes flashed with sudden sincerity before the teenager waved him off. "Yeah, yeah... Whatever, man."

"We're done here, then." Avino muttered, turning to face the river.

"...What, so you're really *not* bringing me to the cops?"

"I just want this entire mess behind us," Avino grumbled, exhausted. "Am I clear?"

“Ur...”

“Am I clear?!” The father boomed with the last of his capacity for anger.

“Shit, yeah! You’re clear!”

“Good,” Avino sighed, utterly wrung out. He sized the eln with one last intense look before teleporting into the shadows beyond.

—

Chapter 20

Karreo

He wasn’t the only one glued to the couch by the time the sun was coming up.

It was about an hour ago when his mother had gently awoken him, wondering why he was out in the living room. When Karreo said he was waiting for Dad, she’d crimped her face in confusion. “He’s not in his study?”

Karreo had explained how he had gone with the man from the Clawed Fist, leaving a note in the kitchen before he left. “They found the bad guy.”

His mother had been less than pleased at the news, cursing in Pyrothian and pacing with unease. “Why would he leave without telling me!”

It was a rhetorical question, but Karreo still shrugged.

“Why didn’t they contact the police?”

“The Clawed Fist guy said they didn’t want them involved.”

She had joined Karreo on the sofa after her frustration passed, her attention moored to the window as she gazed out with a frown.

Valen too eventually joined their vigil. He’d come out into the living room yawning, only to jump with surprise at seeing he wasn’t the only one up. Karreo filled him in the same.

And so now the three of them were waiting for their father, growing more antsy by the minute.

Then, out from the morning fog, came a vehicle. It was not the same one the Clawed Fist had arrived and left in, however.

Even still, Karreo spotted his parent in the passenger seat as the car pulled up.

The older demorin was the very picture of exhaustion as he handed the driver some cash and left the vehicle, his family meeting him in the front yard to sweep him up in an embrace. The car lingered in the driveway, waiting.

“Gods above, Avino! What on earth happened?!” Their mother shot after the initial sweetness of the reunion.

“I’ll explain inside, but we need to leave. *Now.*” their father urged with weary intensity. He gestured to the house and then the car. “Grab your bags, we can’t delay.”

They all hurriedly retrieved their luggage, their father sharing the reason for their urgency as they met back in the living room.

“We are in danger here. I managed to escape, but they’ll likely be after us.”

“Who?!” Valen and Karreo cried.

Their father shared a look with their mother, suggesting they had already spoken when they were grabbing their belongings.

“There’s some people we thought were our friends, but it turns out they’re... they’re not.”

“The Clawed Fist?” Karreo wagered.

“*Who?*” Valen said again, not near as savvy.

Their father nodded and sized each of his sons with an intense look. “Stay close to Mom and I, keep low. Assume everyone and anyone can mean harm until we say so. Understood?”

The boys hurriedly nodded and he patted both of them on the back.

“Good lads. Let’s go.”

After loading their cargo in the trunk, the family filed into the car, the driver quiet as they took their places. He drove off without delay, towards the city of Akarth and its airport.

They reached their destination without any incident, taking the better part of the day.

The airport was bustling with thousands of patrons as the family hurried their way to customs. A lengthy line thwarted their sense of urgency, but it could not be helped.

Karreo spent the downtime people-watching, suspicious of every passing face and stranger that was caught staring. There were quite a few of them, but that was more likely due to their heritage than any ill intent. Demorin weren't exactly common.

If anything, the startled glances and double-takes were far more comforting than the idea of someone watching them with no surprise. Luckily, no one appeared to meet that description as their airport chores lugged on.

They were sat in the terminal now, their flight still a good hour or so out.

"Ugh, Lucy still isn't picking up," his mother grumbled upon returning from using a pay-phone. "But, she knows we're coming. We talked last night."

"She's likely just wrapped up in her own things, dear," their father surmised. "We'll shoot her another call when we land."

They eventually boarded their aircraft and nestled in for a long trip. The city of Sengard was in the country of Varlan, which was well across the pond. It was to be a ten hour flight.

Valen was uncharacteristically quiet. Karreo had prodded him with occasional stabs at conversation, but his brother was distracted at best and cagey at worst.

"He's just got a lot on his mind," his mother quietly reminded Karreo.

Indeed, he wasn't the only one. Their father had hardly spoken other than when necessity demanded it. He appeared focused and hypervigilant, which matched the circumstances.

"Please sleep, Vinny," Karreo overheard his mother eventually tell him. "You being exhausted isn't going to help us."

The aircraft was dark as other patrons struggled to get their own rest, the curse of uncomfortable seats and crowded quarters ensuring it was a proper endeavor for most.

It took a lot of tossing and turning, but slumber did eventually come for Karreo. However, his dreams were restless and fleeting, and when he awoke, the sky was pink with morning far earlier than it should be. Thus was a consequence of traveling across the sea.

Their flight passed on unremarkably, Karreo filling the time with books and cloud gazing. It fascinated him they were up high in the air, making what would have been a month-long trip in

times past a mere blink of an eye in comparison. The marvel was only possible through the marriage of magic and mundane engineering; much of their world was defined by the two working in tandem.

The local time was nearing noon when they landed, what felt like seven AM to their Akarthi reckoning of time. They were as energetic as ghouls as they retrieved their belongings and checked in with customs, yawning and bleary eyed.

Their mother once again tried to contact her sister, who was still not answering.

“She’s expecting us, it will be fine, Vivie,” their father said.

Karreo could sense apprehension despite his father’s encouragement.

The towering buildings of Sengard loomed on the horizon as they exited the airport, beckoning. Aunt Lucia lived in an inner city suburb, calling an old town-house home. It was a moderately sized abode for only a single resident, but it meant she always had plenty of room for guests.

It would take the better part of the afternoon to travel to their destination despite its relative closeness. Over-congested roads and endless traffic promised as much. Sengard was one of the largest cities in all of the realm; it was only by the exposure to Akarth that the boys did not feel overwhelmed. Well, for the most part. They weren’t in Akarth all that often, so there was still much to be marveled at. The cooler blues and grays of the architecture were in contrast to Akarth’s warm hues, for one.

Their father opted for another taxi instead of their usual bus route, as it was more low-key. This driver was far chattier than the other; however. He yapped ceaselessly and had far too many questions.

“Where you folks from?” “What brings you to the ____ (nickname for Sengard).” “Have you been here before?” “Where ya resting your head?” “Make sure to try Skip’s Tavern if you’re out East.” “Is that spell slinger the real deal?” “Is Pyroth as hot as they say?” “Oh, you’ve never been there? Aren’t you folks demorin?”

He yammered on and on, their parents offering canned responses that spared no intimate details.

Valen was still reserved and disenchanted. Karreo had noticed him staring several times at Sienna’s note while on the plane, and he had that same melancholy about him as he gazed out the window. Karreo wished there was something he could do for his brother, but emotional comfort was far more challenging than recon and books ever were.

“Um... maybe... Maybe you’ll meet a new girl here in the city?” He still tried.

Valen bristled at that, gracing his attempt at encouragement with naught but a sigh.

They finally arrived at their destination: a shopping square a few blocks from Aunt Lucia's townhome.

The family had not eaten since landing, but had held out for one of Aunt Lucia's famous meals. Even Karreo, normally a more picky sort, enjoyed her dishes. The idea of one of her hearty casseroles or pot pies promised it would be worth the fast.

They walked the remaining distance to breathe some life back into their cramping legs. Their luggage certainly complicated their pace, but they still found themselves in front of Aunt Lucia's iron garden gate without too much fuss.

His father, ever-cautious as they'd traveled, was confident they weren't being followed when he gave them permission to head on through.

They arrived on the covered porch and his mother knocked, but no reply came, even after a lengthy pause. She cursed and shot his other parent a worried look, but they didn't need to dwell in their concern.

Aunt Lucia finally opened the door, her smile wide and bright. "Hello, hello! You made it!"

"I've been calling you!" His mother chided, but relief and joy rendered it more playful. The demorin sisters embraced, Aunt Lucia chuckling apologetically.

"I'm sorry, Viv. I've just been so swamped with work and getting everything ready."

They broke apart and the hugs proceeded down the line. Karreo awkwardly received his, but something felt even more off putting about the closeness than usual. '*It's probably just because everything has been so messed up.*' he figured.

"Come in, you all must be exhausted!" Aunt Lucia gushed, gesturing inside. They stepped through the door and into the safety within, all of them awash in relief. It had been a completely *maddening* couple of days, but they were finally getting a break.

Chapter 21

Karreo

"I'd been meaning to call you all day," Aunt Lucia further appeased when they were all inside, and his mother tottered with confusion.

"Pff, on what responder, Luc?" his mother nervously laughed.

"Oh, right, you still haven't gotten a mobile device!" The burgundy demorin sniggered. "A bit behind the times."

"Not many have them in our town," his father contributed with a shrug.

"I'm only teasing," Aunt Lucy insisted. She then clapped her hands together and gestured to the staircase. "Go on and take a load off, then I have a casserole I can heat up!"

There was nothing confusing about that. They headed to their rooms, their parents in one and Valen and Karreo sharing another.

"She seems a bit flustered," he heard his father whisper to their mother as they entered their quarters.

"She's a little out of it, yeah..."

They reconvened downstairs in the kitchen. Aunt Lucia popped the oven closed after placing the casserole inside. "It'll be twenty minutes or so."

His mother sat at the table with a weary sigh. "Thanks for having us here. I hope it's not too much."

"Don't be silly! You've all been through the wringer, I'm happy to give you a safe place to recover."

"There's some new developments we need to discuss," his father sighed. "Boys, why don't you—"

"No sense sending them off, Vin," his mother commented wryly. "We know we'll have an audience."

Karreo flushed. Perhaps he'd played his hand a bit too candidly this past week.

Aunt Lucia raised her eyebrows. "Got some snoops, huh?"

"Our own little spy, I'd say," his mother said, to his further chagrin.

"Well, alright, then," his other parent muttered as he readjusted in his seat. "Well, Lucia... The night before we left, things got a lot more... complicated."

He went on to explain how the man from the Clawed Fist had found the perp, and suggested to Avino to go confront him together. He figured he meant scare him out of town, and so he agreed. It wasn't promised that things would go their way legally, so if they could chase the kid off, things could go back to normal.

The man from the Clawed Fist did not have the same solution in mind, however... He wanted to not only hurt the boy, but.... Remove him from the situation entirely. Permanently.

That just wasn't something he could agree to, and a conflict broke out between them. The man became maddened, and attempted to cut him down after his attempts to indoctrinate him failed. He was able to incapacitate the man and flee with the eln, but the other demorin promised retribution.

"I understand if you prefer us staying somewhere else in light of that," he finished his tale.

"Of course not. You are my kin, that's what families are there for."

Something about her wording struck Karreo as odd.

"I do not think we were followed, but I cannot promise that we weren't," he upheld. "If we're going to stay here, you need to know the risk."

In light of the full version of events and his father's intensity, Karreo was wisened to just how serious it all was.

"This isn't my first rodeo. I'll take my chances." Aunt Lucia accepted the development well enough. If anything, Karreo felt it was a little *too* well.

The timer dinged and she stood with a smile. "Perfect timing, eh?"

Valen stood from his chair with an apologetic grimace. "Aunt Lucy, I'm really sorry, but I'm going to head upstairs and lay down. I don't feel well at all."

"Oh, hun, that's fine! Go rest up, I'll bring you up a plate in a bit."

"Um, well, I'm... really not that hungry."

"Nonsense! You're a growing boy and must eat! Especially after all this madness you've put up with."

Valen gave in to her insistence with a defeated nod. "Oh... okay." He left the room with his tail dragging, them all seeing him off with a frown.

Aunt Lucia tsked. "He's had the worst of it, hm?"

"It's been a lot for him. Him and Sienna broke up before we left," his mother shared.

"Oh, poor bug. His first heartbreak?"

Both of their parents nodded solemnly.

"Well, he's young. There'll be others," Aunt Lucia said, every one murmuring in agreement.

She got to spooning a helping onto everyone's plate, but not one for herself. "I ate not even an hour before you all got here," she excused.

It must have been a different dish, for the casserole had been fully intact before she cut into it.

As she made her way around the table, Karreo noticed she was minding her right leg, resulting in a limp. She was concealing it, but Karreo could still tell thanks to years of watching his father's movements.

He was too shy to bring it up, but he didn't have to.

"Hurt yourself, Luc?" his mother wondered.

"Oh, I think I just pulled something earlier. It's been bothering me. I'm sure Avino knows the struggle!"

His father politely chuckled at that with a small grin, but it faded quickly.

Aunt Lucy changed the subject as she sat back down. "So! How was your flight?"

The small talk began, Karreo internally wincing. He had little appetite for surface inquiries. What he did have an appetite for, however, was casserole.

He took his first bite, and an unfamiliar flavor and texture spooked his taste buds. He flinched against the surprise, betrayed by what he was tasting. It was not *bad*, but it was not nearly on par with Aunt Lucia's usual masterpiece.

He was not the only one to notice.

"Trying something different with the casserole?" His mother wondered, shaking her fork at her plate.

“Oh, ah, yeah! It’s good to try something new every now and then.”

Karreo couldn’t say he agreed if it meant lesser casseroles.

“Surprised you’re shaking up Mom’s old recipe,” his mother commented.

Aunt Lucy giggled, and Karreo pegged it as nervous. “Well, tradition always has room to grow!”

“I suppose,” his mother conceded, albeit skeptical.

“It’s still delicious, Lucia. Thank you,” his father defused, and that was the end of the great casserole shake-up.

Karreo pushed around more bites than he ate, which went noticed by his relative.

“Eat up, Karreo! You’re a growing boy, too!”

He was uncomfortable by her insistence, but there was something else he could not pin down that bothered him about what she said. “I uh... I am. I’m just...” He trailed off awkwardly.

“Lucia, it’s fine. We’ve been through a lot,” his father came to his rescue.

She raised her palms in resignation. “I just figured you all must be starving.” She smirked at Karreo with playful reproof. “No sweets for you later unless you finish, Karreo.”

Karreo continued to push his food around as dinner passed, distracted by the check in his gut. Something wasn’t adding up; he just couldn’t put his finger on *why*.

He’d forced down enough bites to quell his hungry belly by the time Aunt Lucia went around the table grabbing every one’s plates.

She assessed his plate with a sideways grin. “I suppose that’ll do, Karreo,” she said, and it *finally* hit him.

Aunt Lucia *a/ways* called him ‘Karri’, not Karreo.

He was snagged on that realization as Aunt Lucia dropped the plates in the sink and faced them all with an almost artificial smile. “Well, I’m sure you’re all exhausted from your trip. I’ll let you get some rest. I have some errands to go run.”

She was halfway out the front door when she stopped in her tracks. “Oh! I forgot to bring Valen up his plate!” She actually interrupted her departure to go do so, Karreo sharing an unnerved look with his parents.

"Is Aunt Lucy okay?" the eleven year old whispered.

"She's definitely acting odd..." His mother mumbled in agreement.

"She's probably feeling pretty out of sorts from all of this as well," his father excused.

Knowing they both sensed it too validated Karreo's suspicions.

Aunt Lucia came down the steps with the same bubbly smile she'd sported most of the evening. "Right then! I'll be back. Help yourselves to anything you need."

With that, she was out the door to complete her errands, whatever those might be.

"Well," his mother yawned and stretched, but the exertion made her stumble. "Oof, geez. I am exhausted."

His father agreed with his own yawn. And then another. "We're going to go lay down for a bit, Karreo. Come get us if you need anything."

His parents retired to their room, and Karreo was relieved to get some time alone. Aunt Lucia's odd behavior was too strange to write off so easily for him; he had the mind to poke around and look for clues.

He got to nosing around the living room, nothing appearing amiss. He was yawning and feeling rather unmotivated suddenly, but then the homeline rang.

He went to snoop at the call log, finding the number that was calling was labeled 'work'. The call history told that the number had called several times not just today, but yesterday, too.

The current call went to voicemail, adding to a tally of missed messages. Karreo looked at the front door, wondering when his Aunt was due back. He decided he had enough time to investigate further and played the most recent message.

"Lucia, we're starting to get worried now. This is so out of character for you. Please call us and let us know you're okay."

This 'work' number expressed concerns in her behavior, too? Why? Karreo played the other missed messages from the number.

"Lucia, this is the second day you've not shown up for work and blown us off. We're not upset, we're just confused. Are you okay? Please call as soon as you get this."

“Lucy, we noticed you didn’t come in this morning or call. It’s not like you, so we’re just checking in. Call me when you get this.”

Karreo’s stomach was plummeting at an alarming rate. Hadn’t Aunt Lucy said she was wrapped up in work, and that’s why she had missed his mother’s calls?

But if she had not been at work, then what was the real reason?

He hurried up the steps to share with his parents, nearly stumbling as his sense of balance was abruptly uncooperative. His limbs were heavy as he made his way down the hall, arriving in front of his parents door, which was unusually ajar.

He bumbled inside, finding them both crudely passed out on the bed, in their street clothes, no less.

A sense of panic bubbled up Karreo’s throat and he scampered to go warn Valen. He sloppily stumbled through the doorway and landed on his belly.

“Whoa! Karreo! What’s wrong?!” Valen fretted.

“Something *really* weird is going on!” Karreo cried, attempting to push himself off of the floor, to no avail.

“*What?*”

“Y-you didn’t eat the casserole, right?!”

They both looked in unison at Valen’s empty plate. ‘*Oh... oh no...!*’

Karreo’s vision began to smear and he forfeited his effort to sit up. He laid there crumpled on the floor as Valen knelt down to shake him.

“Karreo, hey, talk to me! What’s going on?!”

“I... I don’t...” Karreo slurred, his lips going numb. “I don’t think that’s...”

“*What?!* Come on, talk to me, buddy!”

Karreo’s eyes closed but his world still spun. “Aunt... Lucy....”

Valen

“Hey! Karreo!” He shook his sibling yet again, but it was no use. Karreo had gone unconscious.

Valen scooped him up, his little brother’s eyes fluttering open to stare at nothing before rolling into the back of his head.

The sight disturbed Valen to his core. Something was *very* wrong.

He hurried him over to the bed and laid him down as carefully as desperation would allow.

“Hang on, bud! I’m gonna go get Mom and Dad!”

He yelled out for his parents and crashed into their room, finding both of them in a similar state. They, too, did not stir when he shook them. It was gasoline on Valen’s panic.

What in all the realms was going on?!

The front door opened downstairs, snapping him to attention. He had to tell his Aunt what was going on!

He hurried down the steps, only to stumble on the last few as his legs gave out. He managed to catch himself before falling, but the aftermath had him wincing from onset dizziness.

“Oh, Valen, I’m surprised you’re up and about!” Aunt Lucia remarked, her tone failing to recognize the seriousness of the situation.

“Everyone... every one is...” His mind was rapidly turning lethargic, words coming to him through a drip feed of molasses.

“What’s the matter? You look ready to fall over. Why not lay down on the couch, hm?”

“N-no!” He refused, pointing towards the stairs with desperate insistence. His arm could not maintain the gesture and threw him off balance as it thunked to his side.

He was teetering when the wall caught him. Regardless of the stability, he still felt like he was spinning.

“Something... is... going... on!” He managed to slur out, but Aunt Lucia merely stared instead of calling for help or even reacting at all.

“Help... Karreo... Mom... Dad...” The pause between each word grew longer than the last.

He suddenly realized he was on the floor, the pattern of the tiles rippling and swaying as he hopelessly attempted to calibrate his senses.

Aunt Lucia *finally* responded by calmly walking over, looming over him with a callous tilt of her head.

He tried to keep staring up at her, but his neck was made of stone.

His relative shuffled with something in her pocket before coolly saying “they’re neutralized”.

Confusion and betrayal were Valen’s final thoughts as he lost consciousness.

Chapter 22

Avino

The harsh glare of an intense light roused him from the void. He winced against the bright assault, but when he tried to lift a hand to shield his eyes, he found himself unable. He squinted in mounting confusion with a groan as his situation came into focus.

His hands were not only bound behind a chair with mundane rope, but cold, metal bracelets barred both of his wrists, constipating his hands with a static sensation. It was an alarming development. ‘*Sapping cuffs!*’

A snicker came from the gloom beyond. “Finally awake, hm?”

Lucia came into the light, waltzing despite her limp. She was smiling broadly, but it was twisted and wicked. She kneeled in front of the chair to sneer at him. “How are you feeling, Vinny? Get plenty of rest after your long trip?”

Avino gaped at her, or at least whoever was stealing her visage. There had been sign after sign that this was not his wife’s sister. “Who are you?! What in oblivion is this?!”

“Oh, silly me. No need for further concealment.” ‘Lucia’s’ form, clothing and all, began to ripple and change, molding like clay. A familiar, horned face emerged from the renovation.

“Thadius...” Avino gasped, enveloped with dread.

"Hello again, palar vi," Thadius grinned with mocking warmth. "Sorry for the... how did you put it... *Theatrics*, but! Now we can finish what we started nights ago." The orange toned demorin rose to his feet to walk across the room leisurely, doing little to mask his limp now.

"Are you comfortable? How are those rucanic suppression bands treating you? Are your binds tight enough?"

"Thadius, this is preposterous," Avino said, suppressing his panic in favor of conviction. "We are not enemies. Whatever this is, it doesn't have to play out like this."

Thadius clicked his tongue as though scolding a child. "Oh, Vaaskiir, we are well beyond negotiation. You made that abundantly clear after you *crushed me* and ran off with that reprobate."

The source of the demorin's newly acquired limp was suddenly evident.

"You forced my hand. You *know* I didn't want any violence." Avino argued. He messed with his binds each time the other demorin's back was turned, reflexively revving up his magic to aid him with a spell, but the sapping cuffs were a gaping hemorrhage in his reserves. They not only suppressed the flow of his runa, but actively drained it.

Even still, if he focused on pooling what little was salvageable, maybe there was a chance he could muster a spell. But, that would take meditative levels of concentration, or commandeering energy from his bodily functions at the cost of serious injury.

"Ah, but your aversion to violence is the very reason we're in this mess, palar vi. Your refusal to be pried away from that perverse sense of ethics of yours will be your downfall." Thadius blathered on towards the wall.

"Perverse?" Avino balked. "You're the ones justifying violence for your gain!"

"We are merely playing by the rules our enemies have laid out. We cannot rise up if we do not level the field. *Their* violence will *not* be met with subservience any longer."

"Two wrongs will never make a right," Avino kept. "Besides, that eln told me *you* put him up to harassing us! You *created* violence to manipulate my family!"

"You had to be taught the pain so many of your siblings endure first hand," Thadius excused without turning around, fiddling his hand with a downplaying wave. "Not that it did much good. Even after harm befell your family, you still chose to value your oppressor's sense of justice."

"You're the real oppressor here," Avino growled. "Our family was *fine* before you intervened."

Thadius sighed with dramatic wistfulness. “Oh, Vaaskiir. It wasn’t supposed to be like this. You were supposed to be thankful for our selfless assistance, and join us. You were destined to rise in our ranks, and help lead our cause as we fought for our brave new world. Instead, you just *had* to turn yourself into an obstacle. It truly is a waste.”

The fellow demorin made his way back over to kneel in front of him, Avino pausing his attempt to slip from his mundane binds, but the sequestering of his runa dripping on.

“But, not all is lost. You have two *lovely* sons full of potential; sons that are about to have their lives changed forever by the cruelty of this world. You see, they thought they could come to Sengard to be safe, but their tormentors followed them here. Now, they’re going to have their parents murdered, and who will be there to help them in their most dire time?”

Avino’s panic surged yet again at the mention of his boys and their role in Thadius’s heinous plot. He *could not* let that happen. “Don’t you dare! You leave them alone, damn you!”

“Ohhh, do not worry, Vaaskiir. We will treat your children well, like our own sons, even. The Arbiters will not fail to teach them properly – that a new world is the only way forward. In fact, maybe Azyria itself is already doomed, and we’ll need... an ancient power to forge a new one.”

Thadius summoned a book into his hands, Avino realizing with a churn of dismay that it was the Vaaskiir Family Tome! The ram-horned demorin tapped the cover with a knowing smirk, clearly revelling in Avino’s shock.

“You are a bigger fool than I thought if you think that’s a good idea!” Avino barked, aghast. “The Hammer of Volkara *needs* to remain locked away!”

“So your misguided ancestor rescinded...” Thadius oozed. “But, let’s not get too ahead of ourselves. Let’s focus on the task currently at hand first, hm?”

He dismissed the book with a snap and got to his feet. He faced the doorway and flashed a hand signal. “Bring her in.”

Another demorin drug his wife into the room, Vivianna complicit as they moved. However, it was a ruse. The demorine abruptly thrust her skull back into her captor’s head with sudden fervor, catching him off guard. With blistering speed she revealed she was not even truly bound, punching the man and throwing him off balance.

Nobody could ever keep Vivi contained.

She yanked the sword from the demorin's belt and sent him into the wall with a swift kick. It was a scene Avino had witnessed countless times in the past; she truly was the domineering, competent woman he fell in love with all those years ago, even still.

Thadius challenged her rebellion with a thrust of his weapon, but Viv was ready. She parried the strike and sent the man stumbling back with the power of her momentum. Her tail thrashed like a whip as she tumbled over to Avino's chair, cutting him free of his own binds.

Though the sapping cuffs remained tight on his wrists, he could still fight.

The couple posed for combat, side by side, falling into the rhythm of a dance they'd long retired. They faced Thadius with hardened resolve, years of experience at their back.

"Insolent fools!" Thadius shouted. "How dare you, you *ingrates*!"

The commotion had backup filing into the room, weapons drawn.

"Where are our children?!" Vivianna demanded, her garnet eyes aflame.

Thadius was scowling but the question transmuted his expression into a slimy smile. "Well, if you must know..." He gestured to his men outside. "Bring them in!"

Karreo and Valen were dragged into the debacle with knives to their throats, both of them limp and unconscious. The sight rattled Avino initially, but he reminded himself that the Arbiters' plan didn't call for them to be harmed.

Thadius still raised a hand to threaten the lethal order. "Keep this up and we won't hesitate to kill them, too!"

"He's bluffing," Avino whispered to Vivianna. "He needs them for what he's planning."

"Oh, do I? Plans can and do change, Vaaskiir," Thadius growled with alarming conviction. "Surrender *now*, or we will take drastic measures."

The couple shared a look, but they both already knew surrender wasn't an option. They would fight for their sons' freedom, no matter what it took.

"Wait," he hissed to his mate, who thankfully did as he asked.

Thadius smirked, assuming he'd won.

But their retaliation had only just begun.

Avino mustered everything within him – every drop of runa he could squeeze out of his entire being, the demand commandeering the very force that kept his body functioning. It all amassed into a spell, and a powerful one at that.

The two demorin threatening their sons hollered as their bodies began to quake and seize. They convulsed and sputtered, dropping their children to the floor, away from the knives. Valen stirred with a groan upon impact, but Karreo remained unresponsive. Avino dismissed the spell with a final crunch on the Arbiters' brainstems, the two dropping to the floor with a thud.

The exertion left Avino debilitated. He stumbled in the aftermath, sweat pouring from his brow, the taste of warm iron on his tongue. He spat out the blood with tenacity and braced himself for further conflict, remaining on his feet despite the weakness in his limbs.

During Avino's spell, Vivianna had shot forward to engage another pair of Thadius's men, having efficiently dispatched them through a flurry of agility and precise strikes. Two more were approaching to engage her flank now, but Avino lifted a palm and once again overdrew from his reserves.

Nebulous, shadowy roots rose from the ground to trip up the assailants, Vivianna not skipping a beat as she turned in a whirlwind to sink her borrowed sword into them.

All the commotion finally woke Valen up. He looked around in a panic, yelping at the madness unfolding. "Mom! Dad!"

"Enough!!" Thadius then roared, his exclamation distorting from a chorus of snarling, dismembered voices.

The leader charged forward to bring his sword down, but it was not on Avino nor Vivianna.

It was on Valen.

Chapter 23

Avino's world slowed to a halt as he watched Thadius drive his sword into his son with not even a shred of mercy. Valen had no chance to dodge as the weapon skewered him between his shoulder blades, smashing him back into the ground. His son wailed out in agony, but his voice was drowned out with a gurgle of blood.

“VALEN!” Both he and his mate cried in horrified unison, their attention on nothing but their bleeding child.

Thadius readied to strike Karreo, and Avino bellowed with desperation. “No! Please!” He dropped to his knees, decimated from not only the battle but his heartbreak. Tears poured out, blurring his declining vision as more Arbiters surrounded them. He let it happen, too broken to fight any longer.

Vivianna wasn’t ready to give up. She launched forward, but in doing so had left herself wide open. Their aggressors took advantage of the lapse and cut her down, sending her stumbling to the floor. She reached out for her son helplessly, forlorn. “Valen!”

Both of them now incapacitated, Thadius chuckled, the sound reverberating off the walls in varying pitches and cadences. “Truly, it’s such a shame. I *really* would have preferred them both alive, but because of your hubris we are only down to one. Now, any further antics and we *will* not hesitate to make that none.”

Avino bawled and choked on the blood flooding his throat. “We yield! *We yield!* Please, don’t hurt him!”

Thadius lowered his blade, flashing his penchant smile. “Ah, so we’re in agreement, then?”

“Oh, gods. Boys. I— I—” He stammered out through sobs that rocked his entire being. “Vivi, I— I love you. I love you all so much. Please, forgive me. I’m so sorry. I love you.”

“Vinny, we tried, love.” Vivianna gasped out, every word strained. “Boys, we... love... you. We.. love you.. so much.” Her voice began to trail off as she faded.

How could this have happened? How did it turn out this way?! Not even a month ago life was normal, unremarkable, *serene*. It had all been ripped away, and for what? *Why?!*

Thadius limped up to Avino and knelt down so they were eye to eye. “Ah, kin toh vi... You have both been worthy adversaries. The Arbiters could have used your tenacity.”

“Fall into oblivion...!” Avino croaked in despair.

Thadius grabbed Avino’s cheek, and he tried to yank his head away, only for Thadius’ claws to sink deep. The other Pyrothian forced him to look directly into his soul. “Listen carefully before you go, kin toh vi. Times are changing. The scorned *will* rise up. We will forge a new world by the power *your* kin were too submissive to utilize. We will overcome, no thanks to *you*.”

Thadius pushed Avino's head away before rising back to his feet, lifting his sword high. "Now go... Go and tell Demor our king the good news."

Avino closed his eyes as Thadius brought his blade down, and when he opened them again, he was staring down at his own slain, corporeal form. Fresh blood leaked from the lethal wound Thadius inflicted as the Arbiter glowered down at him.

"It's done. Give me... a second to gather myself, then we'll wake him." Thadius sighed before cursing in Pyrothian. "Hellfire blaze it all. What a mess."

Avino seethed at the injustice, his essence flickering with rage. Thad had the gaul to lament the disaster *he* orchestrated?!

His wife cried out, stealing his attention. "Vinny! He's still alive!" Her shimmering, wispy form was cradled over their eldest. She was pushing down on Valen's back, holding fast a ball of light that was trying to escape.

Avino flew over at once, his phantom heart skipping a beat. Valen wasn't dead?!

He arrived next to her, their auras wavering where they met. He scanned where his wife was pressing, discerning the orb was his boy's soul. They couldn't let him pass!

"No, no, son, not yet," he told him.

"You have to keep fighting!" Vivianna encouraged too. "Hang on!"

Avino assessed his son's mortal injury with bleak reckoning. "He's losing too much blood, Vivianna..."

His mate grabbed his ghostly hand and placed it atop Valen's back, next to hers. A raw, uncompressed power was disrupting the space there, surging with potential.

It took no words to coordinate them entwining their cores together before reaching into the force as one, tapping into a power far, far greater than their mortal forms had ever wielded or experienced. They channeled all of their love, sorrow, and dedication into a spell that seeped deep into Valen's wound.

Through their intervention, the flesh was willed to mend. At first the bleeding ceased, but then even the wound itself began to close, cells dividing at rapid speed, searing shut with a silvery sheen.

Thus, the ball of light they had been containing dissolved back into their son, anchoring him to the mortal plane once more.

He was healed. He was going to survive.

“Oh, son,” Avino uttered, his aura swelling with emotion. “We love you so much...”

“I’m so sorry we failed you both,” Vivianna sighed with a heavy pulse of regret. “Please, help your brother. He’ll be... he’ll be so lost without you.”

A sensation rippled across their backs, akin to an inverse wind. Avino gandered past the tiny room they were in, witnessing a veil of fog that dithered the horizon beyond. It was beckoning them, their grip on the material world slipping away like sand, grain by grain.

As more of him went, he could feel his mother embracing him, and the chime of Lucia’s laughter. His father was telling him something he could not hear, but he did not have to. He understood.

Avino turned his attention back on his son, touching his shoulder with one last goodbye. “We’ll see each other again, Valen. Until then, be strong. Be good. Be brave.”

“We love you,” Vivianna farewelled, too.

Their peace made, they disintegrated into the wind, towards their next adventure.

Chapter 24

Karreo

He had fallen asleep by the fireplace. His father approached to scoop him up, Karreo limp as he remained snoozing. He was safe and loved in his father’s arms; he didn’t want to be put down and for the moment to end.

His father laid him down in his bed, and his mother was there to tuck him in, kissing him on his forehead.

Karreo spared a sleepy peek at his parents, seeing that they were clad in a shimmering aura. They were smiling at him, but it was a forlorn type of grin. As he stared, details grew harder to parse as their visages wavered, the bright halo around them building in intensity.

Soon it was too bright to stare, and Karreo had to shield his eyes.

“Please, be good; be safe,” his mother whispered.

“Never forget who you are,” his father said. “Follow your heart, son.”

Karreo tried to open his eyes but it was just too bright. “Wait—”

“We love you, Karreo,” both of them said, their voices sounding further away.

The thought of them leaving terrified Karreo. He went to get up so he could run after them, but when he tried he found himself stuck. He yelled out for them, struggling against his paralysis, until he finally was able to roll out of bed.

He fell to the floor, his eyes snapping open with a start, finding himself not in his room at all. Unfamiliar hands were shaking him, stirring him from the disorientation of his dream.

“*Tahee* (child, masculine), hey, are you hurt?!” He could not yet see them, being face down, but he recognized it as the man from the Clawed Fist.

Karreo yelped with fear and tried squirming away, but his hands were bound. The Clawed Fist must have captured them!

...But then the man cut his binds, setting him free.

“Are you hurt?” The man repeated, turning Karreo to face him. The older demorin’s expression was of worry and regret, far from the scowl Karreo had imagined him to be wearing.

“Wah—” the eleven year old stammered, confused. He looked around, spotting an unfamiliar hallway. “What... what is...”

His memories came flooding back with a lurch. They’d been poisoned by someone who was impersonating their Aunt Lucia, and—and— what happened next?!

“Where is everyone?!” Karreo demanded, his voice trembling.

The regretful look on the Clawed Fist deepened. “Oh, tahee, I’m... I’m so sorry. We got here too late.”

What was that supposed to mean?!

“Where are they?!” the child again pressed, and the older demorin sighed.

“We... came to apologize to your father for the misunderstanding, and found your Aunt’s house ransacked... We were able to track you all down to the docks, but...”

Karreo gaped at the man with horrific bewilderment.

"We found your family being attacked. We were able to fight them off, but... it was... it was too late."

Panic rapidly rose in Karreo's chest and he floundered onto his feet. He frantically sprinted down the hall, unsure of where he was going, but desperate to get there.

"Hey, wait! *Tahee!*" The Clawed Fist called out.

Karreo turned the corner and noticed an archway. He fled into a large room beyond, a piercing iron stench assaulting him as he entered.

What he saw made him scream and balk in terror. Strewn on the ground in scarlet heaps were bodies, mostly of humans and eln. Then, the worst of his fears was confirmed.

His entire family was amongst the dead, slain.

Karreo wailed as he backed away from the carnage, hyperventilating. He couldn't tear his eyes away from his family's bloodied corpses as footsteps came up behind him.

He turned to run, crashing right into the Clawed Fist.

"Easy, easy, tahee!" The demorin's arms wrapped around him as Karreo bawled. The child was too dazed with grief to struggle free.

The demorin petted his back gently, holding him tight. "Shh, shh... You're safe now, it's over."

Dismay rocked Karreo as he howled and cried, despair swallowing him whole. He buried his face into the man, too desperate for solace to contain himself.

"Hey, we need to get this kid out of here!" The man called out to someone beyond.

The idea of leaving his family had him shoving out of the embrace and hurrying back into the room. "W-we-we can't leave th-th-th-them!"

The man caught his hand before he escaped, Karreo hopelessly struggling against his grasp.

"Tahee, I'm sorry, they're gone. We have to get you out of here before there's more danger."

Karreo reached his free hand towards his slain kin, sputtering and sobbing. "No...No... No, no, no, no..."

"We'll give them a proper burial, Tahee, I promise you. But, please, we need to go."

Karreo crumpled in defeat, too despondent to put up a fight any longer.

The man scooped Karreo up, holding tight as he carried the child away from the nightmare. "Shhh. They can't hurt you anymore. We'll take care of you, Tahee."

Valen

The sudden rush of water enveloping him forced open his eyes with a gasp. He barely got a breath in before he was plunged underwater with force.

He attempted to calibrate himself, adrenaline coming to his aid as it pumped through his veins. His hands were bound, but he was able to kick and cease his descent. Nothing but a murky, green gloom surrounded him; he could hardly tell which way was up.

Bubbles from his nose were his compass. He followed them to the surface, breaking the waves with a yell.

"Hey!" He cried out, wincing against the water in his eyes. He struggled to keep his body upright between the binds and the swell. He started to sink before once again emerging with a shout. "Hey!!"

His hair was stuck to his face and blocking most of his vision as he scanned around frantically. All he saw was emptiness and fog; all he could hear was the sloshing of water.

He crudely paddled in a random direction, gasping and coughing against the barrage of waves. Desperate tears soaked his cheeks as he struggled on, his body sluggish and tiring quickly.

Hope was sapping away fast as he endeavored forward, unsure if he was even going in the right direction. "Help!" He screamed out into the dark, panic turning his swimming sloppy and uncoordinated.

Nothing but the lapping of water answered, his heartbeat pounding in his ears. He gasped with each breath and his body burned with fatigue. He *had* to get a grip or this was going to end with him drowning.

He managed to flip onto his back so he could float and regain some strength, his body bobbing with the surf. The water was not salty and there was only a minor current, so he figured he must be in a lake.

He mustered enough energy to press on, doing his best to keep his cool, but each toss of the waves chipped away at his resolution. His muscles were weakening far quicker than swimming had ever demanded of him; he felt heavier and heavier as he battled on, anemic.

Then, the rumble of a far off boat hummed somewhere from the fog. He set towards the noise at once, invigorated.

“Hey!” He coughed out, his voice cracking. “Hey!!”

The engine abruptly cut off, to his horror. “Help, please!”

“Is someone out there?” A teenage voice called out, dubious.

“Yes! Over here, help!” Valen sobbed with relief as the engine kicked back on. He couldn’t hang on for much longer; his body was just so, so tired.

The purr of the engine was approaching as the demorin’s legs lost their agency to kick. He bobbed in place, utterly exhausted, unable to catch his breath.

A light flashed onto him, but Valen’s world went dark.

Rorrik

“Ugh... I can’t believe we got stuck doing smuggle duty *again*...” a teenaged felidaren lamented, the sparse moonlight slipping through the cloud cover doing little to illuminate his gray tabby coat and dark outfit.

“Hey, it’s not so bad,” his older brother disagreed with his usual grin. “Maybe you can even get a quick swim in while we’re out here!”

The young catfolk wasn’t impressed with the joke as he scoffed towards the misty depths. Jumping into a supposedly haunted part of the lake said to have a monster in it was *not* his idea of fun. “Ffff *yeah*, I’ll leave the laps to you.”

Some of his apprehension must have betrayed him, for his sibling’s smile turned more mischievous. “Awwww, don’t wanna get wet? Or maybe you’re scared of Gara and her goons?”

“Knock it off, Jate.” He tried to be aloof, but the idea was creepy. He always was uncomfortable running the “1-way path” at night, but he wasn’t about to admit that.

"Well, you're in luck. Haven't spotted any dumpers out here tonight, so Gara won't be sniffing around for her latest snack," Jate kept up his teasing with a snicker.

"Don't make me give her one..." The felidaren muttered with a roll of his eyes.

They both giggled, but then Jate's ears perked and he jerked his head to stare out into the fog.

"Wait, Rorrik. Do you hear that?"

Rorrik's ears flattened and he hissed, hating how his tail frizzed with dread. "Seriously, Jate. Quit it."

"No, listen!" Jate leaned closer to the source of the "noise", rocking the boat.

Rorrik turned indignant. "I'm not a kit anymore! You really think I'm gonna fall for—"

"Hey!" A wayward shout cut him off, both of their tails doubling in fluff now. "Hey!"

The brothers shared a look of terror and Jate cut the motor, both of them pressing themselves into the floor of their dinky vessel.

"Help, please!" The voice cried, too young to be a cop and too panicked to be a rival.

"Is someone out there?" Jate called out, Rorrik swatting him with a growl. His brother shot him an unimpressed look instead of his usual cheese.

"Yes! Over here, help!"

"We gotta help him," Jate said, bringing the boat back to life to coast them *towards* the ghost.

"What?!" Rorrik forced himself into sitting up, but his heart still pittered with apprehension. "Jate— what about the job—"

Jate ignored his protest. "Grab the torch, will you?"

Rorrik was incredulous as he dug through their kit to fetch their flashlight. He hesitated before turning it on, fearful of what he might light up, but he swallowed down his apprehension with a surge of teenage gusto. Whatever was out there, he wasn't scared!

The beam pierced the fog as Rorrik scanned all around. Splashing and sputtering clued him in on where to shine, and a horned entity came into view.

The brothers jumped, but upon closer inspection, they realized it was just another kid; a demorin, by the looks of it. A drowning one, at that.

Jate didn't hesitate to toss off his shirt and dive overboard. Rorrik skidded to the edge of the boat and watched as his brother surfaced next to the demorin, forcing his sinking form back to the surface.

He led the kid to the side of the boat, where Rorrik helped hoist him over the lip and into their vessel.

Jate pulled himself back up, the boat slouching enough to tip. Rorrik hollered at him, afraid they would *all* be plunged into Gara's lair, but they regained stability.

Both of their attention now fell on their new visitor, Rorrik studying him with unexpected intrigue. The demorin was about his age, with handsome features and sharp dress. Rorrik almost didn't notice that the teenager's hands were bound, being distracted by other details.

Jate cut the binds, dragging Rorrik back to reality.

"Hey, whoa, maybe there's a reason he was tied up!"

"Why else would he be?" Jate grumbled, uncharacteristically grim.

Seems they had stolen a snack meant for Gara.

Jate started the motor back up and turned the boat in the opposite direction of their job.

"Jate, wait, Dad'll kill us if we don't complete this run." That had him more uneasy than the ghosts and sea monsters.

"We need to get him back to land – It's clear he's in trouble. Mom will have our back!"

Jate was right. Rorrik went back to studying their mysterious stowaway, patting him down for any weapons or things of interest. He noted a spyglass was attached to his belt, and when he flipped him over he saw his shirt was well-torn on the back.

"Holy—" Rorrik gasped as a glinting, star-like scar gleamed beneath the fabric, catching the dim moonlight. It was a gnarly wound, or at least it *had* been; It looked completely healed over now.

"What?" Jate wondered in suspense.

"He's got a huge scar on his back!"

"Pff. Got right to disrobing him, eh?"

"N-no—" Rorrik's cheeks flashed, but he shook that off. "His shirt has a hole there, like it— just happened or something."

"...But it's healed?" Jate was puzzled and Rorrik matched the feeling. Who healed their victim before dumping them?

"Maybe he healed it himself?" Rorrik wagered, and Jate nodded.

"That would make sense."

Rorrik went back to studying the demorin, assessing his strong but gentle features and the way his ebony hair was twisting as it dripped. He looked at the curve of his horns and the shape of his tail; curious. He had never gotten the chance to see a demorin up close before; he was definitely a sight to behold.

The demorin suddenly coughed and stirred, Rorrik's tail frizzing as his admiration screeched to a halt. He leaned over the fellow teenager, helping him wake up with a gentle shake.

"Hey, you alright?" He asked, to which the demorin's eyes popped open.

They became ensnared in each other's gaze, Rorrik's emerald on the demorin's topaz.

"W-Wher.. Wha... wha—" the other teen stammered, disoriented. He was already losing strength fast, despite his panicked, pointed questions. Well, at least attempts at them.

"Hey, relax, we're getting you help," Rorrik attempted to ease with a lopsided grin.

The demorin gaped at him, the tabby's fur burning hot on his cheeks as their eye contact kept.

Then, the demorin dispelled the intensity to close his eyes, breathing hard, but with relief. "Thank... you..."

Rorrik opened his mouth to reply, but nothing but an uncertain murmur answered. It went silent but for the lapping water and their buzzing motor.

Jate broke the quiet with a snicker of disbelief. "Well, you wanted out of smuggle duty, right?"

Chapter 25

Rorrik

Their mysterious castaway was evidently seriously anemic, according to their medic, Fennfell Waye. The brothers had drug the demorin to their private clinic, Fenn receiving them with appropriate urgency.

They had placed their hands on the demorin to magically scan his condition before taking blood and hooking him up to the works.

Vitals told the demorin's heart was slow, but still beating, while the blood test showed a critical lack of hemoglobin. Hence, the anemia.

"You just... found him swimming in the middle of the lake?" Fenn again asked for clarification, completely dumbfounded, and indeed the events seemed unreal even for the brothers to recollect.

"Well, swimming is a bit of a stretch," Jate elaborated with a hesitant chuckle. "He was more on his way to drowning."

The petite floraling fussed with the stranger's hookups, their emerald features taut with concern. They hung a bag of black blood onto the IV caddy, the flowers in their hair quivering as they shook their head. "Well, if the water hadn't killed him, the blood loss was on its way to. Though, I can't find any fresh wounds, external or otherwise, that would explain the amount of blood loss."

"Well, you saw the scar, right?" Rorrik assumed.

"Which one?" Fenn said with a scoff.

The tabby tilted his head. "There's more?"

"He's got a pretty gnarly one on his abdomen, and an even worse one on his back," the plantkin explained. "Both completely healed, luckily."

"So... he'll be okay?" the felidaren cautiously hoped.

"I believe so. Just give the transfusion time to do its thing." Fenn glanced over the clipboard at the side of the bed, their opal eyes widening. "Oh! I also found trace amounts of Faint Flax in his bloodstream."

The demorin had been *poisoned*, too?

What in all of Azyria had he been up to; checking off a list of every bad day he could possibly have in one night?!

“He better have quite the story when he wakes up,” Jate remarked with a head shake of disbelief.

“I’d say,” Fenn agreed. “Anyhow, we’ll be in touch over his condition. For now, you’d better go break the news to Panther. I imagine that’s a bit more urgent than watching an IV drip.”

More urgent maybe, but a *lot* less enticing.

“It is about that time,” Jate said with a nervous chuckle. He faced his younger brother with a lopsided grin. “Ready to talk to dear-old-dad, Rorrik?”

“You’re the one who *insisted* we come back before we finished the job,” Rorrik reminded with a flattening of his ears.

“Oh, because you tried *so hard* to talk me out of it,” Jate scoffed. “The way I remember it, you were too busy ogling.”

Rorrik slapped him with his tail, too flustered for a quip and unimpressed with the accusation. Jate only laughed.

“Look, I’ll take the blame, alright? Just back me up, that’s all I ask.”

The tabby spared a look at the clinic bed and the unconscious demorin who laid there. He was already much less pale as blood returned to his system, a stark difference to how they’d found him. Rorrik knew he’d either be white as a ghost or in the belly of Gara if they hadn’t intervened; he wouldn’t let his father’s fury make him regret that.

“I got you, don’t worry...” Rorrik grumbled to his brother, pulling his eyes off of the castaway to walk out of the room. He hissed in the dim hallway light. “Come on, let’s go get this over with.”

Their father was already waiting for them when they stepped into headquarters, his muscular arms crossed and tail ticking. His black, spotted face was scrunched in a scowl; his piercing yellow eyes drilling.

“Heeeey, Dad!” Jate started, attempting to defuse with a little wave and nervous grin.

The futility of their task fully dawned on Rorrik as he folded against his father's ire with a nervous glance to his feet. '*We are **so** dead...*'

"You mind telling me why you're both slouching here instead of completing the contract?" His father spoke in a low growl, on the edge of anger, but not quite across that threshold.

They would have to tread carefully to keep it that way.

"Dad, it's— it's the funniest thing, really!" Jate looked to Rorrik for backup, who managed to contribute a hurried nod. "You're not going to believe it!"

"Try me," the older felidaren grunted, ever unimpressed.

"Well, we were out on the lake, making great time, when we heard someone calling for help."

Their father's unenthralled look held. "At Gara's Haunt?"

They both nodded.

"Where our rivals *take out their trash*? What made you think it would be a good idea to intervene?!"

Jate winced and Rorrik helplessly tried to gulp down his bubbling panic.

"I—I don't think this was anything like that!" Jate spoke fast. "This guy — he's just a kid! Rorrik's age! He was still alive and out there swimming! Well, um, drowning."

Their father's brow twitched at that.

"If he was being dumped, surely they would have killed him first, right?" Jate pressed.

The silence was deafening as their parent weighed that. He finally shook his head, a low growl rumbling in his chest. "I still fail to see how it was your business."

"We couldn't just leave him!" Jate held, elbowing Rorrik into nodding too. "He was going to die out there! He's just a kit, Dad!"

Their father stepped up to jab a claw at his older brother. "*You're* just a kit, too. Don't act like you aren't!"

Jate recoiled with embarrassment before dispelling the shame with a flattening of his ears. "Well—"

"You're making decisions you have no clearance for," he hissed. "Because of your little rescue mission, we could lose a client and have to rebuild credibility!"

"Pff, drops don't work out all the time," Jate excused, his indignation evaporating as he attempted to restore brevity. "Just make up some excuse!"

Their father wrinkled his nose and shook his head. "No, that will be *your* job. *Do not* mess it up this time." His focus landed on Rorrik, who accordingly shrunk with dread.

"And what do *you* have to say about this?"

"Uhhh—" He did his best to summon his prior conviction. "W—what were we supposed to do, Dad? It's... not like we could just let him die."

Their father sighed, frustrated, but not booming with the level of anger they had been bracing for. "Ugh. Where is this kid now – what did he have to say?"

"We brought him to Fenn. We, um, didn't get the chance to chat 'cause he passed out on us..." Jate revealed with a nervous chuckle.

"How convenient," their father spat with bitter sarcasm. "The bill is coming out of your paychecks. *And* the loss."

"Of course!" Jate agreed, but Rorrik groaned. There went his spending money for the *month*.

The dappled catfolk squeezed the bridge of his nose, huffing away steam. "Jate, report to _____. But, do *not* reveal what actually happened, do you understand?"

Jate saluted. "Got it, boss."

"We don't know who this kid is and who or what they were involved with. Until we do, we haven't seen him, haven't heard of him, *nothing*, am I clear?"

They confirmed with a nod, and the father looked between his sons with tired exasperation. "You kids sure know how to complicate everything..."

"You and Mom taught us well!" Jate quipped, and Rorrik smirked despite the danger.

He swatted them both away with a hiss. "Now get out of here. Scram."

Chapter 26

Valen

He was playing in the river with Karreo, both of them hooting with laughter, as their parents watched from the bank. They were calling out to them, but Valen couldn't hear with all the splashing.

He stopped to look over when he noticed the beach was much further away than usual, stretching inexplicably far. The distance was so great that he struggled to make out his parents' visage, and their voices were fleeting despite their splashing having ceased.

He was struck with a sense of confusion that was mutating into panic. He trudged through the shin-high water, yelping out for his parents to wait, but the distance was expanding in front of him. The water rose higher around his knees, and then his waist. He managed to yell out before it surged past his head, plunging him entirely under.

He struggled against the deep, kicking furiously as his hands were suddenly tied. He spotted the outline of his parents appear above him, their silhouettes rippling as they reached down and pulled him to the surface.

He was on his back now, dripping wet and coughing, his eyes too heavy to open. He could sense his family next to him, but then that feeling began to fade, riling him into forcing his eyes open.

An unfamiliar pair of green eyes were peering at him, framed by gray-brown tabby fur. The face they belonged to was unclear, his vision was too obstructed to make out any detail.

He closed his eyes again, his world spinning and his heart aching. He whimpered out for his father and mother, terrified to be without them.

A current of comfort answered his plea, lulling him into peace. He lingered there in his parents arms, not ready to let go, but a bright light was building and he was forced to shield his eyes.

The scent of disinfectant and chirping of medical machinery received him from his fractured dream. His eyes were wet with tears as he squinted around the room, his surroundings foreign. Disorientation punctuated his every thought as he tried to move, finding his limbs slow to respond and burdensome.

"Hey, you're finally awake," an unknown voice greeted.

Valen winced in the direction of the greeting, finding an androgynous floraling approaching his bedside. They fussed with the medical equipment Valen was apparently attached to before hovering a hand above his arm. A brief glow emanated from their palm and they nodded to themselves. "You're looking good. A lot better than when you came in."

"Wah..." Valen's mind desperately attempted calibration, but his reckoning was stubborn to bloom. He proceeded to sift through the grog and confusion, only for realization to abruptly flatten him.

A whirlwind of memories assaulted his consciousness. Aunt Lucia, Karreo mentioning something was wrong with the food, waking up to bloody conflict, and...

He grasped at the back of his shoulder blades with a gasp. He'd been mortally stabbed, and yet here he was? Alive?

A nebulous recounting of helplessly laying there bleeding as his parents fussed over him played at the edge of his memory. He could hazily recall them pleading him to stay alive, and their corresponding intervention. Had they somehow healed him?

But then, where were they now?!

The remnant of his recollection told the truth, but he did not want to believe it. He couldn't.

Regardless if he accepted it or not: they were gone, murdered by the very folk who had promised to *help* them.

But then, where was Karreo?!

His mother's wispy plea echoed. "*Please, help your brother. He'll be... he'll be so lost without you.*"

That had to mean... Karreo was still out there – alive!

"You must be overwhelmed," the floraling intruded his revelation. "It's alright, try to relax. Let's get that heart rate back down."

Indeed, the machine was beeping frantically. Valen had been too turbulent to notice, but now it was impossible to ignore. He covered his ears, a silent wail splitting his lips.

The medic sighed before laying their hand on him again, a pulse of tranquility flashing from their fingertips. It snuffed out his panic like an extinguisher to a flame, roping his heart rate back into a more agreeable rhythm.

The hysteria was gone, but not the trauma. He closed his eyes, his lips shuddering as his heart and mind grappled with the cruel reality he'd been cast into. The amorphous memory of his parents' farewell played over and over again, like a stuck record. Despite it all, he still could not bring himself to accept it. It was too painful. Nothing felt real; it had to be some kind of dream, or perhaps a misunderstanding.

Had Karreo been cut down and healed, too? If that was the case, where was he now?!

"M-my brother," he forced out in a croak. "Where is my brother?"

The floraling beheld him with a frown. "I'm... sorry, but they didn't bring anybody else back."

"Wah—who—" The vividness of those green eyes flashed in his mind. That's right – he'd come-to in the lake, when a young felidaren had fished him out.

Where was Karreo, then, if he'd not been dumped with Valen?

Too many unthinkable scenarios answered that wonder.

"They didn't see anybody else?!"

"Not... that they mentioned. Would you want to speak with them?"

"Yes!" Valen answered instantly, aflame from all the uncertainty. Panic was building yet again, but another mysterious touch from the medic reeled it back in.

With that, the plantkin left his bedside with a nod. "I'll contact them at once."

They left the room, leaving Valen to sort through the rubble of his shattered life. He plunged his head in his hands, his shoulders rocking with a violent sob.

Everyone and everything was gone; he was all alone.

Rorrik

Sudden afternoon light insisted at Rorrik's eyelids, coming on way too strong. He rolled over with a grumble, uninterested in any and all propositions that required him leaving the comfort of his bed.

"Somebody's sleepy!" Came his mother's sing-songed voice from in front of his window, explaining the abrupt flood of sun. "I heard you had quite the time last night!"

He merely grunted in reply. The young felidaren wasn't ready to give yet another run-down, especially if it meant waking up. He'd already exhausted the story to his father, management, the rest of his brothers... Surely she'd heard it from one or all of them by now?

"Oh, I see... You're still pretty tired, huh..." Her tone trailed off in a way that promised intrigue, and she waited a baited second before continuing. "I suppose you don't wanna come with me to go question him, then?"

Rorrik rolled back over with a start. "He woke up?!"

The calico catfolk giggled, amused at his turn around. "Not too long ago, yes."

Apparently Rorrik wasn't as tired as he thought.

He stretched with gusto before springing to his feet. His mother took the cue and exited the room.

"As soon as you're ready, meet me down in the lobby. Don't drag your tail; Dad wants this done ASAP." She called out from the hallway.

She needn't tell him twice.

—

"Not that I didn't already mention on the phone. He's a bit raw, so I would proceed carefully." the floraling said.

"Not to worry; we won't drill him too much," the torbie assured. She turned to her son and made a show of gaudily nodding. "We'll go slow and not overwhelm him, hm?"

He recognized a chastising comment when he heard it. He smirked, albeit with a touch of chagrin. "What are you looking at me for?"

"Well, I know you, kit. You can be... a lot at times."

"Mom, it's fine. I'm not gonna, like, prank him or something."

Her green eyes were soft but serious as she shook her head. "It's not that, cub. It's just... we don't know whatever he's been through. I need you to be... sensitive to that."

Rorrik looked to the wall with a thoughtful bob. He had figured whatever led the demorin to such a bad night was not a good time, sure, but had he fully considered those ramifications?

He was suddenly a tad more nervous to properly meet his new friend. Something told the felidaren the fellow teen wouldn't exactly be up for a night on the town or any antics just yet.

Indeed, they'd have to take it slow and sensitive.

Fenn led them to the demorin's room and knocked, and a defeated voice told them to "come in".

The demorin was laying on the bed, appearing weak but a lot more with-it than they'd left him. The teenager's yellow eyes widened as they walked in, and the two of them caught each other's stare.

"It's you—" The demorin gasped with an intensity that made the fur on Rorrik's cheeks tingle.

"Ahm... Hey there!" Rorrik gave a little wave. "You're... a lot less wet this time!"

What a stupid joke. Why did he say that?

The demorin blinked before shaking off the felidaren's wisecrack. "You— you rescued me out there in the water, right? Did you— did you see anybody else?! Hear anything? See anything?"

Rorrik's ears fell as he frowned. "Um... Sorry. It was... it was just you."

The demorin winced and dropped his gaze, Rorrik hating to deflate whatever hope the fellow teen had.

"Why? Who else would there be?" His mother stepped in, gentle.

"My... my brother..." The demorin muttered without lifting his head. "He... he has to be out there. They healed me— they— they had to have healed him, too!"

"*Who* healed you?" Fenn asked now.

"My..." The demorin squeezed his eyes shut. His mouth opened, but nothing but a pained gasp left his lips. Then, raw and bleeding: "My... parents..."

His mother stepped closer to kneel in front of the bed. "Can you tell us what happened to you? Your family?"

They all watched him intently, Rorrik especially so.

The teen shakily sighed before forcing out his tale, fighting for every word. "I... I don't even know where to start... we... we were... We were attacked."

The calico catfolk nodded; the family had surmised as much. "By who?"

"They... they call themselves the Clawed Fist... They were... they were supposed to be helping us but they... he..." The demorin's sentence fizzled out.

Rorrik hadn't heard of any group or gang by that name, but that was a positive sign. At least they weren't housing a rival's loose end.

As the demorin gathered himself, his parent glanced at Rorrik expectantly. Oh, right, he should be taking notes...

He scrawled out '*Missing brother, attacked, Clawed Fist, betrayal*' on a notepad he fetched from his pocket.

"Why did this 'Clawed Fist' attack your family?" his mom pressed on.

The demorin shook his head with a grimace. "My Father... my father refused to join them... and they... they attacked him, b-but he got away. So we— my family— came here to escape... but... but..."

"Here?"

"T-to Sengard..."

Ah, so he was an out-of-towner!

"...Where do you come from, then?"

A glossy look possessed his features as he choked on another reply. "W..we.... We're in the outer suburbs of A-Akarth. I-in... River...view..."

Akarth?! 'Out of Towner' was right!

...Rorrik couldn't recall any syndicates with that name in Akarth either, but his older brother Gavin would be the one to ask.

He jotted down the new information. *'Refusal to join caused attack, fled to Sengard from Akarth, town Riverview'*.

"You mentioned they were supposed to be helping you with something?" His mother backtracked.

The demorin remained almost zoned out. "They... said they would help us with... discrimination and violence. But it... it was all fine... *perfect*... until... until them..."

"What do you mean?"

"They ruined everything... It was all... it was all perfect... Oh... *oh gods*." The demorin squeezed his eyes shut before burying his face into his hands.

`8i

'Life was fine before group ruined everything' went into the notebook.

His mother beheld the demorin with swelling empathy, and she wasn't alone. "Oh, kit... I'm so sorry... What... happened when you were attacked?"

"They... they..." He rattled from behind his fingers. "They... killed... them... And... and.. They tried... they tried to kill me, too."

The scar Rorrik knew to be on the demorin's back popped into his head. The only thing rivaling the tabby's sympathy now was his intrigue.

"They stabbed me, but my parents... they... they were already gone, but they... they somehow healed me."

"How do you know it was your parents? Were they healers?" Fenn wondered.

"No. But... I... I remember them being there. It's all... so hazy. I just... I know it was them."

Fenn had a rare look of surprise. "So they healed you through will alone? If that's the case, that's... miraculous. It's healed over completely – it must have been some powerful magic."

"So, what about your brother then? Did you see him get..." His mom didn't finish the thought, but she didn't have to.

"I... I don't know. Everything happened so fast and it's... so hard to remember. But I... didn't see him with my parents on... the other side."

"And *you* were healed, so he probably was too!" Rorrik cut in with a surge of positivity.

The demorin sat a little straighter and hurriedly nodded. "That's – that's how I feel too! But... if Karreo— my brother— wasn't out there with me... then..."

"Don't worry, we'll help track down your brother," his mother assured.

The fellow teenager slowly nodded, albeit scarcely comforted.

"...How did you get out there in the lake anyways?" Rorrik couldn't help but wonder.

"I... I don't know. Last thing I remember was lying there before going unconscious, then suddenly I was waking up in the water."

"Did you see any kind of boat or vessel sail off?" His mother asked.

"No... I was just suddenly out in the water... alone. I swam for a bit, and, well..." The demorin looked to Rorrik. "That's when... you saved me..."

Rorrik didn't care to correct him that it was Jate who had insisted they check it out. He certainly didn't mind being the hero.

"Well, perhaps you were dumped and took a little while to come-to out in the lake," his parent brain-stormed.

"Maybe. But it... it's almost like I was dropped from high up. I sunk for awhile before I was able to kick to the surface..."

The mother and son shared a stumped look. There wasn't an easy explanation for that.

A pause in conversation gave Rorrik a moment to jot down a couple more notes. 'Parents killed. Was stabbed, but healed. Has memory of parents healing him on "other side". Brother MIA. Car-ee-oh. Was dropped into lake from height? Didn't see boat.'

"Well, regardless of *how* you got there... This 'Clawed Fist' probably thinks you're out there at the bottom of the lake," the calico assumed. "If they knew you lived, I highly doubt they would have let you go."

The demorin processed that with a heavy brow. "Then... what do I do now?"

"That's a good question!" The mother stood up from her knelt position. "You'll have to lie low for a bit."

Rorrik leapt on the prospect before his mother could continue. "Oh! Come to the Den – it'll be safe there!"

The torbie shot him a look, but it was primarily of bemusement. "As my son said, we have a room for you at the Den while you get your bearings."

"The... where?"

"The Panther's Perch Inn. We'll have everything you need to get you back on your feet, cub. But first, we need something from you..."

The demorin beheld her with wary expectation.

"We never did get your name, kit." She smiled, glad to dispel his worries.

The demorin stammered before running a hand through his wavy hair, his maroon cheeks flushing with a rosy-purple. He held out a clawed hand. "I'm Valen. Valen Vaaskiir."

His parent received Valen's outstretched hand in both of hers. "Pleased to meet you, cub. My name is Kyla Cattiaikin, buuut you can call me Mrs. Catty for short. And this is," she gestured to her son, but he was already hopping up to do the honors.

"Rorrik! Rorrik Cattiaikin." He gripped the fellow teenager's hand, a jolt zipping up his arm as they touched, frizzing his fur.

Valen managed a weak smile, his citrine eyes shimmering even just a tad brighter. "Well, Rorrik, Mrs. um... Catty. Thank you..." He gingerly took his hand back and released a tired sigh. "For... everything."

Chapter 27

Valen

The medic tending to him, Fenn he learned their name was, deemed him stable enough to discharge later that day.

"If anything changes or worsens, contact me at once," they told him as they removed his IV. "Please, take it easy."

The floraling led him outside, and Rorrik was there to pick him up. Wait, no, that wasn't right.

He looked an awful-lot *like* Rorrik, but he was taller, older, and had darker tabby fur.

He was leaned up against a vehicle, but stood at attention when the two approached. "Valen, right?" He spoke in a deeper voice than Rorrik; he was either in his late teens or early twenties.

Valen slowly nodded. Up close he could spot more nuanced differences in facial features; he only imagined this must be a relative of Rorrik's.

"I'm Gavin. You've met my mother and brother," the tabby introduced himself, confirming Valen's suspicion. Gavin looked to Fenn and dismissed them with a nod. "I got it from here, Fenn."

The floraling bowed. "Be well, Valen."

"Ahm... thank you for your care, Fenn," Valen said in a small voice, an echo of his polite personality. The plantkin offered him a gentle grin and wave before taking their leave, and Gavin opened the car door.

"Shall we?"

They stepped into the vehicle and Valen sluggishly buckled himself in. He felt like a passenger in his own body; the words and motions he performed were through no type of choice or deliberation. Events were simply happening *to* him; the world was hazy and dreamish from his bunker of shock.

"The Panthers Perch isn't too far from here," Gavin mentioned as he began to drive. The streets back wherever they were were slow. The felidaren cleared his throat after a brief pause. "So, I've got a couple questions for you, if you don't mind..."

Valen waited for his inquiries as the static in his brain whirled.

"The way I've heard it, you're supposed to be dead..."

Valen squirmed at the observation. He wasn't sure how to respond; all he could muster was a "yeah..."

"Definitely going to have to lay low for a bit then," the tabby muttered. "Lucky for you, that's our specialty."

He didn't have the energy to put much thought into that comment as he watched the sparse traffic pass by. However, it was starting to pick up as they turned onto another road.

The catfolk stared intently at the road ahead. "Sooo, do you have any friends or family we can reach out to when the dust settles down?"

"I... have an Aunt who lives in Sengard but... but I don't think she's... around... anymore." His heart was too petrified for further grief at the realization; it was barely beating within its stony tomb.

"Is this the same Aunt you were staying with?" His tone maintained leveled professionalism, which Valen valued over pity in that moment.

"Yes," the demorin confirmed with downtrodden accord.

"8724 Sycamore Way? Southbank district?"

Valen was startled to hear her address; how was he savvy to that information? "Uh—yes..!"

Gavin nodded nonchalantly. "I'll check it out."

"How—how did..."

"I know? Heh, that's my job." He spared Valen a brief smirk. "I know things. And if I don't know, I know how to find out."

He talked like one of the detectives in Karreo's stories. Valen might have been more impressed if not for the circumstances.

"...What else do you know, then?"

Gavin began to rattle off fact after fact, casual. "I know you're from Riverview in a house that was paid for in full 16 years ago, 620 Bankside Drive. You're a registered mage with a level A4 permit, your father owns an enchanted tailoring business called the _____, you're a good student with a ____ GPA, your mother was a high ranking member of the Scarlet Buckle guild, your brother is aged eleven, while you just turned fifteen last month on the 24th..."

Valen gaped at him. "How... do you know *any* of that?"

"I have my ways," Gavin shrugged. An amused twitch lifted the corner of his smirk. "And, you know, public records are a thing."

Valen was stunned, but too overwhelmed to dwell on that surprise. “You really can help me find Karreo, then!”

“We’ll track down your brother, yes.” Gavin said. “Let’s start with the basics. Describe him for me?”

“He’s... a demorin— obviously... pretty quiet, but really smart...” Valen trailed off as worry squeezed his throat. “Red skin, black hair, yellow eyes. His... horns haven’t come in all that much yet.”

Gavin mentally noted the information with a bob of his head. “Can you describe where you were attacked?”

“Ahm... It all... happened so fast. It was... a big room?”

“So, it wasn’t at your Aunt’s house?”

“No... definitely not.”

“Understood.” He clicked his tongue and appeared thoughtful. “So the group antagonizing your family is The Clawed Fist...”

He said it more like a statement than a question, but Valen still nodded.

“Seems they’re branching out into more than just politics...”

“You’ve heard of them?” He shouldn’t be surprised, considering the rest of what Gavin knew.

“Not as much as I’d like,” Gavin admitted. “I know they’re a group based in ____ and have a presence in quite a few major cities. Can’t say I’ve ever heard of them doing anything like this, but most orgs maintain a squeaky clean PR. We know better, though, don’t we? I’ll be looking deeper into it.”

So Gavin’s knowledge *did* have limitations.

“Well, do you have any questions for me?” The felidaren wondered.

Valen considered it, but only one pressing wonder was on his mind. “How do you plan to find Karreo?”

“First step will be tracking down where the attack happened. I’ve a suspicion it was down by the bay— considering you ended up in the lake, and it wouldn’t be the first seedy thing to happen down there.”

That made sense.

"I'll check around your aunt's too. And, of course, we've got eyes and ears all over the city."

They did? It was the second loaded comment, but Valen didn't have the energy to unpack that quite yet.

Gavin was quiet as they drove on, allowing Valen a reprieve from the questioning. He proceeded to watch the traffic flow outside; the roads were more congested now, but still flowing. He leaned his head against the glass and closed his citrine eyes against the heaviness compressing him.

They at last pulled into a tucked away parking lot at the back of a moderately large three-story building. It was clad in a facade of gray and brown cobblestone, commonplace for Sengard's older architecture.

Gavin parked the car and offered him a half-grin. "This is it. Follow me."

They walked up to a back door, which the felidaren unlocked before gesturing to him to walk inside. Valen did so by the grace of his autopilot, and a hum of distant commotion and smell of warm food welcomed him. Despite the pit in his gut, his stomach stirred at the aroma.

They looked to be standing in a storage room of sorts. Gavin didn't skip a beat as he led them ahead, past the boxes and shelves and into a kitchen.

A burly felidaren with sandy brown fur and tawny hair turned to greet them, his markings reminding Valen of a puma. He grinned from beneath a thick, curled beard, his whiskers twitching. "Ah. Been expecting you, lad. Welcome to the Panther's Perch!"

This must be the father of Rorrik and Gavin. Valen dipped his head sheepishly, falling into a social script. "Thank you, sir."

"The name's Russell Spear Tooth." The catfolk held out his hand and Valen shook it.

"I'm Valen Vaaskiir." The words tasted numb.

"Well there, Valen. We got a room all set for you. Go take a gander, get some rest, then come fill your belly. Can't imagine Fenn fed you much, eh?"

Valen forced a meager grin. "That's very kind of you, thanks."

Gavin nodded and jerked his head for them to get moving. "This way, Valen."

Valen followed with one final nod to the felidaren, who saw them off with a chuckle.

They navigated a set of hallways before arriving in front of a door that read '103'. Gavin seamlessly revealed an old fashioned toothed key and held it out.

Valen received it, affording himself a smidgen of curiosity. '*Huh... that's a bit of a novelty.*'

"This is it. Inside you'll find a few changes of clothes, soaps, and anything else you should need to make yourself comfortable." Another smooth motion revealed a sleek rectangle in the tabby's palm.

Valen's brow lifted at the sight of it. Was that a mobile responder?

"If you need anything, we'll be in touch with this responder. My contact information as well as several other IDs are already saved."

Wait, it was for *him*?!

Valen received it with a wide-eyed gape. He'd never handled a portable responder before, only landlines! This model was far more modern than anything he was used to, on top of that.

"Well, I'll let you get settled in. I've got a lot of work to get to. I'll be seeing you." Gavin was off after a little salute, Valen barely forcing out a small "thank you" in time.

He faced the door and sunk the metal key in the hole, twisting to unlock it with a solid click.

Inside was a small but charming room with a full bed, a desk, and a bathroom. A few pairs of clothes were laid out on top of a dresser, and the tub was stocked with soaps. Even a comb and toothbrush were on top of the sink.

His eye caught his reflection in the mirror, and he balked at the state of himself. A mop of greasy, tangled hair, oily, sunken skin, and filthy, torn clothes had him looking absolutely *wretched*. He had been walking around in this state?!

A shower was absolutely in order, despite the urge to wallow. Soap had *never* felt so necessary as layers of filth rubbed off.

He was scrubbing his shoulders when he felt a bump of raised skin on his back. He paused and traced his hand as far down as he could reach, confused. Then, recognition slammed into him. '*Right, the... scar.*'

When his shower was finished, he did his best to crane his neck around to see the damage in the mirror. A crude, star-like scar glowered from between his shoulder blades, glinting proof of his terrible ordeal. It made the one on his abdomen seem small and unremarkable.

It was a bit poetic, really.

He couldn't convince himself to stare for long. He hastily combed his hair and took refuge in a pair of the spare clothes, which were thankfully loose and comfortable.

He hunkered down on the bed with a sigh, too fatigued to keep his eyes open any longer. The drone of static enveloped him from the dark of his eyelids, and he succumbed to a harried slumber.

Chapter 28

Kyla

It was the next morning.

Kyla was sat in the living room, thumbing through Gavin's report when her ears flicked from approaching footsteps. Her mate's dark form appeared in her peripherals, his tail a pendulum.

"Can you explain to me when exactly we became a charity?!" He muttered, a growl rumbling in his chest.

She lifted her head to meet his yellow daggers. "Oh? That would be news to me."

He was not impressed with the retort. "Don't be coy, Kyla. What exactly were you thinking bringing him here?!"

"Who's being coy?" she challenged. "I don't think you're understanding the situation, love." She patted the spot next to her on the loveseat and he complied, huffy as ever.

"*Explain* it to me, then." He sounded so doubtful. "How is housing some one's loose end without any benefit to us *not* charity?"

She handed him the report so he could take a look for himself. “That ‘loose end’ happens to be quite the catch. Young, magically gifted, intelligent...” She paused for effect. “Powerful...”

Nii’em’s brow furrowed, and he kept reading. She waited patiently for him to see her point: his innate aptitude score, grade point average, report of suspected high level magic...

The panther shook his head after glancing through the document. “So he happens to be gifted. *But*, Gavin recovered this information *after* you invited him here.”

“It was a bit of a gamble, sure,” she admitted. “But the way I saw it: here was a kid who clearly had something special about him falling right into our laps. We’d be foolish to send him off.”

“Did you forget the part about him being a target for murder?” Nii’em grumbled. “You really want to make an enemy we know *nothing* about by helping him?”

“His enemies think he’s at the bottom of Gard Lake, hun. To them he’s dead. Why else would they have dumped him?”

The ebony felidaren hissed under his breath at that. “So what’s your angle, then?”

“We help this kid get back on his feet, and he helps us in return. He’s got a lot of potential, he just needs some time.”

“...So he’s an investment then.”

The mother in her didn’t like that wording. “That’s a bit... callous of a way to look at it, but...” It was technically true.

“Hmph.” He handed the report over and stood up to leave. “Let’s hope this gamble of yours is worth it, then.”

“It will be.” She decided to lean into the metaphor. “We just have to play our cards right.”

The rest of her morning consisted of the near impossible: herding cats, for a family meeting was underway.

Indeed, it took much hounding, writs, and deduction, but by the grace of Nocturna’s luck, she was able to gather all *seven* of her children into the meeting room

"I'm sure you've all heard by now that we have a special guest staying at the Perch," she began, a reception of hurriedly bobbing heads answering her. Her children looked remarkably similar to one another, as most shared a similar gray tabby coat, green eyes, lithe form, and brown hair. Their facial features and markings offered little assistance in telling them apart, but, being their mother, Kyla had an easy enough time.

She shushed the threatening burst of comments.

"We need to be clear on just how serious it is to keep his presence here a secret. No discussing his presence here to *anyone* outside of our circle. Secondly..."

They all waited.

"Make sure you take it slow with him. Pace yourselves out. There's a lot of you, and I know you're all eager to meet him, just... don't overwhelm him right out of the gate, hm?"

Jate, her second oldest at seventeen, laughed. His frame was more muscular than the rest of his siblings, but he was still lean and amble. His fur was a lighter gray, while his hair was long and tied back. "Aww, but we were gonna have so much fun with him!"

"Yeah, there goes the plans for a new test subject..." Quinn, the third of her children at sixteen, joined the teasing. Quinn was the most eccentric of the bunch, but it made his job of tinkering and inventing a lucrative one. His tabby fur was the lightest shade, and his medium length mane was commonly tousled and chaotic.

"What, so we can't even talk to him?" Calvin, the third youngest at fourteen, protested. His striped coat was warmer hued than his brothers, and his wavy, chin-length hair was veering on red. Calvin usually had something bitey or smart to say.

"I'm not saying that," the mother clarified.

"He's been through a lot is Mom's point," Gavin came to her aid. He was the first born of all her children, aged eighteen, and his charcoal gray tabby coat was particularly dark. He sported more spots than his brothers, and his straight, almost black hair was worn just above his shoulders. Gavin worked full time as an informant, which he was exceptionally good at.

"Yeah, he doesn't need you all getting in his face, stressing him out," Rorrik contributed. Rorrik was right in the middle of all her children, currently fourteen but rapidly approaching his fifteenth birthday. His shoulder-length hair was often brushed back, and his tabby fur was a warm gray.

"Yeah, he's too busy having *you* in his face," Jate quipped with a knowing smirk. Jate and Rorrik often bantered, as did most of her boys, but it was all in good humor.

Rorrik's eye roll and tail slap challenged that.

"Soooo, he's here secretly?" Talis, her second youngest, wondered. Talis was thirteen as of that spring, but his youthful energy and cutesy appearance concealed that fact. His thick, chestnut hair was on the shorter end of medium, and the gray of his fluffier coat could just as well be described as brown.

Kyla nodded. "Just while everything is fresh."

"...Because people want to hurt him?" Came the small voice of her youngest, Aylee, aged eleven, the only girl out of seven. Instead of a gray tabby coat, she had a tortoiseshell pattern with patches of ginger stripes, much like her mother. Instead of the rest of the family's varying shade of green, her eyes were the same stark yellow as her father's. Her dark, brunette hair was long, and her bangs reached into her eyes.

"Unfortunately, cub, yes. But, he'll be safe here, as long as we all do our part in keeping it that way." She looked amongst them, serious. "Can I trust you all to do that?"

They each confirmed in their own manner, and she nodded in turn. "Great. As you were, then!"

—

Valen

It was evidently already the next morning when he awoke. Being his room lacked any windows, there was no sunlight to clue him in, only the clock on his nightstand. It read 11:42, nearly noon!

Despite it all, he was still impossibly tired.

He laid there on his back, his thick hair encroaching his face, knotty and misshapen from sleeping with it wet. It was bad practice, but he'd been too exhausted to care. Even now, he'd rather wallow than attend to his hygiene.

...But he did *really* have to use the bathroom.

It was only by his bladder's insistence that he was forced out of bed. He avoided looking in the mirror until he was washing his hands, and his mop was as gnarly as he suspected.

The sight riled him into action. He got to taming the beast with a wet brush, gentle but steady. It was frizzy and flat when he was done, but at least it was more agreeable...?

He scrunched his hands through it to encourage more volume and sighed. It would have to do.

A knock at his door had him changing gears in a tizzy. He felt entirely out of sorts and not exactly willing for company, but he wasn't going to be impolite either. He was about to open the door, but paused to cautiously peep through the hole.

Rorrik was standing there, a tray of food in-hand. He waved towards the peephole, making eye contact despite the view being one-way, a smirk tugging at the corner of his lips. "It's just me," he eased before hoisting the platter. "I brought snacks!"

Valen opened the door just enough to let the felid in, who did so with a bounce in his step.

"Good morning. Orrr should I say good afternoon!" The fellow teenager snickered. "How'd you sleep?"

'Like the dead...' "Uh— j-just fine, thanks."

"You gotta be hungry; Rusty said you never stopped by for dinner last night!"

'Rusty?' Although there indeed was a pit in his belly, he couldn't say he felt like eating. That was, until he got a whiff of the unmistakable aroma of pancakes and maple.

The tabby handed over the tray, and Valen peeked inside at the bounty. His nose was correct: a stack of fluffy pancakes, eggs, potatoes, and fruit were on... both plates? Rorrik brought him two helpings?

"Welllll," the catfolk drew out the word in a loaded manner as he pointed towards the door and started to inch towards the exit. "I can let you dig into that..."

Valen squinted at the extra meal. "...Have *you* eaten yet?"

"Oh, uh, nope! Why do you ask?" He said it a bit too innocently.

The demorin found it in himself to smirk as he shook his head. "There's two plates of food here..."

"Well, if you're offering!" Rorrik chimed. He happily aborted his exit, yinked a plate off of the tray, and slid onto the chair by the desk. His movements were nimble and confident; Valen couldn't help but scoff, amused.

It wouldn't be the end of the world to have some company while he ate.

The demorin sat down on the bed with his own plate, using the tray as a makeshift table. He pecked at the dish as he weighed how to begin, settling on the fruit cup. He nibbled at a slice of orange before committing to the bite, the blast of flavor crisp on his tongue. It was sweet and tangy, a delectable sample of citrus.

He forked another mouthful as Rorrik cleared his throat.

“So, you’re 15, right?”

Valen paused his chewing at the question before awkwardly swallowing. “Uh– yes. Yeah.” Lucky guess, or had his brother clued him in?

“Me, too!” the tabby shared. “Well, at least, I *will* be in a couple days.”

“Oh, really?” So they *were* the same age.

“Yeah! On the 14th!”

“Oh, nice! My birthday was only a couple weeks ago, on the 24th of ‘May’.”

Rorrik laughed. “Ha! Happy late birthday!”

Valen managed a giggle, too. “Happy *early* birthday!”

Their laughter waned into silence, but Rorrik kept the conversation going.

“So, what are you into? Or– like,” the tabby shook his head and his whiskers twitched. “What do you like to do? For fun, I mean?”

It was cute to see him stagger a bit, considering his self-assured impression. Valen did wonder why such an innocent question had him stumbling, however...

“Um...” Normally, talking about himself wasn’t an endeavor, but his whole world *was* uprooted and in ruins. Even still, there was some autopilot to rescue him. “I... like magic.”

“Whoa, magic? What kind?” The felid’s excitement was enough to make him grin despite it all.

“Mostly illusions, but I got a few innate spells. I have a teacher that–” he tripped over some rubble. “Well, I... *did* have a teacher...”

Rorrik appeared to note the plunge. “Uh– what else do you like to do?”

“Um. I cook. And, I really like music...”

The tabby perked up yet again. “Really? What do you play?”

His acoustic guitar flashed into his psyche, its maroon stained wood glinting from the light of his bedroom window. It sat abandoned, the tension leaving its strings and dust gathering on its proud body. It would go unplayed forever on, left behind in a world ripped from him.

“The... guitar...”

“Oh, nice! I play, too! Or, well, I... dabble.”

Valen jumped on the chance to change the subject. “Really? What instrument?”

“There’s a piano in the lobby I goof off on, mainly. I’ve tried a little bit of everything, though. Drums, guitar, sax...”

Valen was genuinely impressed. “No kidding! Saxophone, really?”

The catfolk appeared almost sheepish. “Heh, yeah! I know it’s a bit weird—”

“Not at all! I think that’s really neat!”

Rorrik inflated with the praise. “Yeah, well, the inn has lots of spare instruments for gigs, sooo I thought why not experiment?”

“Naturally!” Valen agreed.

Rorrik was all smiles. “We should play together some time!”

Valen nodded despite the sting the proposition instilled. “Yeah...”

Rorrik was nearly done with his helping, while Valen had hardly pecked at his. He finally managed a bite of the hotcakes, and they were as fluffy and sweet as he could have dreamed. If he was more in the mood, he’d savor the quality more, but, alas...

The felid once again nudged forward conversation. “Uh... you said you like to cook, too, right? What kinda’ stuff?”

The demorin was growing fatigued from all the elaboration. “Um, all sorts of dishes, but, what about you? What are *you* into?”

“Me? I like exploring, dancing, messing around...” Rorrik trailed off. “Just goofing off, really.”

“I guess fishing, too, huh?” Valen wagered, but Rorrik’s head tilted in confusion.

“...Wah?”

Valen blushed at the apparent dud of a guess. “I just– I only assumed because you were out on the lake when...”

Recognition struck his new friend instantly. “Ooooh, right! Yeah! Fishing, of course!” He said it like it was a joke, and it was Valen’s turn to feel puzzled.

If he wasn’t fishing, what was he doing out there, then?

The felid tapped his fork against his now-cleared plate. “Well, I gotta get to a job. But... I’ll see you soon?”

“Job? You work?”

“Ehhh kind of, ha! It’s complicated.” The felid got to his feet, his dish in tow. “We should hang out soon, though!”

Valen nodded. He had enjoyed the teen’s company, even with all the painful recounting.

Rorrik left with a smirk and a wave. “I’ll see you later!”

Chapter 29

Rorrik

Gavin and Jate were waiting for him in the breakroom, mid conversation. They ceased their talking as Rorrik approached, but kept snickering.

The felidaren’s ears angled back and he squinted at his siblings. “What’s so funny?”

“Oh, nothing, little brother...” Jate assured, unassuring.

“How’s he doing? Did he eat anything?” Gavin wondered, betraying some context.

So they were talking about him and Valen. Rorrik scoffed; he should have figured Jate was being pesky and gossiping again.

"He ate, yeah. Even invited me to eat with him!"

"Ah, so your little scheme worked then..." Jate oozed, and Rorrik's features scrunched with indignation.

"You're an idiot." He retorted, and both of his brothers guffawed. Rorrik had to laugh, too, despite the chagrin (or maybe for it).

"Well, I'm glad you're getting along. He can use a friend, I'm sure," Gavin said, genuine.

Rorrik shrugged with a light blush at the sudden candidity. "Y-yeah..." He was glad, too.

Jate wrapped an arm around both of their shoulders. "Well, you guys ready to go snoop around the docks?"

Gavin nodded, but Rorrik shook his head. "Lemme gear up, then we'll go."

"Should've already been ready, but you *had* to take your sweet time..." Jate chided playfully, and Rorrik rolled his eyes.

"Shut up." He went to do as he said, shaking his head as his brothers sought him off with more giggling.

He prepared with haste. He fastened his armor, concealed his weapons, and stocked the rest of his equipment with honed adequacy. It was only minutes later he was ready to go, not that it would make a difference in his siblings' teasing.

"Let's move out, then," Gavin ordered upon Rorrik's return. "Time to get some answers."

"According to one of my guys, the pier was pretty busy a few nights ago. Most of it didn't sound relevant, but he *did* mention spotting more than a couple of Pyrothians heading into a condemned office building." Gavin explained enroute.

Condemned was right. The dirty and decrepit building slouched above them, beckoning with a stink of mold and iron. The joints of the place creaked in the lakeside gust, promising structural integrity with its fingers crossed.

Gavin took a peek at the papers nailed on the building's door and scoffed. "Condemned Year _____. Five years ago."

Jate waved it off with a mockingly pompous wave. "Oh, I'm sure the council is getting to it! You can't just rush these things!"

"Surprised the place hasn't just toppled over on its own." Rorrik muttered, his ears wincing with another groan of wood and metal.

"Sure that's what they're waiting for. Don't have to send out a crew to knock it down if the problem takes care of itself," Gavin said. "Let's hope it at least waits for us to take a look around first."

Rorrik's sense of self preservation was disrespected at the idea of stepping foot inside. The stench belching from the shattered windows was insult to injury.

"Heeey, look, across the street!" Jate pointed and Rorrik followed his finger. On an only slightly more put-together building, a sign read ____'s Electronics & Gadgets. Rorrik hadn't realized the snoop had a shop out here, but it wasn't surprising, considering he had them all over the city.

"I'd bet my tail ol' ____ caught something on one of his cameras," Jate wagered. "Should I go pay a visit?"

"He does owe Panther a big one," Rorrik pointed out. "Why don't Jate and I—"

"Jate can handle the buttering up on his own, Rorrik. You're with me." Gavin deflated his idea instantly.

'*Shit.*' Well, it was time to go get flattened into a furry slurry or asphyxiated on noxious fumes. Or both.

"Good luck, you two! No jumping, running, or horseplaying! Safety first!" Jate was way too happy to send them off as he backed across the street.

"Choke on a hairball," Rorrik hissed and Gavin snickered.

"Hey, at least we don't have to deal with _____. Pick your poison."

"Um, *you* picked for me," Rorrik grumbled.

Gavin's corresponding scoff was apologetic. "We'll be out sooner if there's two of us. Let's just pop in quick and see what we find."

The place was huge, but luckily for them, layers of disrupted dust and debris betrayed the path of the nights past. It was clear where there was foot traffic, at least to their trained eye.

They crept down the halls to lessen the toll of their presence on the unstable floors. More than just the dust clued them where to head next as the odor of old blood and death built with every step.

The trail delivered them into a large room, perhaps once a conference area for suits. The evidence of carnage was stark and splattered all around; seemed no one had bothered to pick up the mess.

Well, other than one key missing feature: bodies. The gore was strewn all about, but not the corpses it belonged to.

"Wellp, make sure you're wearing your gloves," Gavin said plainly before waltzing inside.

Rorrik hung back, balking, swallowing back disgust and queasiness. It *was* repulsive, aaand he was a bit out of his wheelhouse. The *Crime Scene Investigation* was more of Gavin's schtick.

His older brother luckily didn't give him grief for taking a moment. The informant was already snapping some photos and writing notes. He eventually knelt down, a swab kit in hand, and scraped at one of the several crusty puddles. "Definitely demorin blood."

Indeed, the color made that clear: it was far darker than most humanoid blood, nearly black.

Rorrik finally convinced his stomach to hang on to his breakfast and he gingerly stepped into the scene, his eyes scanning all around, unsure of where to focus.

"What are we looking for exactly?"

"A picture of what happened, really. Which, the Claws were kind enough to not clean up after themselves."

Rorrik gestured at a splatter. "Sooo you can glean something from this?"

His brother glanced over. "I can tell they were cut from a downward strike with a blade. The amount of blood loss tracks with a blow to a major artery, likely the carotid, seeing as it appears like an execution from the lack of struggle."

Rorrik's stomach lurched yet again as he was reminded of just what and *who* they were investigating. This is where Valen's family, and the demorin *himself* for all intents and purposes, *died*.

"These other splatters happened in combat. Judging by the boot scuffs and splash, this one was hit in the flank with speed. This one was disemboweled. This one was struck here and

fell over there.” Gavin was gesturing all around, but then his focus fell on one of the pools and even his brother appeared a tad put-off.

“....This one has little signs of struggle. Likely... struck in the back, judging by the bleeding pattern...”

Rorrik felt dizzy at the realization. So that was *Valen*’s blood puddle?

The tabby fought to pull his attention away from the black stain; it was a bit too grizzly to fathom. A metallic glinting on the floor over by a wall caught his eye instead.

He hopped up to take a closer look. It was... a spyglass?

He picked it up and manipulated it in his gloved palm. The instrument appeared pretty ancient, and was enchanted if the runes decorating it had anything to say. “Uhh, I found something?”

“Oh?”

“Yeah. Some kind of, like, old spyglass. There’s runes on it.”

Gavin was over to take a look for himself in a tip-toed flash. He offered a sample bag after a quick gander. “Definitely bring that back and we’ll dust it. Even if it’s a dud, maybe it can still tell us something.”

The tabby dropped the spyglass into the bag and zipped it. Hopefully it was something; the room was short in clues despite all the carnage.

Gavin cleared his throat. “...I’m not seeing a puddle or impression that would align with a child’s amount of blood.”

Rorrik straightened at that. “No sign of his brother, then?”

“Not that I’m seeing...”

They both stared all around the room, and a curious realization struck Rorrik.

“Wait a minute. The bodies are gone, but there’s like... no drag marks or smears or anything like that. It’s like they just... vanished!”

“...Right out into the lake, you think?” Gavin extrapolated.

The felid hurriedly nodded. “That would explain why Valen never saw a boat! They just... poofed them out into the water!”

"It's a solid theory. It would explain the sensation of falling from height, too." Gavin began rummaging through his kit and lifted out a handheld gadget. (describe it more) "Well, if they used magic, this'll give us some insight."

He offered it to Rorrik and he accepted the task without much apprehension. He'd used a rucanic spectrometer before, it wasn't exactly complicated. It was as simple as waving it about and honing in on readings. Now, what those readings *meant* was a bit beyond him, but...

"That'll be able to pick up trace amounts of disruption from the rucane. Most spell signature's would have faded by now, buuut if they really were teleported, then it will still give a signal. Teleportation is powerful magic."

Rorrik turned on the gadget and it immediately whined and whirled. His ears arched back at the ruckus as he waved the doohickey around, leading it in the direction it was most fussed over. He was getting a hot reading by all the imprints, but the execution one was especially boisterous.

"Definitely senses something here," Rorrik noted. He kept leading the gadget around, but as he walked up to Valen's... spot, the device crescendoed off the chart.

"Whoa—" Rorrik turned the dial's intensity down, but the device still whirred. "Holy shit—are you getting this?"

Gavin paused his sample collection to come take a gander. "That tracks. His parents' essence did that huge spell to heal him, right?"

"Right!" Rorrik powered down the gadget and handed it back to his brother. "Well, the whole room's basically hot. Looks like we're right."

Gavin slowly nodded.

"Well, what now?" Rorrik wondered. "We know what happened with Valen, sure. But if his brother wasn't hurt, then—"

His pocket began to buzz, as though on cue.

It was Jate. Rorrik answered the call. "Hello?"

Jate spared the greetings. "Yeaah, you guys are gonna wanna come over and see this!"

Gavin and Rorrik shared a look. It seemed the next piece of the puzzle lay in whatever Jate had found.

Chapter 30

Valen

The past few hours had been a paradox. The time passed painfully slow, and yet also was a blur.

He was cocooned within the duvet, his heart entangled within a web of once-sweet memories turned melancholy, when his end table began to buzz. He squirmed free of the blanket with a start, confused and tilted.

It wasn't his end table buzzing, afterall, rather the corresponder on top of it. Rorrik's name was flashing on the display, waiting for him to pick up.

Valen studied the phone with apprehension, unsure of how to even operate the thing. It had no buttons he could see, just... a picture. However, he did have a faint recollection of seeing folks touch the screen itself to navigate the controls.

He tentatively pressed the green of the two "buttons", and a light buzzing sensation confirmed beneath his fingertip. That seemed to do the trick, as the interface now read 'ongoing call'.

The demorin wondered if he even had the phone the right way up before putting the device to his head, the action striking as unnatural.

"...Hello?"

"Valen! Uh, hey! It's Rorrik. We really need to talk. Be ready in 15 minutes?" the audio was far crisper than any corresponder Valen had used prior.

"Uhhh—"

"I know, it's short notice. But, it's about.... uh, *you know who...*"

Valen at first didn't follow. Then, jarring realization slammed him with understanding. "You mean—"

"We'll be there soon. Sit tight!"

The call ended, leaving Valen to bob in the wake of shock. His adrenaline surging, he dropped the phone and tossed both the comforter and himself off of the bed. He floundered his way into a new change of clothes and readied himself with the coordination of a newborn fawn.

Both hope and despair took turns on a seesaw, rising and falling in tandem. What had they found? Was Karreo okay? Or was he...?

Time upheld its paradoxical profile as he awaited the knock, every second a lifetime. When it finally came he was throwing the door open instantly to hurry the felid inside.

But Rorrik stayed in the doorway, pointing to the hallway beyond. "Uh, follow me actually."

They hurried down the hall before arriving at what appeared to be a break room, as it had a table, kitchenette, and a television.

Sat at the table were Gavin, Mrs. Catty, and... Another Rorrik look-alike he did not recognize.

He didn't have the patience for pleasantries. "What happened?! Did you find him?!"

"You'd better sit down," Gavin advised, a lethal slash to Valen's hope.

Although he felt more like pacing the floor, he still obliged, Rorrik taking the spot next to him. Mrs. Catty was beholding Valen with apologetic eyes and it did little to help the sinking feeling in his belly.

Gavin, thankfully, got right to an explanation. "We tracked down where the attack happened."

Vomit threatened to inch up Valen's throat as nerves wreaked havoc on his innards. He waited, too gripped with dread to speak.

The other Rorrik doppelganger spoke now. "Turns out it was right across from a business that we know well. This guy is *obsessed* with surveillance and always has a bunch of private cameras set up, sooo we checked in to see what he caught that night."

He pressed a button on a remote, and a low quality video popped up on the TV screen. It was green tinted and monochromatic, indicative of night vision.

Valen's unease only intensified. What was he about to witness?

"The camera could only catch so much, being across the street. However, at 03:38..."

He trailed off as he fast forwarded through minutes of an empty, unremarkable street and closed building doors, until finally...

A figure emerged from inside the building: a sharp dressed demorin. Valen's world quaked; his father had made note of the Clawed Fist's spokesman sense of style, and this demorin fit the bill.

But that was not the most remarkable detail.

The demorin was not alone.

He was cradling something – someone. They were small, a child.

The pixels didn't betray much detail, but it was still aboundingly clear.

It was Karreo.

Valen had involuntarily stood up to stare closer at the screen. At first all he felt was despair, seeing his brother's corpse in the hands of the Clawed Fist, but then he spotted movement.

Karreo was wriggling in the man's arms, clearly distressed, but not endeavoring to break free.

Which meant Karreo was alive.

Karreo was alive!

Tears poured out of Valen's eyes, rendering the pixelated footage even harder to parse. His hand lifted to cup his mouth, futilely containing the shock and awe swelling within him.

Karreo was alive.

"Is that him?" Gavin's question arrived muddled and far away.

Valen couldn't speak. All he could do was gracelessly nod as a sob rocked his shoulders. *Karreo was alive.* Mrs. Catty's hand braced his back, gentle and sympathetic.

"He's alive then!" Rorrik pointed out with hesitant glee. "He's okay!"

"Well, I wouldn't say okay..." Gavin corrected.

Indeed. The Clawed Fist had him now.

But they wouldn't for long!

Valen turned to rush outside of the room, but Mrs. Catty grabbed him. "Whoa! Where are you going?!"

"We have to help him!" Valen cried. Who knows what the Clawed Fist had in store for him?!

"Okay, hang on, breathe," the mother spun him around so they were facing each other. "Look at me. Breathe."

Panic was screeching at him to move, yet he somehow abided. He tried to breathe like she instructed, but his lungs were stubborn and compressed. He managed a gasp as his face drowned in rivers of relief and desperation.

"Let's talk about it," the tortoiseshell said, gesturing back to the table.

Sitting back down was a bridge too far. "No! We need to go find him!"

"It's not that simple. These guys clearly mean business; picking a fight with them isn't going to be easy," Gavin contributed, contrastingly calm.

The level headedness was driving Valen mad. "I'll do it myself, then!" he barked, frenzied by his grief.

"No, kit, think clearly for a moment," Mrs. Catty attempted to reign him back in. "Rushing out there and getting yourself killed again isn't the answer. We know *nothing* about this group, only what their pamphlets and political posturing wants us to believe."

"It's very likely they operate under all sorts of names and syndicates, on top of that. We have some digging to do to figure out who we're even dealing with. It's a process," Gavin said.

"A process that takes a lot of manpower and work," Mrs. Catty added.

"Let me help, then!"

"Oh, we plan to. But, our first order of business is you keeping a low profile. We can't risk the Clawed Fist discovering you."

"But if the Clawed Fist knew where I was, wouldn't that lead them to us? Isn't that what we want?!"

"Maybe, orrr they could just hire a third party to take care of you," the other brother cut in.

"That, and we still don't know what kind of hornets nest we're kicking. We need reconnaissance before we do anything rash," Gavin said.

Valen didn't *want* to see the logic, but it was piling higher and higher, casting a shadow on his brash outlook. Even so, the sense of urgency swirled within him, like an animal pacing its cage. "What can I do, then? I can't just... wait around and do nothing!"

"Well, what are your skills?" Mrs. Catty inquired.

"He can do magic!" Rorrik interjected before Valen could reply.

The teen confirmed with a nod. "Mostly illusions, but..." the bully's quaking form flashed in his mind's eye. "...There's been some other spells, too."

"...How are your people skills?" Mrs. Catty wondered instead of drilling further on the magic.

It caught Valen a bit off balance. "Um, fine, I suppose? You mean like talking to people?"

"Like customer service."

Valen was even more confused now. "Well, I worked at my Dad's shop every now and then..."

"Perfect! How are you with cleaning, multitasking?"

He failed to see where she was going. "Fair, I guess?" His perplexion was blatant.

"Fantastic! We'll have you work the inn whenever needed, then. Rusty could definitely use a paw."

His confusion morphed into indignity. "What?! How is that going to help find Karreo?!"

"It will help *you* heal, which is what's needed the most out of you right now. We'll work on honing your abilities, too, not to worry."

It made sense, but worry gnawed at the bars of the cage. "But... but what if they... what if they kill him..."

"If the Clawed Fist wanted to hurt him, they would have done so during the attack. It seems whatever they have planned, they want him alive. You said the Clawed Fist was trying to recruit your family, yes?" Gavin said.

The implication was unsettling. Valen released some steam through a harried sigh and hugged his sides, shaking from adrenaline. He glanced at the still-frame on the television, at Karreo's distress and the cruel demorin kidnapping him. "I'm just... I'm just so worried about him."

"Aw, kit, I know. We're gonna find him," Mrs. Catty soothed.

"One step at a time," Gavin assured.

"We're pretty good at the whole recon gig," the other brother offered. "I'm Jate, by the way!" The tabby extended a hand and Valenshook it with a meager grin.

"Nice to meet you, Jate."

"Ha, yeah! We've technically met, but it wasn't exactly a normal introduction!" Jate guffawed and Valen tilted his head.

"When was that?"

"I'm the one who jumped in the lake to grab you. You're forgiven for not remembering, haha!"

"Oh...!" His brow furrowed with puzzlement. "I thought that was Rorrik...?"

Jate's laughter swelled again. "Oh, is that what he told you?"

Rorrik appeared miffed and swatted his brother with his tail. "I didn't!"

"But you didn't care to set the record straight, either," Jate chided through a snicker. "I see how it is, little brother."

The brothers exchanged light blows and Valen attempted to diffuse with a nervous chuckle. "Well, thank you for saving me. Both of you." He spared every one in the room a glance. "Thank you all, really. I'm in your debt."

Mrs. Catty clapped, cheerful. "Well, let's get that debt repaid with some labor, then!"

Valen's grin aged sheepish at her blunt remark. "Of course. When do I start?"

"Whenever you're ready. You've been through a lot, and we understand you need time."

The demorin shook his head. "I think... I'd rather have something to focus on sooner than later."

“Well, alright! I’ll let Rusty know to expect you in the kitchen at 7am tomorrow, then?”

Valen accepted with a nod. “It’s a plan.”

Chapter 31

Valen

He was a lot more conflicted about his new employment the next morning. Did he really want to do this? Could he do this?

It was hard fought peeling himself out of his shallow slumber; his eyelids were crusty from dried tears, his head was pounding, and his muscles were stiff and heavy from stored tension. The nights had not been kind; there was nothing else to stare at but the grief in the dark.

It all had him wanting to remain laying down; to wallow and hide under the sheets, but, indeed, that same gloom that had tortured him all night would be joining him in bed if he did. If he would get up and be busy, the distractions would at least dampen the drone of pain.

Plus, he couldn’t justify moping when Karreo was out there needing him.

He muttered curses as he dressed for the day, his tail fidgeting with restless energy. Karreo needed him, yes, but what was he doing about it? Why did helping have to look like working the inn?

The logic of it all answered the question, but it was hardly enough to quell the insistence frothing his blood.

Even so, he found himself standing in the kitchen right on schedule. Russel Speartooth was delighted to see him as he handed the demorin an apron to wear.

“Lad, am I glad to see you. You’d think I’d be swimming in help with all these kittens kicking about, but the place is in a state! Aye, the dishes need cleaning and the floors need a fresh round. But, first things first. Let’s get some fuel in your belly.”

Breakfast was oatmeal that put bland porridge everywhere to shame: the dish tasted of maple and cinnamon and the texture was thorough and pleasantly crunchy from a topping of pecans. It was rich and hearty and comforting.

Valen told the felidaren as much as he ate, mostly to make smalltalk, but the innkeeper was ticked with the praise.

“Hm, aren’t those some fancy compliments! You know your way around food, then?”

Valen gave a meager shrug, humble. “Well, I do like to cook. I have for most of my life.”

“No kidding! And here I was gonna have you doing naught but scrubbing dishes and floors! If you know your way around a stove, let’s see it, lad!”

He was tasked with preparing the soup of the day. Russel at first kept over his shoulder to walk him through the process, but then he began to watch more than instruct.

“Aye, you know what you’re doing. Just have it, lad. Do whatever you like with it, just don’t poison anybody.”

It was a lot of pressure, but a challenge Valen was up for. If he could lose himself in anything, it was cooking.

He was stirred from his concentration with a little tap on his shoulder. He jumped, nearly dropping the knife he was chopping with.

“Heh heh, careful!” Rorrik snickered at his surprise. The felidaren leaned against the counter, a smirk on his striped features. “Didn’t mean to startle you. How’s it going?”

“Aha, hey! Just... working on this soup.” He gestured broadly to his workstation.

“Rusty already has you cooking, huh? That’s great!”

Oh, so “Rusty” was Mr. Speartooth?

...Why didn’t he call his father ‘Dad’, let alone refer to him with a nickname?

“Hey, don’t be jabbering at him, Rorrik. He’s got work to do, and so do you,” Mr. Speartooth’s chiding came from across the kitchen.

“I’m just saying hi, Rusty,” Rorrik dismissed with a whimsical eyeroll.

“Isn’t Panther expecting you? I wouldn’t be farting around here if I were you.”

Panther?

Rorrik scoffed and shook his head, but he also quit leaning against the counter to stand straight. He scooted backwards towards the exit, smiling as he went. "Right, right. I'll let you get to your, um, soup, Valen."

Something about the snark of his grin and glint in his eyes kept Valen's attention on him. It was one of Valen's first good looks at the felidaren that wasn't punctuated by turmoil and heaviness. He was intrigued to find the fellow teenager was rather handsome, with a well shaped jaw and keen, emerald eyes.

Well, of course he'd noticed his eyes before. Those were well carved into his memory from their unusual meeting.

Even so, they were twinkling now in a... new light.

Valen noticed he was staring a bit too intently with a sudden dart of his gaze. His attention returned to the produce on the counter, his cheeks flushing with embarrassment.

"Heh, yeah! I'll be seeing you...!" The demorin farewelled, to which Rorrik gave another one of his penchant snickers.

He waved goodbye before disappearing out the door. "Good luck with Rusty. Bye, Val!"

The nickname contributed to Valen's bashful fretting. Even so, he smiled at the usage; Rorrik liked him enough to call him by a pet name?

He was staring at the carrot on the cutting board, rather scrambled, when he heard the water in the pot bubbling a bit too vigorously.

He turned the heat down with a grimace. 'Whoops.'

The demorin was almost done chopping vegetables when Rorrik walked back in. Wait, no, that wasn't right. This was another brother of his, it seemed, but Valen couldn't say he recognized who.

"Valen, right?" The tabby said, smiling. His eyes were tired and his hair and clothes were a bit mussed, but he was chipper enough. 'Seems to run in the family.'

"Uh, yeah! Nice to meet you...?"

"Quinn! I'm a brother of Rorrik's, as I'm sure you can tell. But, ah, I should probably go get this carburetor to stop leaking. I'll catch you later!" The brother left with a salute.

Carburetor, leaking? That explained the state of his shirt. 'So he must be some kind of mechanic then.'

So there was Rorrik, Gavin, um, was it Jake, Quinn...

"Hi!" Yet another unfamiliar voice spooked him. He looked over to see a smaller Rorrik-look-alike, albeit with a fluffier, warmer hued coat. He was a bit younger, perhaps 11 or so? "I'm Talis!"

"Oh! Hey there!" Valen waved to the felid, blinking away his shock. How many were there...? That was one, two, three, four, five...

"What are you doing here? Are you cooking?"

..Six?!

He turned to meet yet another brother. This one was beholding him with stare that was a tad judgemental.

Valen laughed nervously. "Uh, hi there! I'm Valen."

"I know that," the child, perhaps aged twelve or so, muttered.

"He's working here, remember, Calvin?" The fluffy one, Talis, said.

So this one was named Calvin? That made it Rorrik, Gavin, Jake— wait, it was Jate, wasn't it? 'Uh—'

"Boys, I said not to run ahead!"

Finally, a familiar voice!

Mrs. Catty entered the room, but she wasn't alone. Yet another felidaren was in her shadow, half-hiding behind her.

Seven! Seven kids!

"Been busy meeting the clan, huh?" Mrs. Catty correctly pegged

.Valen laughed nervously, doing his best to remain polite despite being overwhelmed.

"Well, here's another one for you. This here is Aylee. Say hi, sweetie."

The hiding felid peered from their mother's hip with weary yellow eyes. Valen noticed it wasn't another brother, but a sister! Her calico fur mirrored their mother instead of her many, many brother's tabby.

"Hi..." Aylee mumbled shyly. She looked to be about ten or eleven. 'Karreo's age...'

It wasn't all that reminded Valen of Karreo. The manner in which the little felidaren was hanging back was a page right out of his little brother's book.

"Only girl of the bunch! Only took six boys!" Mrs. Catty said with a chuckle.

"No kidding?" Valen gaped, reeling from all the introductions.

Russel Speartooth popped his head back into the kitchen.

"Well, only one more of the family to go! Unless I miscounted, hahaha!"

Wait, but if he'd met all six boys, Aylee, Mrs. Catty, Russel. who would that be?

"That's right. He'll be by soon I'm sure," Mrs. Catty agreed.

"Aye! Gotta check out the fresh meat."

The adults shared a laugh as Valen re-counted a couple times in his mind, and then on his fingers. The math wasn't adding up. "...Who is left?"

"That would be me." A newcomer indeed said, but with far less charm and smiles.

A largely built, black felidaren with piercing yellow eyes walked in, an intensity about him. Valen was immediately unnerved by the catfolk's intimidating presence; this was clearly a felid that meant business.

"Ah, there you are!" Mrs. Catty giggled. She approached to give the man... a kiss?!
"Morning, sweetie."

Wait! Did... did that mean that... No! Yes? But wasn't Russel—

The felidaren's yellow eyes were boring into him, influencing Valen into standing straighter. "U-Uh its nice to meet you, sir!"

"Hmph. Call me Panther. We'll be keeping a close eye on you." With little regard for ceremony or social script he turned tail. "Don't disappoint us."

"O-of course, Panther sir."

The catfolk merely grunted before taking his leave.

Valen was left stupefied. THAT was their father? He'd for sure thought it was Russel, considering personalities, but apparently not!

"Don't mind him. He's a bit intense, but a sweetie under all that gruff," Kyla eased, nonchalant.

Safe to say, that was not what Valen was expecting.

"Just keep your head low, mind what he says, and you'll get along fine," Russel contributed. The puma then tapped his watch, insistent. "Now, back to work with ye! That soup ain't gonna prepare itself!"

Valen placed his apron to hang on the desk chair, weary. Sore and entirely fatigued, he was restless for a shower, as he'd certainly earned his badge of grime from a hard day of work.

When he was clean and dressed he collapsed into bed with a groan. Mr. Speartooth had certainly kept him busy; his tasks had ranged from cooking to cleaning to inventory and everything in between. (+mention how soup was!)

He was drifting off when a knock came at his door.

"Housekeeping," was facetiously called out, Valen doubting the validity of the claim.

Indeed, when he peered through the hole, it was Rorrik.

The demorin opened the door and Rorrik immediately strolled in. Valen fought a yawn; while it was nice to see his friend, he was hoping to sleep sooner than later.

"You look beat! Rusty worked you hard, huh?" Rorrik remarked, Valen sluggish as he confirmed.

"Well, I'll be out of your hair in a second. I just wanted to ask you something."

"Oh, no, you're fine—" Valen started, but the words coagulated in his throat as Rorrik pulled a glinting object from his belt.

"Any chance this is yours?"

Valen couldn't believe his eyes. It was his spyglass!

"Oh my stars—" he gasped as the felidaren handed it over. "Where—how—"

"I found it at the, ah, scene," Rorrik elaborated. "We dusted it for prints, only to find a bunch of yours on it! So, it must belong to you, huh?"

"Y-yes!" The demorin gasped, awestruck. His eyes were misty as he studied the trinket in utter disbelief. He'd not had the curiosity for long, yes, but it was still a relic from the life that he'd been robbed of. "I... I can't believe it!"

"I saw it has runes, what's it do?"

"It's got like... a bestiary programmed into it," Valen tried to explain, distracted. "But, I just... I can't believe this." He finally tore his eyes off the spyglass and looked upon his new friend.

Overwhelming gratitude had him stepping up to embrace the felid in a hug. "T-thank you!"

"Whoa, ha, you're welcome!" Rorrik said, almost with a degree of nervousness. "It must mean a lot to you, huh?"

"More than you know..." Valen sighed, breaking the embrace to scrub away the threatening tears. "I just... thank you. Really."

The tabby rubbed the back of his neck and shrugged, his gaze on the floor. If Valen didn't know any better, he'd say Rorrik was acting bashful.

"Of course, man. Um..." The felidaren pointed to the door and half-chuckled. "I'll, uh, let you get some sleep, then! I'll... see you later?"

Valen nodded and waved goodbye, radiating with emotion. "I'll see you later."

Chapter 32

Life was settling into something of a rhythm as the days passed.

He worked the inn until he was too exhausted to sail the seas of his grief for too long at night. In between all the cooking and cleaning, Rorrik's presence was a common staple of his days; the two had become fast friends. The other Cattiaikins were a charismatic bunch, save for their father, who Valen had done his best to placate with respect and hard work.

Progress with researching the Clawed Fist was as slow as the family had warned, but luckily Mrs. Catty offered more than just inn work to settle his restless spirit. She had enrolled him in lessons of the rucane, which he was due to start sooner than later.

He was presently at the end of his shift, nearly done with the dishes, Rorrik standing next to him as he worked.

“So, you excited for tonight, birthday boy?” the demorin wondered as he placed the last of the dishes into the washing rack.

“Hell yeah! It’s gonna be awesome!” The freshly-turned-fifteen-year-old gushed. “Man, I wish you could come, though...”

“Parties aren’t exactly under cover,” Valen reminded, a tad regretful. “I really hope you have a great time, though!”

“We’ll have to have another party after this blows over,” Rorrik suggested. “It’ll be wild!”

Valen chuckled with a touch of nerves, intimidated by the prospect. “If you say so.”

“Thanks again for that cake earlier. It was sooo good,” the felid gushed.

“Of course! Happy birthday, again,” Valen replied with a smile. He had spent his time afterhours the night before making a cake for the felidaren, which he’d presented that morning.

“Sorry I don’t have any other gift,” the demorin had regretted.

The tabby had been ecstatic, however. “Don’t be! This looks amazing!”

It had been yellowcake slathered in fudge icing and drizzled with a white chocolate ganache. He had put a lot of care into it; seeing his friend’s excitement made it well worthwhile.

Rorrik studied his claws as Valen wiped the counters. “Well, I gotta get ready for the party. See you later?”

“Yeah, I’ll be seeing you,” Valen agreed. “Have fun!”

—

Valen was sat on a bench on the inn’s rooftop, a constant thumping of music and commotion vibrating beneath him. The ruckus was a bit too much from inside his room, and so he was waiting out the climax of the event from the relative peace of the roof.

The melancholy was seeping in, arriving like fog creeping over the landscape. His thoughts returned to where they always did. His dad's gentle words, his mother's laugh, Karreo's fettered manner. He remembered countless nights listening to his father's stories, his mother teaching him scales on the guitar, catching fireflies with his younger brother...

Such treasured memories now stained with hurt and longing. It all was so unfair. How had his life fallen apart so quick and so violently?

He'd lamented it time and time again, his father's wise advice answering every time, at first too quiet to hear, but growing clearer each round. "Sometimes, we're dealt a rotten draw. It's unfair, yes, but that's how the game goes. We can either lose ourselves in spite, or make due with our hand and move forward. Either way, life goes on."

His father had been talking about his injury and the upheaval it had on his life, but this was another beast entirely.

Valen had lost *everything*.

Yes, he'd been given a second chance by his parents, but appreciating it was hopeless in the wake of their demise. Although his mortal injury had been healed, it'd left another gaping wound in its place.

A gust rustled his hair, and he swore he could hear his father talking to him in that moment. "I know, son. I know. Let yourself feel the hurt, but don't hole yourself up there. Your life is just beginning."

Valen processed the console with a raw heart. When he closed his eyes, he could feel his father's arm drape over him and pull him close. A sob erupted at that, releasing pressurized anguish, contempt, and regret. He sheltered within his parent's comfort as his internal volcano belched and surged.

As the worst of it waned, his eyes slowly opened, the ghost of his father dispersing on the wind. He ached to feel him go, but his solace remained.

His parents were gone, but they were still by his side. It might not be physically, but their love persisted within him.

It didn't chase the hurt away, but it did make it more bearable to endure.

The stair door creaked open suddenly.

"Oh, there you are! What are you doing up here?" Rorrik's entrance had him scrambling to wipe his eyes and sit straight.

“Ah! You know, just getting some air! It’s... a bit loud down there.” Valen hurriedly explained. He faced the approaching felidaren, seeing that he was holding two cups and... a guitar case on his back? “What are *you* doing here?”

“Thought I’d bring a little bit of the party to you! Here, have some punch!” His words slurred in a way that suggested it was a bit more than just juice.

Valen took the cup and glanced down at the concoction with a hesitant chuckle. He’d had sips of his parents wine before, but not enough to feel much of anything.

Rorrik shrugged off the guitar case before plopping down with little of his usual dexterity next to Valen. “Heh heh. It’s good stuff!”

A tentative sip challenged that assertion. It was... definitely spiked. He forced himself to swallow and winced, Rorrik laughing out loud at the display.

“First time?”

“Uh, no, or, yes,” Valen stammered. If he got over the bitter flavor, he could taste the notes of strawberry, pineapple, and citrus, but it was an uphill battle.

Rorrik snickered at his contradicting answer. “So you haven’t?”

“Well, I’ve had wine with dinner...” Valen elaborated. “But not... punch.”

Rorrik elbowed him through more giggling. “First time for everything, huh?”

Valen took another ginger sip, and then a chug. If he drank it fast, it would be a lot less of a slog to get through it, right?

Rorrik cheered him on. “Ha, no way! I thought you weren’t even going to drink it!”

Valen wiped his mouth as his belly protested the recent addition. The demorin wasn’t exactly sure why he drank it, if he was honest. To be polite? To impress his friend?

His guts gurgled and finally pushed out a burp, relieving much of his stomach woes. Rorrik hooted and slapped him on the back.

“That’ll do, Vaaskiir!”

Valen scoffed and shook his head. “Yeah, yeah...”

“Well!” The tabby switched gears. “I believe *you* still owe me a jam session!” He leaned down to unzip the guitar bag, revealing it was not a singleton, but a dual case!

Valen processed the development, his mind fizzy, no doubt a product of the punch. He finally smiled gently. "I do, don't I?"

Rorrik unzipped the case with a hum before freeing one of the guitars and offering it to the fellow teenager. "It probably needs to be tuned."

It was an acoustic guitar of polished, chestnut wood, certainly a lovely specimen of an instrument. A quick strum confirmed it was indeed out of tune, but not insultingly so. Just some minor adjusting...

The guitar was unfamiliar in his lap, but like an old friend in the same stroke. It felt good to hold an instrument, even if it was not his treasured possession.

Valen plucked at the strings tentatively, inspiration slow to come to him. Rorrik took the second guitar into his lap and got to strumming much more actively, albeit out of tune.

The catfolk snickered as he began to adjust the tension in the strings. "Mmm yeah I thought so. It's been a bit since they've been played."

"Well, good thing we're playing now, then, huh?" Valen wagered, and Rorrik grunted.

"Yeah!" The tabby proceeded to fuss with the strings before dismissing via a lackadaisical hand wave. "Eeeeh close enough."

The felid started strumming a jovial sort of tune, playfully bumping shoulders with Valen as he did so. The demorin nodded and began his own song, finding it became easier as he connected with the strings.

They fell into a conversation with their instruments as they played under the moonlight, their performance rising above the clamor of the city beyond. Rorrik's style was upbeat but mischievous, with sudden staccatos and quick successions that mosied back into unsuspecting riffs. It certainly contrasted Valen's melodic loops and gentle strums, but it was all the better for it. The mashup was zesty and rich, with a crisp profile.

They were both getting into it, as they laughed and smiled and made silly faces. Even with some occasional botched notes and missteps, Rorrik clearly had a lot of natural talent (especially considering he was inebriated). Valen was certainly impressed; it was a rewarding experience playing with him.

It was minutes if not an hour later when Rorrik yawned, wobbling in his seat slightly. He sluggishly placed the guitar back in the case and gaudily stretched. "Hoo! Too much punch..."

The demorin proceeded to strum softly as he hesitantly chuckled. He himself felt a tad dizzy, but the night's breeze was eroding the sensation. "You good?"

"I'm goood..." Rorrik oozed, lounging back on the bench. He giggled to himself, making Valen giggle too.

"You ready to head back to the party?" Valen wondered, and Rorrik surprised him by shaking his head.

"Nah, I wanna listen to you a bit longer..." The felidaren yawned yet again and closed his eyes, Valen swearing he could hear the rumbling of a purr. "You sound... so nice..."

A blush heated Valen's cheeks at the candid praise; it seemed the punch was a tad heavy handed. Not that the demorin minded. "If you say so, birthday boy."

He strummed until Rorrik's purrs turned into little snores, and then he played some more. It was an idyllic picture of peace, a rare reprieve from the madness his life had become.

When Valen finally put the guitar back into the jointed case, Rorrik was still snoozing. The demorin took a moment to admire the city lights reflecting on his fur, and the strands of hair that fell into his face, betraying his combed-back updo. His heart pittered as he more thoroughly admired his features, and it suddenly felt too intimate to continue.

It drove him to look back out into the urban sprawl beyond, his cheeks hot. A sobering wash of melancholy swept in on the literal second wind.

Sienna's honey eyes and sweet giggling throbbed in his memory, a painful recollection. He'd never see her again, never realize where the road they had set down together would wind up. Her friendship, her longing, her very presence... it had all been ripped from him. They were in different worlds now; the Valen she knew didn't... even exist anymore.

He squeezed his eyes shut to ward off another volley of tears, but they still pounded at the door. His shoulders vibrated with a suppressed sob, but then Rorrik repositioned so he was cuddled into the demorin.

"S's okay..." the felid mumbled, clearly more asleep than awake. "S's okay..."

Embarrassment and surprise added to the emotional cocktail Valen was served. His friend's closeness was the battering ram needed to breach his suppression. He was helpless as the tears fell, in defiance of all his efforts.

Rorrik's chest rumbled with a purr as the demorin sniffled, the vibration resonating deep within Valen's core. It rippled across the rubbled landscape of his heart, tending to the debris with soft reckoning.

The storm moved through after long, leaving naught but the embarrassment of their closeness. They should probably be getting back downstairs, anyway.

Valen gently pulled himself from the felid and stood up, stirring the catfolk into waking, albeit barely.

"It's late, we should probably head down," Valen suggested quietly, his cheeks a flushed maroon from feeling bashful and the mourning.

"Okey." Rorrik got to his feet with the same coordination he'd practiced all night. Despite a degree of teetering, he was stable enough to stand. He reached for the guitars, but Valen grabbed the case instead.

"I got it, don't worry," he said. "Let's get you to bed."

The inn was far quieter when Valen made it to his room. Rorrik had earlier limped off to crash into his own bed, but not until Valen had told him one more "happy birthday".

"We'll see how happy he feels in the morning," Jate had joked.

Valen had laid down for sleep, but only a session of tossing and turning awaited him. It was nearing five AM when he finally resigned the effort.

He found himself walking up the stairs to the roof yet again. He reached the top, stepping outside into the moist and crisp air of night. The sky was dark with a rich purple, but a stunning display of pink and yellow were piercing the bottom of the horizon, the first inkling of the sun.

Dawn was approaching.

Valen draped across the railing, emotional as he beheld the tapestry of evolving color before him. The sun, framed between a skyline of buildings across the water, inched higher and higher, the sky intensifying in saturation as it climbed. As the light transformed the world, Valen couldn't help but notice symbolism.

It was remarkable how, despite the blackest of nights, the sun would always shine the brighter. The light and warmth of dawn would always come, a promise of a new day.

Valen heeded the sky with wonder, his expression warm and bright with light. Indeed, he was suffering through a terrible night of pain and grief and despair, but perhaps by the light of new purpose, friends, and surroundings, he would one day arrive at dawn.

Yes. He would find Karreo and forge a life worth his parents' sacrifice.

He just had to keep moving forward.

omg

—

Boo



Oh noes

Stuff will happen here